

RED FLAGS AND RISHTAS



A DESI ROMCOM



RADHIKA AGRAWAL

BLOOMSBURY

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*For Baba, whose parting gift to me was the confidence to finish this book
and the courage to chase my dreams*

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A Serial Dater

IF MY LIFE WAS a romcom, the guy sitting across from me would be *the* guy. Not the one I was currently on a date with – that would be far too obvious. I mean the handsome man sitting behind him, two empty tables away. He would watch me from a distance, an amused smile on his face. Right off the bat, he'd know I was on an awkward first date, and a force greater than him would propel him to step in and save the day. He would run to me and tell me my car was being towed away, and I'd follow him out into the parking lot, even though I took an Uber to the cafe. We would escape to the street and hail an autorickshaw, breathlessly smiling from ear to ear.

That's it. The perfect meet-cute.

But, of course, my life wasn't a romcom, and the man I was shamelessly fantasising about in front of my date was not even looking at me.

'Shall we order?' asked Manan, patiently waiting for me to direct my gaze back to the menu.

'Oh, right. Actually, I'm not that hungry. I'll just get a coffee,' I said, ignoring the faint rumble in my stomach.

'You sure? It's dead in the afternoon,' he said, sounding confused.

I felt bad for him. But those were the rules – coffee dates for guys I would ghost, lunch dates for second-date contenders, and dinner and drinks for when I was DTF. To survive dating apps for as long as I had, you had to have rules in place. Otherwise you'd be spending all your time playing nice to losers and crying over fuckbois who had no intention of calling you back.

Not that this guy was a loser per se. He seemed nice. We had been chatting for over a week, and he was everything I looked for in second-date contenders. Funny, charming, respectful and confident. I was so excited, I'd saved him my prime spot – lunch on a Saturday. But as I waited for my date to show up at the cafe today, I realised I'd been catfished.

There are two types of catfishing in my online dating handbook. The first is where you steal someone's identity or create a fictional one to seem

more desirable. In the second, instead of lying about who you are, you only lie about a few things. These lies could range from easily detectable physical traits like your weight or height to more personal details about your life like where you work and live or what you enjoy.

So while Manan seemed like a perfectly nice guy, he had lied to me. I figured it out when I saw him getting out of his car. He was five inches shorter than the man I'd matched with on Tinder. I could've bailed right then, but that was against the rules. Ghosting was fine – everyone did it. But standing someone up? That was a real dick move. And I was not ready to be branded an asshole, even in the slippery world of online dating.

So that's how I found myself sitting across from a type-two catfish, trying to pretend I wasn't completely put off by his struggle to hop onto the high chair at our table. It's not that I had a problem with him being short. I am five feet two, so I'd dated plenty of short guys. In fact, I found tall men slightly unnerving. But I hated that he'd lied about his height on the app – and not just by an inch or two but by a solid margin.

Tinder was full of men claiming to be six feet tall. And usually, it was easy to spot the liars. Some of them would have photos taken from an upward angle, while some made sure not to include any full-length shots at all. Sometimes, they accidentally added a group photo that put things into perspective. But Manan had left no such clues for me to pick up on. His profile, I realised, had been carefully curated to fool women into thinking he was a tall, confident and charming man, when in reality, he was deeply insecure.

'Can we get two cappuccinos, please?' he asked the waiter, a look of longing crossing his face as he returned the food menu.

'So tell me about your work,' he said to me after the waiter left our table.

'I told you in a text earlier. I work in the events team of a men's fashion and lifestyle website. There's not much else to tell. It's just regular work,' I said.

'Right.'

We indulged in five minutes of small talk before a weighty silence took over. The thing you should know about me is I'm not afraid of awkward silences. In fact, I quite enjoy them. You can tell a lot about a man from the way he deals with a lull in conversation. For example, if he's too eager to fill the gaps, he interprets silence as rejection. If he acknowledges it, he's

trying to salvage a situation he thinks isn't going in his favour. But the most telling reaction is what was happening to little Manan right now – excessive sweating.

When a man begins to sweat in the face of an uncomfortable silence, he's not thinking straight any more. He's panicking, and if I had read this guy right, he was about to ask me *the question* in three ... two ...

'So, um ...' he said, clearing his throat.

'Yeah?'

I smiled sweetly at him, counting down the last digit in my head.

'What are you looking for? On Tinder, I mean.'

Bam. The sweaty ones always caved. Okay, just to be clear, I didn't have a problem with *the question* being asked. I just didn't think it had any reason to exist so early on in the conversation. But I wasn't going to tell him that. I wasn't going to tell him the truth either. I had a perfectly rehearsed answer for the about-to-be-ghosted. Something that would speed up the process and soften the eventual blow.

'Oh, you know. Just going with the flow. I'm not really in a place where I can focus on other people. I mostly keep to myself, but it's nice to get out there and meet people once in a while,' I said, the words tumbling out of me mechanically.

Complete, utter bullshit. I went on a date every week, more often than not with an entirely new person. I was definitely out there. Just not for him.

'Right, okay,' he said when I didn't ask him about his stance on the matter.

From there on, it was pretty easy. He drank his piping hot coffee in five whole seconds and called for the bill soon after. I was out of the stuffy cafe and lounging in the air-conditioned backseat of a cab in less than fifteen minutes.

My room seemed smaller than its actual size, thanks to the large shopping bags that were scattered everywhere. They belonged to my best friend, Vrinda, who, in her nonchalant way, was flaunting the spoils of her latest retail escapade.

‘Come on, you know I’d get bored without you,’ Vrinda said, turning around to examine the folds of the metallic green Bronx and Banco dress in the mirror.

‘Stop fretting, you look fantastic. Like a goddess, even,’ I said, hoping the compliment would distract her from pursuing the matter any further.

‘Don’t change the subject, Ananya,’ she scolded, before letting herself crack a smile. ‘But, hehe, thank you!’

Vrinda’s long-term boyfriend was throwing a party tonight, and she wanted me to come. She had promised that it wouldn’t be like the last time or the time before that ... or the one before that. Of course, I had no reason to believe her. In the four years that V and Saurav had been together, I had come very close to physically assaulting people at every party he had thrown. Saurav was great, but I couldn’t for the life of me get along with any of the rich brats in his social circle. They had all grown up in South Delhi, attended private schools that took them to Europe for exchange programmes and had miraculously glided into their late twenties without a single worry tainting their charmed existence – and they made sure to rub it in my face every chance they got. Not only did we have absolutely nothing in common, but I also found them truly, truly insufferable. And sure, you could argue that Vrinda came from their part of the world, but she wasn’t like them. Not one bit.

‘I’m not changing the subject. I just can’t come this time,’ I said, rolling over on my stomach to reach for my phone.

I scrolled mindlessly through Instagram, pretending to be distracted. From the corner of my eye, I saw Vrinda peeling her eyes from the mirror to face me. She crossed her arms in front of her chest, waiting for me to look up. When I didn’t, she let out an exaggerated sigh and plopped down on the bed next to me.

‘But why? What can be more important than hanging out with your best friend in the whole wide world?’ she said, pouting.

‘I’m hanging out with her right now,’ I pointed out and scooted over so she could snuggle up in my blanket.

She peeped into my phone, letting herself get sucked into the empty, addictive world of social media. We aww-ed at a video of a puppy who was too scared to jump from a tiny step and eww-ed at a Bollywood lip-sync reel our school classmate had posted. This was my favourite part of the

week. V and I hung out all the time, sometimes at mine, less often at hers – almost always indoors.

This, inside the room I had decorated as a teenager, was where I felt our friendship thrived the most. We had practically grown up here, spending countless hours through school and college discussing fashion, pop stars and boys. It was under the posters of SRK and Coldplay that we had watched porn for the first time, lying on this very bed. My mirror had seen us attempt (and fail at) many make-up trends over the years. In tenth grade, we had hidden an abandoned kitten in my double-door wardrobe and sat in silent protest on my wooden floor when my mom told us we couldn't keep it. In this room, we had choreographed dance routines for our future weddings even when we were painfully single, and bitched about how our boyfriends sucked when we weren't.

This, right here, was perfect. I wasn't a fan of being placed in other settings. Especially if they had anything to do with pretentious parties.

'So what is it that's keeping you so busy tonight?' V asked.

Her tone was casual, a calculated attempt to broach the subject again.

'I ...' I said, racking my brain for an excuse that she would consider legitimate, 'um, I have a date.'

'Didn't you just go on a date this afternoon?' she asked, giving me the side-eye before her need to be filled in took over. 'How was that, by the way?'

'Ah, blah. I'm going to end up alone,' I said, forcing some dejection into my voice.

'Hey, come on,' she said, bumping her elbow with mine, 'you're never going to be alone. You have me.'

I smiled, turning on my side to look at her. Vrinda was beautiful. And I don't mean the regular kind of beautiful. Not only did she have the most chiselled, editorial face, but she was also athletic, tall and graceful, which, if I'm being honest, sometimes made me envious. I was her cute, clumsy, short best friend. Okay, not *that* short. FYI, I was above the average Indian woman's height. But next to her, I felt like a minion from *Despicable Me*.

'So you're breaking the one-date-a-week rule, huh?' she asked, referring to my imaginary date later tonight.

'I guess I am,' I said and sighed, before adding, 'I need some action to get me through the disaster that is my life.'

She smacked my face with Mr Corny, my stuffed pink unicorn.

‘You’re so dramatic.’

‘You live for the drama,’ I retorted, snatching my childhood friend from her.

‘Hey! I’ve got the perfect idea,’ she said, her eyes twinkling.

‘No, I’m not bringing him to the party,’ I said, rolling my eyes at her.

‘But why not? Come on, Annie. Don’t be such a buzzkill.’

I honestly didn’t like doing this. It wasn’t fun to see her disappointed, and it was definitely not enjoyable to lie to her. But some things just had to be done.

‘He’s just not a party kinda guy. He’s made a reservation at that new rooftop restaurant in Connaught Place.’

‘Who doesn’t like parties? He sounds awful. What’s his name anyway?’ she said, then added, ‘But ooooh, rooftop ... how romantic.’

Talking to Vrinda was often like dealing with two personalities all at once. Some people found it annoying, but I didn’t mind. It felt like I had two friends at the cost of one. I know that makes me sound kind of pathetic, but hey, I’m just being resourceful.

‘His name is, um ... Aakash,’ I said, coming up with the most generic name I could think of.

I was beginning to fear that she would ask to see his Tinder profile. But before she could interrogate me further, the door to my room swung open. My mom walked in, holding a tray with a bowl of fruits, a packet of chips and two glasses of lemonade.

‘Mom, I wanted a cola,’ I said, pointing to the lemonade.

She pulled my side table to the front of the bed and set the tray down on it.

‘Do you know how much sugar that thing has? You’ll get a tummy like your mummy,’ she said, slightly pleased with her rhyme.

Vrinda laughed, giving her all the encouragement she needed to go on.

‘Vrinda beta, teach her no. You’re always eating healthy and going to the gym and all. And this aloo can’t even get her own snacks from the kitchen,’ she clapped my arm on the word aloo.

Vrinda laughed some more before finally noticing the murderous look I was throwing her. ‘Aloo? She’s thinner than me, Aunt,’ she finally said.

‘Too thin, if you ask me,’ my mother mumbled, adjusting her dupatta.

‘Mom! What’s your problem?’ I asked, opening the packet of chips with a loud pop.

‘You are my problem,’ she said, then leaned forward to tuck a stray hair behind my ear.

‘I just don’t want people to judge my little aloo.’

‘Can you please stop calling me that?’ I demanded, smoothening my loose Steve Carell T-shirt over my stomach, as if to reassure myself that I hadn’t magically gained weight under the scrutiny of my mother’s gaze.

‘Who’s judging her?’ Vrinda asked.

‘You didn’t tell her?’ Mom asked, looking at me like I was supposed to know what she was talking about.

‘Um ... no? What’s there to tell?’

‘Don’t tell me you forgot,’ she said, as her hand immediately flew to cup her head. ‘The Chauhans are coming to see you tomorrow!’

I shot up from the bed like someone had lit a fire under my butt.

‘Wait, that’s *tomorrow*?’ I said at the same time as V’s voice went extremely shrill.

‘Someone’s coming to *see* you?’

I held up a hand to her, trying to telepathically communicate.

I’ll explain later. Don’t feed this fire right now.

Her eyes practically screamed at me.

Coming to see you? Like for marriage?

‘Mom, you know how I feel about this whole thing,’ I said. ‘I’m going to turn him down.’

She sighed, shaking her head as she said, ‘First meet him na. He’s a nice boy from such a nice family.’

‘You haven’t even met him!’ I said, throwing my hands up in the air.

‘Okay, okay. Don’t get mad. You don’t have to do anything, just sit through tomorrow. It’s too late to back out of it,’ she said, giving up.

When I didn’t respond, she bent over to peck my forehead. After a few moments of stubborn silence, she left Vrinda and me alone to discuss the mess.

‘Oh my God,’ she breathed.

‘I know,’ I whined.

‘But you hate arranged marriages.’

‘I know.’

‘But you don’t have to do it, right? You just have to meet this guy,’ she pondered.

I didn’t know why I had agreed to do this. As our school psychology teacher would put it, I had let my parents get a foot in the door. Now that I had complied once and given them an in, it would be easier to get me to agree to their bigger requests in the future. If I wasn’t careful, I’d find myself marrying a lalaji’s son in no time.

A week ago, when Mom and Dad had brought up the topic of shaadi at the dinner table, I’d thought nothing of it. They were discussing potential matches for my cousin Riya, who was twenty-nine and ‘looking’. And suddenly, they started talking up this one boy who worked in marketing, had a seven-figure salary and apparently looked like a movie star. I oooh-ed and aaah-ed at regular intervals, pretending to be interested in my cousin’s fiancé-to-be. Until it dawned on me that they weren’t talking about a match for Riya.

‘They’re so sneaky, man. They made my biodata without asking me. And you know the worst part?’

‘What?’ Vrinda asked, her face aghast.

‘They used that horrible photo of me from Garima’s Diwali party,’ I groaned.

She snickered before her face went deadpan again.

‘You know, they just worry about you because you haven’t had a real relationship in years. Ever since Mr You-Know-Who,’ she said, pulling me close.

We didn’t talk about my ex. That was another rule. It was a story as old as time. Hot musician meets gullible girl, leads her on and then breaks her heart, forever tainting the way she lived and loved.

I nestled my head in the crest of her shoulder and said, ‘I know.’

‘You just need to put yourself out there a bit more,’ she said, rubbing my arm gently. ‘You know, meet new people – and I don’t mean off the apps. Talk to real people,’ she said.

‘Where am I going to find these “real” people?’ I asked, pursing my lips.

‘I don’t know. Anywhere. At the supermarket, or the park or uh ... parties,’ she whispered the last part into my ear.

I tore away from her.

‘God, you’re relentless.’

‘Come on, just come. I’ll be your wingwoman,’ she said.

I sighed. She wasn’t going to let this go. When V wanted something, she made sure she got it. Especially with me.

‘Fine. But I’m not letting you set me up with any of Saurav’s annoying friends. I’ll bring my date.’

She squealed and hugged me again, satisfied with her victory. Meanwhile, my brain was busy making a list of things I needed to arrange in the next three hours.

1. A bomb-ass outfit.
2. A guy called Aakash.

The Failed Fuckboi

A WARM PUFF OF WIND went past me, tousling my shoulder-length hair. Instead of flying smoothly over my face like Deepika Padukone's introduction shot in *Om Shanti Om*, mine got stuck to my lip gloss. I turned around and slapped the stray strands away, blowing air from my mouth for assistance. I fished out my phone from the tiny black sling bag I was carrying. A text awaited me.

Almost there

9:06 p.m.

Ugh. My date's lack of punctuality was costing me my outfit. I already regretted wearing the peach bodycon dress, and I hadn't even had a bite to eat yet. The body-hugging outfit that had seemed flattering a few hours ago was now a recipe for sweat patches. Of course, I could've avoided waiting out here in the heat, but the thought of entering Saurav's house by myself was somehow less appealing than enduring this humid April weather. I wasn't ready to face the pack of wolves yet.

The party seemed like it was already in full swing, if the hum of music coming from inside the bungalow was any indication. The 11:00 p.m. noise curfew did not apply to this uber-rich neighbourhood, despite it being a residential area. The plots in Sainik Farms were huge and far apart – ideal for throwing ragers.

I was about to dodge the second call from Vrinda in fifteen minutes when a cab pulled up in front of me and Aakash stumbled out of the backseat.

'We're outside,' I spoke into the phone, disconnecting it immediately to greet my date.

'Hey, sorry I'm late,' he said, bending down to hug me.

Fuckbois, in my experience, were always huggers. I had never met one who had tried to shake my hand or take a seat without any physical contact.

This one, too, squeezed me tight, letting me believe for a microsecond that we'd spent countless days and nights deepening our bond instead of the five-sentence exchange we'd had on Tinder earlier this evening.

'Shall we?' I asked, linking my arm through his.

He smiled at me, his square mouth revealing a set of pearly white teeth. As we walked over to the house, I took a second to mentally congratulate myself. I'd done well. Not only was he devilishly handsome, but he was also super fit. I could feel the skin of my arm tingling where it curled around his huge bicep. His printed shirt had a slimming fit, eliminating the possibility of any hidden fat. And as if that wasn't enough, he was also intimidatingly tall. If I hadn't worn my nude heels, there's a solid possibility I could've been mistaken for his teenage sister.

'So whose party is this?' he asked, his tone casual.

'Saurav's. He's my best friend's boyfriend,' I said.

He nodded and waited for me to ring the doorbell as we reached the porch. Now that we were almost inside, I could hear the music loud and clear – an EDM track that would never find its way onto my playlist. Saurav's parties always had a distinct musical trajectory – the first hour was dedicated to jazz as people trickled in and had their first glass of wine, the second was flooded with EDM, the third and fourth were a mix of pop and hip hop before everyone finally gave in to the genre they enjoyed the most: Punjabi pop.

'I love this song,' he said as 'Rasputin' remixed by Majestic and Boney M began blasting from the speakers.

I sighed internally.

We were greeted by Vrinda, who squealed and planted a big kiss on my cheek before I had the chance to say hello.

'You made it!' she said to us both.

'Of course! You look like a vision, V,' I exclaimed, admiring the way her sequined cocktail dress hugged her curves. An elegant diamond necklace sat around her neck, making me conscious of my own lack of jewellery. I wondered if I should have borrowed some bling from my mom for tonight but quickly dismissed the thought. The desire to fit in was not worth texting her every hour with photographic proof of her treasured jewels' whereabouts.

V thanked me and led us both inside, unaware of the unease already churning in my belly. 'He's gorg, by the way,' she whispered in my ear.

'Can't disagree,' I said, squeezing her hand.

A part of the gang was crowded around the luxurious leather couches in the living room, talking over each other. Saurav and a few others were missing, presumably smoking out on the airy balcony.

'Annie, hey,' said Srishti, a girl I recognised from last year's soiree. She glided from across the centre table to hug me.

I hated when people I barely knew called me that. *I'm Ananya*, I wanted to tell her. *At least to you*. But I swallowed the annoyance and returned her smile, letting her hold my hand in the way that drunk people do.

'And who might this be?' she asked, eyeing the man I'd entered the party with.

We had a round of introductions for Aakash's sake, and I began to relax as the focus shifted to my date. A part of me felt guilty for parading him around like a trophy, but he looked like he was enjoying being the centre of attention. Besides, I fully planned on making it worth his while later.

The first hour was largely uneventful. I'd devised a strategy to get me through this night. *Do not engage*, I told myself every time someone said something that would rile me up, like 'Sweetie, you should totally join us for our annual trip to Maldives this year' or 'You must be keeping so busy. My manicurist does home visits, you know'. I'd made friends with the uniformed servers, who helped me stuff my face with fancy finger food to avoid conversation. So far, it was working. I was fed and buzzed enough to not care that I didn't like 95 per cent of the people at this party.

But then, I had the misfortune of interacting with a guy named Jay, whom Saurav introduced as his friend from 'Uni', even though I knew they'd both gone to Ram Lal Anand College. He was the Indian equivalent of a frat boy – loud, obnoxious and operating on zero-point-five brain cells.

'How's it hanging?' he said, nodding at me.

'Getting drunk,' I said and raised my glass.

He took that as an invitation to join me on the single-seater sofa, wiggling his ass to make space where there wasn't any, much like the aunties in the Delhi Metro.

'Wanna play a game?' he shouted in order to be heard over the music.

Anything to get you off my lap.

‘Um, what’s the game?’ I asked.

‘See that glass on the table?’ he asked, referring to the square glass table sandwiched between the couches.

‘Uh huh.’

‘We’ll try to dunk this bottle cap in it. Whoever does it first wins,’ he said.

‘All right, why not?’ I took the bottle cap from him and got up so fast that his right butt cheek crashed onto the sofa.

‘From there,’ he said, pointing to an imaginary line next to where he was seated. ‘And no leaning.’

I closed one eye, aimed for the mouth of the glass and tossed the flimsy cap in the general direction. Of course, being the terrible shot I am, it didn’t even land on the table. It sat lousily on the rug under the counter, mocking me.

Jay laughed, getting up to squeeze my shoulders from behind. I resisted the urge to shake off his hands and pull a face.

‘Don’t worry. Maybe on the next try,’ he said in a way that suggested there wouldn’t be another attempt.

And sure enough, he dunked the damn thing in one go, turning around and whooping endlessly, as if he was in a stadium full of fans. When I didn’t join in the celebrations, he walked over to me and handed me the bottle cap.

‘As my prize, I’d like to take you on a date, pretty lady,’ he said, smiling widely, presumably in a bid to charm me.

‘Um, I’m not really interested. Thanks, though,’ I said in what I hoped was a polite tone.

I could tell he hadn’t expected me to turn him down. I didn’t particularly enjoy being this blunt, but he should’ve read the room. If his ego hadn’t impaired his 6/6 vision, he’d have seen I was far from showing any interest in him.

‘Okay ... how about you give me your number,’ he began slowly, ‘and we can talk later?’

‘I ... er ...’ I mumbled, trying to think of an excuse, and when I couldn’t find one, I decided to use the liquid courage. ‘No, thanks.’

‘You know what? I’ll give you my digits, and you can hit me up if you change your mind,’ he said as he winked at me, unmoved by the rejection.

I was about to tell him I wasn't going to let him do that either when Aakash appeared at my side.

'Hey babe, want a drink?' he asked, touching the small of my back.

Jay turned red as realisation hit him. He held up his hands immediately. 'I'm so sorry, bro. Didn't know she was your girl,' he said, beginning to retreat.

That pissed me off more than anything that had previously come out of his mouth. *Do not engage*, I reminded myself. But it was too late.

'Oh, so you'd stop hitting on me if I'm with someone, but not because I'm simply not interested?'

I had to practically shout the last bit because he had sprinted for the balcony.

My date shifted his weight awkwardly, clearly not thrilled to have rescued me. My little outburst attracted the attention of a few of the others in the living room, and Vrinda and her boyfriend rushed to my side.

'What's wrong?' she asked, touching my arm.

'Nothing, don't worry,' I said, deciding this wasn't important enough for her to fret over.

I did, however, throw a dirty look in Saurav's direction, who should've known better than to let one of his weird friends hit on me. He had tried to set me up twice before, once with and once without my consent, and had failed both times on account of the total lack of compatibility between both parties. It's not like he didn't know me. I had been third-wheeling him and V for years now, after all. But when it came to finding me guys, he always went for who he liked, not who he thought I would like. I think he just wanted to make sure he had a partner in crime for our future double dates.

'Aakash, what happened?' Vrinda asked, directing her attention to my date, who was looking away and taking imaginary sips from his empty whisky glass.

When he didn't respond, she tried again. 'Aakash?'

I elbowed him in the ribs, and his head shot back to the four of us. 'Oh right, me.'

Okay, so maybe I'd lied. His name wasn't really Aakash. But I had managed to convince him to pretend that it was, and that had to count for something, right? He'd been weirdly unbothered by it, as if this was a regular request by girls he met off dating apps. But I'd realised over the

course of the night that that was his general demeanour. He wasn't super inquisitive, avoided confrontation and was as easy-going as they came. Which worked perfectly well for me.

Vrinda took my hand and led me away as Karan (aka Aakash) and Saurav escaped to the balcony for another smoke. We walked hand in hand down the hallway to the master bedroom and shut the door behind us. I dove onto the bed, bouncing a few times over. V joined me, giggling as her dress flew up in her face.

This was another one of our rituals – the mid-party catch-up session. I think it was her way to check in on me and make sure I was having a decent time, but I liked to look at it as a brief hiatus from the pretence outside. During this period, we could gossip, kick off our heels, crack PJs and adjust the wedgies under our dresses.

'I'm sorry if Jay bugged you,' she said, handing me the bottle of tequila she had picked up on her way.

I took a big swig, feeling the liquid burn my insides all the way down to my stomach. 'It's too late to apologiiiise,' I half-sang, using the bottle as my mic.

She giggled again, saying, 'Oh, I love it when you get tipsy.'

We took turns drinking straight from the bottle, talking about what everyone was wearing, who they'd shown up with and what they were doing in life.

'Did you know Srishti is engaged?' V asked, taking two big sips in a row.

'Is she? To whom?' I asked, trying to remember if I'd seen a ring on her finger. I'm sure she would've waved it in my face if she had it on.

'That investment banker dude,' she said, absently running her fingers over the expensive linen on the bed.

'What? Didn't they meet like three months ago?' I asked, taking the bottle from her.

'Yeaah. Time is a construct, apparently,' she said, snatching the tequila mid-sip from me.

'Hey! I was drink—'

'It's just that ... why is it that Srishti's five-second boyfriend can propose to her but ...' she said, her voice fading away as she buried her mouth in the bottle.

Uh-oh. V was now entering what we Delhiites liked to call the ‘Bad Trip’ or ‘BT zone’. It was imperative I saved her, or she’d spend the rest of her night sulking.

‘Hey,’ I said as I scooted closer to her, ‘he’s gonna propose.’

‘You think?’

She turned to face me, her big brown eyes wide and unblinking.

‘Of course,’ I reassured her. ‘He’d be crazy not to.’

She let me pull her back from the edge, and we resumed drinking over happier topics. And when the alcohol started hitting our sweet spots, we got up from the king-sized bed and proceeded to traverse the hallway back to the living room, into the world of the wine drinkers and foot tappers. The thing was, she fit into both these rooms – I didn’t.

The party buzzed with laughter, clinking glasses and the lively chatter of people prancing around in their glamorous designer outfits. As I made my way back into the room, I couldn’t shake the feeling of being an outsider. The people here spoke a different language, a subtle code of references and connections that felt distant and exclusive. So I parked myself in a corner and decided to focus on the tequila.

At some point, Karan found his way back to me and asked if I wanted to head to his place. We said our goodbyes, stumbled out of the house, got into a cab, made out for however long it took to get to his place and then somehow made it to his apartment.

He didn’t bother switching on the lights when we entered and led me directly into his room. Karan didn’t give me any time to peep at the little mementos or the framed photos on his wall. And the first thought I had when his lips met mine was that I had to pee. All that tequila was on its way out.

I kissed him back for a few seconds, crossing my legs to buy my bladder some time. When I couldn’t hold it in any longer, I gently pushed him away.

‘Where’s the loo?’ I asked.

He pointed to a door outside his room and said, ‘Don’t be loud. My brother’s asleep in the other room.’

The washroom was well equipped, which was always a good sign. I had a theory – boys who didn’t keep toilet paper in their loos couldn’t make girls orgasm. If they couldn’t understand our safety and hygiene, how would they comprehend our pleasure?

I congratulated myself on my choice for the second time that night as I proceeded to do my business. I took some of the toilet paper and used it to wipe my underarms. I wasn't carrying any make-up in my bag except for my lip balm, which I carefully reapplied. And after taking a good, long look at myself in the full-sized mirror, I flushed the toilet and made my way back to the hottie in the next room ...who was fast asleep on his bed.

I poked his shoulder lightly, and he grunted unattractively, turning onto his side. He had taken his shirt off, and his abs mocked me from a distance.

Got any more toilet theories, huh, Annie? They seemed to say.

Ugh.

Because there wasn't a couch or a chair in the room, I sat down on the other end of the bed and took out my phone. I had officially entered the BT zone. This night had been an absolute waste of my time, and I was ready for it to be over.

If this was a romcom, I would sneak out of Karan's house, assuming I'd never see him again, only to bump into him a few days later at the supermarket, where he would reveal how hurt he had been by my flippant behaviour. I would then take him out for dinner to make it up to him, and we'd pick up right where we had left off.

But this wasn't a romcom, and I passed out on his bed, waiting for my cab driver to arrive.

A Messy Affair

A LOUD NOISE WOKE ME, and I almost fell off the bed. Karan's bed. When I turned my head, I found him staring at me in his morning daze, as if he was trying to figure out who I was and how I'd gotten there.

'Wake up, you fool.' A man's voice came from outside the room, followed by a few thumps on the door.

Karan clutched his head and rubbed his eyes.

'What happened last night?' he asked me, groaning.

'Um, you passed out,' I said, getting on all fours to retrieve my heels from under his bed. 'And I guess I did too.'

He groaned again, and I heard him fall backwards onto his pillow.

The thumping on the door continued. 'You're going to make us late!'

Okay, so this was going to be awkward. It looked like this guy's brother would witness my walk of shame without knowing that there wasn't much to be ashamed about.

'What time is it?' Karan asked.

I checked my phone. 10:00 a.m. And five missed calls from home. *Shit.*

Mom would've wanted me at home and freshly bathed by now. I did a mental calculation of my ETA – it would take me at least fifty minutes from the South Delhi hub of Hauz Khas, where Karan's apartment was, to the foreign lands of Noida, where I lived.

The Delhi NCR region included various districts like Faridabad, Gurgaon, Noida and Sonapat, but somehow, the least liked area was the place I called home. In school, kids often teased me by saying only gundas lived on the other side of the Yamuna, Jamuna paar.

My phone rang again, reminding me that I needed to get out of here right now. ASAP. Yesterday.

As I was popping up from the floor, heels in hand, the door to Karan's room was thrown open.

'Karan, wake the hell—'

The man in front of us stopped mid-yell when his eyes found me. He took one look at me in my creased dress and frizzy hair and whipped his head in his brother's direction.

‘Seriously, man?’ he demanded, pointing a rude finger at me.

I yanked my bag off the bed and threw it around my shoulders, eagerly waiting for my cue to leave. Karan, however, seemed to be in no such hurry. He ignored his brother (and me) and stretched his gorgeous body lazily.

His brother picked up something tiny and black from the wooden cabinet next to the door and threw it at him.

‘Hey!’ he shouted, ‘Don’t touch my action figures.’

The tiny black thing, I realised, was a miniature Batman.

‘When the hell are you going to grow up?’ his brother asked, his annoyance growing.

He couldn’t have been that much older, but it looked like he had assumed the role of a parent. There was definitely some resemblance between the two brothers, especially in their general build and height, but I was in too much of a hurry to stay and observe. Karan, I realised, wasn’t going to make this easier for me. I’d have to take the emergency exit.

I kept my eyes on the floor as I made my way towards the door, and the stranger who was blocking it.

‘Ananya, you can stay for breakfast if you like,’ Karan said just as I was about to slip outside.

I saw the look his brother threw at him. Homicidal.

Shuffling my feet to face him, I waved him off, saying, ‘Nah, I’ve got a thing.’

By a ‘thing’, I meant an arranged marriage meeting.

He walked over to me, pulling a light green T-shirt over his head. I caught myself yearning to say a proper goodbye to his abs, which had now disappeared under the fabric. Not that I’d ever gotten to say hello.

What a shame.

‘All right, I’ll walk you out,’ he said, touching my shoulder.

I sighed internally. *Yes, please.*

Except Karan’s brother didn’t move from the doorway. I was suddenly very aware of how tiny I must’ve looked, sandwiched between two freakishly tall men. Instead of throwing another insult at Karan, his brother

directed his attention to me. I found myself squirming under his frowning gaze.

‘What’d you say your name was again?’ he asked, furrowing his brows together.

Now that I was looking at him up closely, I could see that his features were softer than Karan’s. His nose wasn’t as long and his jawline was less in-your-face. His eyes were the lightest shade of brown, sheltered under thick, dark eyebrows.

‘Ananya,’ I said, wondering why on Earth he had developed an interest in me at this inopportune moment.

As soon as I said that, he dug his hand into his denims and started looking for something on his phone.

‘What the fuck are you doing, Aadar? Move,’ Karan said, and I was grateful for the newfound urgency in his voice.

But Aadar didn’t seem to have heard him. His eyes went wide as he finished studying something on his screen.

‘Dude, quit being a creep.’ Karan went past me and smacked his brother on his chest.

Instead of hitting him back, Aadar held up his phone to Karan, whose expression changed when he saw whatever was on there. A few seconds later, he burst out laughing.

‘What the hell is happening?’ I demanded from the two men standing in front of me – one bent over laughing and the other looking like someone had punched him in the balls.

When neither of them responded to me, I snatched the phone from Karan. There, smiling behind a rangoli, was my face. It was the photo from Garima’s Diwali party.

‘Oh my God,’ I said, feeling the blood rush to my face.

No way. No fucking way.

I tried to remember what my parents had told me about the guy I’d be meeting today. Marketing guy. Seven-figure salary. Looked like a movie star. None of these things were great identifiers. Apart from the movie star bit ... which I was on the fence about. Aadar was a good-looking guy, but he was not his brother. I mean, he could’ve been a movie star, although probably not in Bollywood.

Just how is this relevant, Annie? I gave myself a mental kick. *Focus.*

Wait, Mom had used the family surname at some point.

And then, an image from last night flooded my brain. The nameplate outside their apartment – Chauhans.

I had never understood why food was so important in arranged marriage setups. I'd always seen it in movies – heaps and heaps of savoury snacks, pakwans and mouth-watering desserts were laid out in front of the other party. And yet, no one ever ate anything. It felt too strange to enjoy dhoklas with smiling strangers who were no doubt judging everything about you and your entire home with every bite.

But today, as I found myself in the single most awkward situation of my entire life, I understood.

'Please try the ladoos, Mrs Chauhan. We got them specially from Sadar Bazaar,' my mom said, breaking the silence with the aid of yet another food item.

Mrs Chauhan, who was wearing a blue and gold silk sari with intricate zari work, reluctantly accepted the dessert plate that was handed to her. My mom, too, was dressed in a sari, even though she hated wearing them. Even at weddings, she almost always wore an anarkali suit. But today was a special occasion, she'd explained. Her daughter was now a woman.

'You said that when I got my period, like, twelve years ago,' I'd argued.

She had shushed me, pinched my chin as an expression of her maternal love and asked me to put on the light pink angrakha suit she had picked out for the day. I'd happily obliged, humming as I took the pain to straighten my wavy hair. Mom had been suspicious about my chirpiness, but she didn't say anything.

In a way, I'd realised on my way back from Karan's place, this had worked out really well for me. Aadar, my to-be suitor, had practically thrown me out of the house when I had joined Karan's laughter riot. There was no way he would show up to propose a rishta the same afternoon.

And yet, here he was, sitting in front of me on my coffee-brown leather couch. Dressed in a dark-grey blazer over a white T-shirt and black trousers, he looked nothing like the dude from this morning. His dad sat on his right,

wearing an off-white kurta almost identical to the one my father was wearing.

To my horror, Karan had also shown up. He was the most relaxed person in the room, and I saw him stifling a laugh on more than one uncomfortable occasion. He clearly harboured no leftover guilt about costing his brother a match. I didn't blame him. I envied him. What I wouldn't have given to be in his position instead of sitting here in clothes that itched me and jewellery that didn't belong to me.

'So tell us something about your work, Aadar?' My dad took the reins in his hands after my mom nudged him to break the silence.

The tension in the living room eased a little as Aadar began talking about his role as a marketing manager at a popular liquor brand. I was only half-listening, busy as I was trying to think of how to get out of this situation quickly.

'Does that mean you can get us free alcohol?' Dad laughed at his own dad joke, and the others joined in.

Feeling some of the intensity drain from my shoulders, I got up from the sofa to place my glass of water on the table. Aadar copied my movement, and our eyes locked as we hung there for a moment, holding on to our glasses. The room went silent. I had no doubt that everyone, or at least our parents, was holding their breath, mistaking this little moment for the first sign of attraction.

'Beta, why don't you and Aadar talk in private? Get to know each other a little?' his mom asked me, placing a hand on my shoulder as I resumed my place next to her.

The adults, minus Karan, nodded in unison. He was the only person less than pleased with this idea. His entertainment was leaving, and he'd have to endure the rest of this afternoon by himself. I led Aadar out of our three-bedroom apartment and into the little garden my mother so dearly loved.

The sun was shining brightly above our heads, and the lack of a breeze made the afternoon particularly stuffy. I hopped up on the wooden slab that separated our garden from our neighbour's. Aadar came to stand in front of me, his hands stuffed firmly in his pockets.

'What the hell are you doing here?' I demanded, getting right to it.

A look of confusion crossed his face as he asked, 'What do you mean?'

‘I mean,’ I said, pausing to inhale dramatically, ‘why didn’t you cancel the damn thing?’

He let out a dry, humourless laugh. ‘Why didn’t you?’

I stared at him, irritated by his ignorance of the unfair power dynamics at play in arranged marriages. If I could have bowed out of this meeting, I would’ve opted to do it long before the events of this morning. But if he wasn’t going to acknowledge it, I was certainly in no mood to let him feel like he had the upper hand in this situation.

‘I’m sorry, my bad. I thought you’d have the balls to do it,’ I said innocently.

‘And come across as the douchebag who cancels two hours prior? No thanks,’ he shot back.

‘Wow,’ I mouthed, shaking my head incredulously.

He opened his mouth, ready with a retort, but then closed it without delivering it. I crossed my legs on the high platform, aware that my mother would throw a fit if she saw me sitting like that in this traditional outfit.

I watched Aadar walk the width of my tiny garden, made tinier by his pacing. Little pearls of sweat were beginning to form on his forehead. I noticed for the first time that he had thick, curly hair, unlike Karan’s straight and smooth locks. He kept his hair cropped fairly short, refusing to let his curls add the much-needed boyish charm to his intense personality. I wanted to reach out and tug on a strand, just to see how long it would be when uncurled.

‘So how are we doing this? Are you rejecting me or will I have the pleasure?’ I asked, clearing my throat.

‘That’s a no-brainer. I’m definitely turning you down,’ he said, his tone harsh.

‘Um, do you have some kind of a problem with me?’ I asked, vexed by his rudeness.

I didn’t want to be here either, but I wasn’t acting like a grade-A asshole, was I? What was the big deal anyway? The worst was over. If we could just get through this afternoon, we could go our separate ways without ever having to see each other again.

‘My problem? How about the fact that you slept with my brother? Like last night!’ he threw his hands up in the air.

‘So you have an issue with every girl your little bro has been with?’ I asked, raising my eyebrows.

‘I’ve never had the pleasure of meeting one of them. With my entire family. As a prospect for my own marriage,’ he said through gritted teeth.

I shrugged, as if to say *fair point*, then said, ‘I didn’t, though.’

‘Didn’t what?’ he asked.

‘Have sex with your brother.’

He stepped closer to me, his expression a mixture of curiosity and exasperation.

‘You’re telling me you spent the entire night in his room and didn’t even try to sleep with him?’

‘Oh, believe me, I tried.’

That seemed to tick him off again, and he scoffed. ‘What the hell is wrong with this generation?’

The judgement in his tone angered me, and I wondered if his disapproval of one-night stands was reserved only for women or if he frequently lectured his brother as well.

As if on cue, Karan appeared from inside the house. He was whistling a tune I couldn’t quite place.

‘How’s it going, guys?’ he asked, raising his eyebrows and smiling like a maniac.

‘Oh, good. Karan, will you please tell your self-absorbed brother that nothing happened between us last night?’ I asked, absentmindedly plucking a leaf from the creeper on the wall behind me.

He bent down to pick up a small stone and threw it high in the air above him.

‘Well, I wouldn’t say *nothing* happened,’ he said, tilting his head to the side and dropping his voice to a whisper.

Aadar whacked his brother on the arm, saying, ‘Dude, I swear I’ve had it with you.’ Karan laughed, seemingly satisfied with the reaction he’d gotten out of his older brother.

I couldn’t decipher what kind of relationship the two men shared. Were they close, despite the silly bickering and trash-talking? They had to be, I concluded, if they lived in a flat together and also showed up for each other’s life events, even if it was out of a desire to witness the other in the face of disaster.

‘By the way, they’re asking if you want anything to eat,’ he said, directing the question to Aadar.

‘I’ve had enough. It’s time to leave,’ he said, waving his hand at his brother to join him inside.

Instead of heading back indoors with him, Karan took a step towards me and stretched out his arms, offering to help me down. I placed my hands on his shoulders, and he lifted me off the platform and deposited me safely on the ground. When we turned around, Aadar had already left the garden without so much as a glance in my direction.

I caught a glimpse of him, frowning and shaking his head as he entered my house for the last time.

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The Calm Before the Storm

UNPOPULAR OPINION: MONDAY IS the best day of the week. I know, I know. Most people prefer the rear end of the week, but not me. Weekends are unpredictable. With no boss, deadlines or eight-hour shifts defining them, there are too many ways in which those two days can go. I could meet a guy for dinner on Friday, fall in love over main course, seal the deal by dessert and take a spontaneous trip to Bali for the rest of the weekend. Or I could binge-watch four seasons of *Outlander*, only to decide that the fifth is not worth my time. On Fridays, I was always overcome with a sense of uncertainty – would I end up conquering the world or avoiding the shower for the next two days?

Mondays, on the other hand, were solid. I could count on them to be boring, formulaic and tremendously obvious. In fact, if you asked me now, at 7:00 a.m., how my day would go, I'd be able to tell you everything, right down to the minutest details. I would snooze my alarm clock until 7:30 a.m., at which point my mother would barge into my room and glare at me. I would quickly shower, get dressed, grab my breakfast to go because my dad was waiting by the door and follow him to his car as he grumbled about how I'd gotten him late again. He'd drop me off at work by 8:55 a.m., and I would run up the two-storeyed building to punch in before the clock struck nine.

I would then pretend to work on the PowerPoint presentation I'd already finished on Friday for the next eight hours. I wouldn't leave my cubicle except to get coffee and go to the washroom, about five times each. At 4:55 p.m., I would book a cab to V's place, and by the time it was 5:00 p.m., I'd be punching out. The perfect, reliable Monday.

Unfortunately, that's not quite how it went this week. My boss, Pooja, was waiting for me by my cubicle when I reached the office. She was wearing a white shirt with dramatic puffed sleeves and a grey pencil skirt. She was tapping her white Gucci sandals on the wooden floor, which was never a good sign.

Even though she was well in her forties, Pooja Ghai didn't look a year over thirty. A lot of it had to do with what she wore and how she carried herself. She took pride in being a power dresser. To be fair, pretty much everyone in this office believed in the power of fashion – it kind of came with the territory of working in a men's fashion and lifestyle website like TheManJournal. And while I admired everyone who made the effort of colour-coding their outfits and blow-drying their hair so early in the morning, I simply couldn't join the gang. That being said, I couldn't show up in jeans and a T-shirt either – I had no interest in being the office outcast. And so I chose an option that was both convenient, comfortable and cute enough to be considered mildly stylish – casual dresses with sneakers. The fact that I looked younger than my twenty-seven years helped, and on most days, I was left to mind my own business, away from the office gossip and confrontations.

As I'd said before, today was not the usual Monday.

'I'm going to need that presentation before lunch, Ananya,' Pooja said, greeting me without a smile, tapping her crystal watch.

'Oh, how come? The meeting is tomorrow, right?' I asked, throwing my handbag on my chair.

I was referring to the weekly review meeting in which all the department heads got together to eat expensive snacks and blame each other for not meeting their individual targets. Pooja, who headed the events department, considered those two hours a complete waste of her time. Unlike the editorial, sales or social media teams, our team didn't always have weekly updates. Events, whether editorial or branded, took place months apart, and the build-up to each one was slow.

Pooja leaned on the cardboard wall as I entered my tiny six-by-six-foot workspace, her chest pressed against the edge.

'They're moving up the Tuesday meeting to the second half. Somebody from International is here,' she said, looking me dead in the eye.

'Who?' I asked.

'Some guy called David Miller. Apparently, he's Michael's right hand,' she said.

Uh-oh. We both knew what that meant. Every time Michael Evans, the global editorial director of TMJ, sent someone for a visit, our asses were lit on fire. And even though I'd already finished the PPT in question, it would

crumble under the kind of scrutiny this meeting would carry. I'd have to redo it, and I had less than four hours to get it done.

'Oh, and make sure you include a slide or two about the new branded event ideas I asked you to work on,' she said, pointing to my laptop as I plugged it in. 'I want them to know we're not just rehashing annual editorial events, but also introducing a line-up of big money days.'

I'm so screwed.

'I would ask Ryan to help you, but he's taken a sick leave,' she said, referring to the only other person in the events team.

I nodded at her, trying to swallow the wave of panic rising in my throat before it made itself known to the outside world.

'No problem.'

She left my side and made her way back to her office, strutting confidently in her heeled sandals. I knew I should've said something to hint that I didn't have any new event ideas – nothing that the international team would approve, anyway. But I wasn't ready to see what telling the truth would cost me. Appraisals were two short months away, and I'd been here too long and had worked too hard to let something stupid like this ruin my chances at a promotion.

I had to get this done. There was no other way. Trying to think of a completely new idea was too overwhelming, so I started with the easy bits. I went through each of the fifteen slides, fact-checking, proofreading, adding stronger visuals and specific stats wherever necessary. It took me around two hours to upgrade the presentation from a C+ to an A-. The improvement was apparent, but I knew it wouldn't count for much without a unique event idea.

I opened my desk drawer, shuffling the pile of unstacked papers to look for the approved events line-up for the year. It didn't reveal anything new – just the same five editorial events TMJ had added to its calendar over the last three years. I knew them by heart, of course. The Entertainment Gala, Fashion Forward, Sports Hour, Biz Kids and, our latest addition, The Influencer Awards. I pinned the list on the board in front of me, next to a Polaroid of Vrinda and me.

Instinctively, I reached for my phone and dialled her number. I knew she was supposed to be helping her mother out at her bridal wear boutique down in Shahpur Jat, but I hoped she'd be able to talk.

She picked up on the fourth ring.

‘Hey, what’s up?’ she asked. Her voice was distant, like she’d put me on speaker. I could hear her rustling garments in the background.

‘I’m in dire need of inspiration,’ I said, my desperation seeping through the phone.

‘I wish I could help, dude. But I’m kind of in the middle of a whole thing.’

I played with the retractable ballpoint pen in my hand, clicking and unclicking as I listened to the faint sound of V shouting at someone on the other end.

‘You okay? What’s happening?’ I asked when she was done.

‘Don’t ask, babe. One of Mom’s friends’ daughters is getting married, and she wants us to do the wedding outfits,’ she said, then added, ‘like all of them ... for the entire family.’

‘Wow,’ I said, ‘that’s a lot of outfits.’

‘Tell me about it. Mom is super stressed coz our designer Kritika is on leave for the whole week to attend her brother’s wedding,’ she said. I could almost hear her frowning through the phone.

‘So many weddings, that’s crazy,’ I said, looking up as an intern handed me my iced coffee.

Generally, I didn’t like ordering the interns around, especially for coffee runs, but I was running incredibly short on time today. A trip to the pantry was a waste of time, much like this phone call was turning out to be.

‘Seriously ...’ she said, taking the phone off speaker, ‘it’s like weddings are all anybody cares about these days.’

I consoled her for a few seconds before hanging up, assuring her that we’d celebrate our long, unfair Mondays with a glass of wine later.

Now that I was back to square one, I began scribbling in my handmade notebook. The trick, I knew, was to put myself in our consumers’ shoes. What were the men of today interested in? Our existing editorial events already covered everything, be it music, movies, sports, business or social media. Plus, we had a series of car launches coming up for the branded section. So what was I missing?

I got a brain freeze as I took a large sip from my iced coffee, and something from the conversation with V came back to me.

Weddings are all anybody cares about.

Men, too, right?

‘Vrinda, you’re a genius,’ I said out loud as the coffee finally began doing its job, and I felt the engine of my brain coming to life.

Putting the ‘Best Man’ idea in the PPT was a risk, I was aware of that. So when Pooja rang me on my intercom and asked me to ‘bring my ass down to her office’, I knew I had fucked up.

As I walked past the line of cubicles to her glass cabin, I just prayed for her to be in a good mood. My boss had a reputation for being moody, and in the past, I’d gotten away with far worse and had been screamed at for way less.

She motioned for me to come inside when I knocked on her door, and I walked up to the chair in front of her desk, knowing better than to sit. I waited for her to look at me, but her head was buried in her laptop. She didn’t say anything for what felt like a few million years, and the silence was so absolute that I was afraid to swallow too loudly.

‘Okay, I’m going to need you to explain this wedding thing to me,’ she said, finally looking up.

I couldn’t tell if she was serious or just getting on my case. I tried to read her current expression. Her smooth, tanned skin was wrinkling in the space between her eyebrows, and her jaw was set tightly. She was either angry or stressed. Neither was good, but I hoped it was the latter.

‘Um,’ I said, aware that my brain was doing that thing it did in high-pressure situations, where it acted like it was completely clueless about what was going on.

My phone vibrated in my hand, reminding me that I could use the presentation I’d made to kick-start my thought process. I quickly opened my email and downloaded the attachment.

‘So the idea came to me because all the men I know who are my age or older are beginning to get married ... or at least starting to think about it,’ I said.

An image of Aadar, sitting in his blazer on my sofa, popped into my mind. It had been a week since his awkward visit to my house, but thinking about it still left me feeling oddly unnerved.

‘Do you have any figures to back that up?’ she asked, her face deadpan.

‘Um, no. Not yet. But it doesn’t matter. Here, let me show you my Instagram,’ I said, taking a step towards her.

She leaned forward to glance at my phone as I scrolled through my feed and tapped on stories of random people.

‘Everyone, it seems, is either getting engaged, married or attending someone else’s wedding,’ I said, then typed a name into the search bar of Instagram.

‘Even influencers are sealing the deal,’ I said, waiting for the profile to load. ‘Look, Harsh Khanna just announced his engagement this afternoon.’

Pooja took the phone from me and studied the picture of a young man with spectacular teeth smiling next to his long-term girlfriend, Deepti. She placed the device on the table in front of her and crossed her arms.

‘So then we should do something around weddings and fashion, maybe?’ she asked, swivelling in her chair to face me.

‘That’s the thing. It can be bigger than that.’

‘How?’

‘We tie up with a wealthy, famous couple, someone like Harsh Khanna, and we convince them to let us be their Best Man,’ I said and paused, hoping for a look of encouragement from my boss.

‘What’s the Best Man supposed to do? Organise the groom’s bachelor party?’ she asked, confused.

‘Well, yes. That and a few other things. But we’d be taking the Western concept of a Best Man and giving it a new meaning in the Indian context. As the Best Man, TMJ would take over all the duties of organising and planning the wedding, along with doing what we do best, creating content,’ I explained.

‘So you mean, like a wedding planner?’ she asked.

‘Kind of ...’

‘But why wouldn’t someone just hire an actual wedding planner?’

I thought about her question for a few moments.

‘Because we would offer them so much more than just planning their big day. The editorial team would cover the whole shebang with exclusive interviews from the couple written in *Humans of New York* style, fashion lookbook breakdowns and listicles that could be applied to grooms

everywhere, along with a massive pile of content from their celebrity guests that would be promoted on social media.'

I paused to lean forward and press the next slide button on Pooja's laptop. A screenshot from last year's plan for The Influencer Awards popped up.

'That's not all. Being a magazine, we can get them way better logistics deals than a regular wedding planner. Like we do for the other events in our portfolio, in exchange for media coverage, we can get a hotel to sponsor the venue, an alcohol brand to cover the bar and some high-end designers to craft special looks for the bride and groom,' I said, took a breath and added, 'and the couple ... they'd get an extraordinary wedding as well as a viral social media campaign.'

'And what would we get?' she asked, her expression still unreadable.

'An insane amount of content, a ton of clicks on the website and, of course, a hefty fee for being the Best Man.'

Pooja shut her MacBook Air, letting her fingers play the piano on its cover.

'Why is this the first time I'm hearing about this?' she asked, a hint of a smile playing on her lips.

I decided to approach the question with honesty.

'Because I just thought of it,' I admitted.

She laughed, lightening the tension in the room. 'Well, it's a little half-baked, but I think it has potential. I'm going to tell the team it's a work in progress.'

A smile escaped my lips and I exhaled in relief.

'Good work, kid,' she said, her choice of words a subtle reminder of her seniority.

Sometimes, when I daydreamed about the future of my career, I wondered if I would be the head of a department by the time I was her age. It felt like an awful amount of time to wait for a glass cabin. I just hoped it would be worth it.

'Oh, by the way, no need to prepare that list of sponsors for next week's car launch,' Pooja said as I was turning to leave.

'Oh, okay ... how come?' I asked.

'The editor had a few contacts that came through. We have a restaurant venue and the bar sponsor already,' she said, packing up her laptop in its

sleeve.

‘That’s fantastic,’ I said, not quite believing that most of my work for the week to come had magically evaporated.

‘I’ll rope you in on the email threads. Just take care of the paperwork for me, yeah?’ she asked as we walked out of her cabin together.

Back in my cubicle, I was thrilled to finally be able to enjoy my Monday. I ate my lunch at my desk, after telling Hina from the editorial team that I couldn’t join her in the cafeteria on account of some unfinished work.

‘That visit from International is keeping everyone on their toes, huh?’ she asked before leaving me alone.

I’d realised long ago that it was better for my professional health if I didn’t have close friends in the office. In a place like this, you almost always had to step on people’s toes to get something done. Inter-department clashes were common, and they got way too ugly when you were friends with the other person. So I stuck to the two-minute small talk rule. I always initiated conversations whenever I bumped into somebody in the washroom, elevator or pantry. But I never hung out with anyone during or after work hours. It might seem like I was taking great pains to be asocial, but the success of my strategy was apparent if you considered my total lack of involvement in office politics. Besides, if I added up the affection everyone in the office had towards me, it might’ve equated to that of a real friend’s. So I wasn’t missing out.

I closed the YouTube tab as I finished eating the burger and fries I had ordered for lunch. The timestamp on my home screen indicated that it was almost 3:00 p.m. Two hours without any work or the surveillance of my boss? What a wonderful day it was turning out to be. I unlocked my phone and opened Tinder. It was time to swipe.

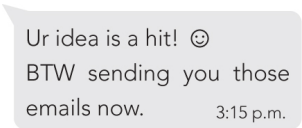
Sometimes I worried that I was on the brink of exhausting all the single men in Delhi. I stressed about what I would do if one day I ran out of men to go on dates with, judge and, well, ultimately reject. And yet, I couldn’t seem to change my dating habits. It’s not that I wasn’t looking for love, because I was.

I’d just found a way to do it without hurting myself. I didn’t have any more heartbreaks left in me after the way my ex had shattered my heart. The entire time we’d been together, all two years of college, he’d been sleeping with other people. Everyone knew. All my friends, who I later

discovered were really only his friends, had known all along. And nobody had ever bothered to tell me. The humiliation was as strong as the pain, and I couldn't bear it. I left college to come back home, taking my exams online after faking a medical emergency. I never went back, blocked every single one of those people out of my life and tried my best to forget that any of it had ever happened.

Once I was back in Delhi, I spent a lot of time healing (read: moping) before I discovered Tinder. Not only was it a great distraction, but it also allowed me to step back into the dating world on my own terms. By following the rules I'd made for my love life, I was able to steer myself away from being tempted by any of the bad apples. Like this guy Suraj, whose profile I was looking at right now. On the surface, he seemed like an attractive, charming guy. He had an athletic build and good posture. His bio was short and to the point. But if you zoomed in on his mirror selfie, you could see his dense, dark eyebrows and the glint in his eyes. The confidence that oozed out of him bordered on narcissism. He was too good to be true.

I was about to swipe left when I got a text from Pooja.



Ur idea is a hit! 😊
BTW sending you those
emails now. 3:15 p.m.

I closed the dating app, clutching my phone to my chest. I couldn't believe this had worked. I realised that it might end up being exactly what I needed with the appraisal coming up. As I gloated, Pooja flooded my inbox with a bunch of long email threads from the sponsors for the car launch event.

Scheduled for the coming Friday, it was going to be the first of five branded events we would do with this automotive brand. It was a pretty straightforward event, so there wasn't too much to plan. Plus, we already had the sponsors, so most of my job was already done. Once I'd formally gotten them on board, all I had to do was send out a bunch of influencer invitations and get them to come to the event for free, which is easier than it sounds. Those guys love parties.

The first two emails were from the restaurant's owners. They were confident the space would be big enough and were ready to arrange a recce this week. I wrote to them, asking if I could come by for a visit tomorrow

afternoon. The recce wouldn't take longer than an hour, but I was sure Pooja wouldn't expect me to come back after it. I sighed happily, already making mental plans for my half-day. Maybe I could schedule a date?

The third email was a pretty standard introductory one from the bar sponsors, but something about it wasn't sitting well with me. It was a reputed brand, Stellar Spirits, one that had never partnered with us before. After a few moments, I realised what was bothering me – this was the company Aadar had said he worked for. I read the email thrice over, looking for God knows what. Eventually, I began to relax. It was a big company. Working with them didn't mean I'd have to work with *him*.

And that's when I saw it. On top of the email message, in the CC field, was the name I'd been dreading I might find.

OceanofPDF.com

A Meal with the Devil

Well, this is awkward

A <aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>

15/5/23 4:02 p.m.

to Ananya

Hi,

I didn't expect to bump into you here. But I'm hoping we can keep things professional. Think you can do that?

Regards,
Aadar Chauhan
Senior Marketing Manager
Stellar Spirits India

Re: Well, this is awkward

A <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>

15/5/23 4:05 p.m.

to Aadar

Okay, cut the BS. You can't seriously expect me to believe this is purely coincidental. You've 'bumped' into me quite a few times now.

Are you a stalker, Mr Aadar Chauhan?

P.S. Of course I can keep it professional. How dare you question my work ethic?

Best,
Ananya Kapoor
Events Manager
TheManJournal

Re: Well, this is awkward

A <aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>

15/5/23 4:11 p.m.

to Ananya

Oh wow! Sober down, all right?

First of all, I'm not sure how you can call yourself a professional while throwing wild accusations at me. I have neither the time nor the desire to stalk you.

And yeah, it's not a complete coincidence. It's just bad luck. Your biodata indicated that you worked here, and I looked up the website. It gave me an idea – a professional one. But believe me, I had no idea I'd actually have to interact with you, or I would've never gone ahead with this. Your biodata said you were a manager. I assumed that was a junior admin type of role. I guess I was wrong.

So if your childish games are over, can we go back to the group email?

Regards,
Aadar Chauhan
Senior Marketing Manager
Stellar Spirits India

Re: Well, this is awkward

A <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>

15/5/23 4:17 p.m.

to Aadar

I see. That's a great story you've got there. For the record, I don't believe one word of it. But because I *am* a professional, I'm willing to put it aside.

For all future intents and purposes, I'm an Events Manager, not a 'Junior' Manager.

Best,
Ananya Kapoor
Events Manager
TheManJournal

Re: E-introductions

S <samarkhanna@stellarspirits.co.in>

15/5/23 4:29 p.m.

to Ananya

cc: <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hi Ananya,

It's a pleasure to connect with you. We're thrilled to initiate this partnership with TheManJournal and are really looking forward to the upcoming event.

Could you kindly arrange for a visit to the venue so @Aadar from our team can vet the bar? Also, do let me know how we can proceed with the paperwork.

Regards,
Samar Khanna
Marketing Head
Stellar Spirits India

Re: E-introductions

A <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>

15/5/23 4:35 p.m.

to Samar

cc: <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<samarkhanna@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hello!

It's great to meet you too. Very excited to see where this goes.

I'm actually going to the restaurant for a recce tomorrow and I'd be happy to send you photos and videos of the bar. There's no need for your colleague to come down there.

I'm attaching the contract with this email. Do let me know if you have any questions about it.

You can e-sign it and send it back to me afterwards.

Best,

Ananya Kapoor

Events Manager

TheManJournal

Re: E-introductions

A <aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>

15/5/23 4:39 p.m.

to Ananya

cc: <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<samarkhanna@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hi Ananya,

I appreciate the offer but it's imperative that I see the venue in person in order to avoid any logistical last-minute issues.

I can make tomorrow work, although I'm in meetings until 5 p.m. Shall we meet there at 6?

We can also exchange the paperwork there itself. Hope that works.

Regards,

Aadar Chauhan

Senior Marketing Manager

Stellar Spirits India

Re: E-introductions

A <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>

15/5/23 4:45 p.m.

to Aadar

cc: <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<samarkhanna@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hi,

Of course, I understand. I will see you there at 6 p.m. Below is the address FYR.
Le Claude, 36,
Defence Colony, Delhi.
Google Maps link [here](#).

Best,
Ananya Kapoor
Events Manager
TheManJournal

Re: Well, this is awkward

A <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>

15/5/23 4:51 p.m.

to Aadar

Thanks for ruining my week. I hate you.

Best,
Ananya Kapoor
Events Manager
TheManJournal

Today could've been the best Tuesday in the history of Tuesdays. A half-day, a free menu tasting at Le Claude, followed by a date with an undecided but hopefully cute stranger. Instead, I was stuck at work all day, painfully watching the clock tick. It didn't help that I was battling an excruciating hangover. After work yesterday, I'd fled to V's place to fill her in about the latest bothersome developments in my life, and we'd decided the only solution was to drink a bottle of wine each and stalk my perpetrator on Instagram.

Aadar had a private profile, so we sent him a request from V's account. And voila! He accepted within ten minutes. Why wouldn't he? The don't-talk-to-strangers rule didn't apply if the stranger in question was a stunning woman. Men are so predictable.

We shouldn't have gone to all that trouble, though. There wasn't much to see on his profile. He hadn't posted anything in months, and his grand total of eight posts consisted of album covers, artsy black-and-white snapshots of the city and a few group photos from birthdays and family functions. There

was one photo that stood out – a post from 2015. It was a hazy Polaroid of a young girl smiling shyly at the camera. There was no caption.

Vrinda and I went on to drink until 2:00 a.m., debating every possible conspiracy theory about who Aadar Chauhan was and why he was suddenly everywhere. My personal favourite was that he was a con man trying to rob me of my riches like Ranveer Singh in *Ladies vs Ricky Behl*. Of course, I didn't have any riches to be robbed of.

I rested my forehead on the wooden desk, groaning lightly. My head was throbbing, and the coffee I'd just consumed had made it worse. I desperately wanted this workday to be over, but I was also not looking forward to what lay ahead. I kept refreshing my inbox every few minutes hoping that he'd email me to cancel. But I didn't hear a peep out of him all day, which is how I found myself staring at my reflection in the glass doors outside Le Claude at 6:05 p.m.

I looked terrible. My hair was dehydrated and extra frizzy, there were dark circles under my eyes and my shoulders were slumped like a seventy-year-old's. The semi-formal plaid dress I'd thrown on this morning, hoping it'd be my redeeming quality, had acquired a visible coffee stain over the course of the day.

I'm so not prepared for this, I thought as I pushed the door open.

A whiff of cold air hit me as I stepped inside, a welcome escape from the pre-sunset heat. A narrow but long alley led to the main seating area. Yellow lanterns were suspended from the ceiling and symbols from French history hung on the wall. I stopped to examine the area, trying to calculate if it could be converted into a photo booth. Just then, a man in a dark-grey suit turned the corner.

'Hello. You must be Ananya?' he asked, stepping forward to greet me. We shook hands as he introduced himself and said, 'I'm Jerry, the manager here.'

Jerry was barely two inches taller than me, but he had a broad chest and big arms. He must've been in his forties, but his smiling eyes took a few years off of him.

'Ananya from TMJ. It's a pleasure,' I said, returning his smile.

'Come, let me show you the space,' he said, ushering me towards the entrance. I asked him to give me a minute and took out my phone to take photos of the alley.

‘Could we remove that podium from there?’ I asked, pointing to the hostess stand at the end of the passage.

‘Of course, I’ll get someone to move it right away,’ he said, not asking why.

‘Thanks. I just want to see if we can turn this space into a mini red carpet,’ I explained and took a few photos of the area the podium occupied. We could definitely fit one camera stand in there, I concluded.

The manager led me inside, where a waiter rushed to offer me a rose-tinted welcome drink.

‘Our special cranberry fizz,’ Jerry said, pointing to the shot glass.

I lifted the glass to my lips and sipped, aware of both men’s eager eyes on me.

‘Mmm,’ I said, tilting my head in surprise, ‘it’s not sickly sweet.’

Jerry laughed, delighted by my response. ‘Yes, we don’t add extra sugar or syrup in this. Takes the fun out of the cranberries, if you ask me.’

‘I agree,’ I said, placing the glass back on the tray.

I was relieved to see that the restaurant was as spacious as it had looked in the photos, and it had movable furniture – no booths, thankfully. The white walls with gold detailing stretched out in front of me, giving the space a hall-like look. The baby pink sofas matched the pink tulips at every table, and chandeliers with swooping arms shone brightly above them. The bar was situated right at the entrance, which was not ideal, at least for us. We didn’t want the influencers running off to drink before they had a chance to pose with the car. The Stellar Spirits guys, of course, would be thrilled. Speaking of, where was the man of the hour?

What an ass, I thought. He hadn’t even had the decency to show up on time after changing my entire schedule. I took a few photos of the bar, listening to Jerry talk about the different cocktails they were thinking of curating for the menu.

‘You’ll have to run the bar menu by Stellar Spirits. They’re sponsoring the alcohol for the event,’ I said, proceeding to explain that someone from their team was supposed to be here today.

‘Oh yes, I met with Aadar sir right before you arrived,’ he said.

‘Oh? Has he left already?’ I asked, trying to hide the hopefulness in my voice.

Jerry looked around and said, ‘I think he went out to take a call.’

A few seconds later, Aadar walked in from the alley, slipping his phone inside his black trousers. He wore a white slim-fit shirt, identical to the one his brother had worn at Saurav's party. I wondered if they shared clothes the way sisters usually did. He had a polite smile plastered on his face as he met us at the bar, one that didn't quite reach his eyes.

'You're late,' he said to me as Jerry excused himself to help with the podium rearrangement.

I scoffed. 'I've been here for like fifteen minutes.'

He checked his watch and said, 'And it's 6:25. Which means you're late.'

I rolled my eyes at him, asking him where he'd been if he was so punctual. He ignored me, leaning on the bar top to peek at the bottles placed behind the counter.

'We can't have more than two bartenders here,' he said, switching to business mode.

'That shouldn't be a problem. It's a small event, and the guests will be busy promoting the car for the most part anyway,' I said.

A part of me was still irked by his presence, but I had to remind myself that I was representing TheManJournal.

'And our whisky,' he said.

'Hmm?'

He turned to look at me and said, 'They also have to promote our whisky.'

The light cast by the chandeliers gave his brown eyes an appealing golden glow. In fact, they looked like they'd been dipped in single malt.

'Well, they obviously can't directly promote whisky or alcohol in general. But we'll shoot them drinking at the bar, cheering, having fun and all that with your branding in the background,' I explained, and he nodded his approval.

I left him to study the details of the bar and went on to explore the rest of the space. A chunk of the furniture would have to be cleared from the middle of the restaurant where the car would be displayed. Jerry showed me the wide back entrance through which the car would be brought inside. I documented every nook and corner of the restaurant on my phone, knowing I'd have to create digital maps for Ryan's reference so he could brief the logistics team. He should've ideally been here, but he was apparently still

sick. I dreamt of the day when hangovers would be openly accepted as valid reasons for sick leaves.

A waiter showed me the food menu as I sat down at a table. It occurred to me that I hadn't eaten anything solid all day, which was probably why my headache had persisted. I was drooling over the names of the fancy French dishes when the chair opposite me was pulled back. I looked up to find a waiter ushering Aadar into the seat.

'All good?' I asked, hoping he wouldn't complain about things I couldn't fix.

'Yeah, we can make it work,' he said.

'Perfect. So if you could just hand me the signed paperwork, I'll let you be on your way,' I said, eager for him to leave me alone with my fancy food.

He let out a low chuckle, shaking his head lightly.

'I'd love to be rid of you too, but I'm not quite done here yet,' he said, dropping the façade of politeness.

I leaned back and crossed my arms. *Be rid of me?*

'Please. You're the one who insisted on coming.' I didn't say it, but the word 'stalker' hung in the air between us.

'Trust me, I have no interest in hanging out with you. This visit was purely professional.' He placed his right ankle on his knee, looking irritatingly comfortable in his seat.

'So why are you still here?' I raised an eyebrow accusingly.

'I haven't tried out the bar menu yet.' He shrugged.

I stared at him, feeling the insides of my stomach rumble with post-hangover hunger.

'Wait, you're going to drink right now?' I asked.

'Why not? Aren't you sampling their food? Perks of the job,' he said, beaming.

It took my overburdened brain a few seconds to realise what this meant. I was stuck with him for at least another hour, in what felt like a grey area. Technically, we were both still working, but we didn't have any obligation to do it together. I could've asked him to sit at a different table or, better still, just stand at the bar, but I knew our lack of interaction would seem odd to the restaurant staff. The best option was to focus on my food and get out of here as soon as possible.

Jerry came to our table a few minutes later with a bar menu, which he placed in front of Aadar.

‘We’re going to open for dinner to regular customers now, but I’ll make sure we get your orders on priority,’ he said to us, his eyes twinkling in the light.

‘Thank you, Jerry. Could you get me a taster for each of these five appetisers?’ I traced a finger down the ‘small plates’ section.

‘And in veg?’

I flipped the page and pointed out two more appetisers.

‘Do keep the servings bite-sized. I don’t have a huge appetite.’ I smiled at him.

Aadar raised his eyebrows without looking at me and mumbled, ‘Clearly.’

I wanted to tell him off for slyly commenting on my body, but Jerry was still standing there, peering over Aadar’s shoulder as he contemplated between the cocktails.

‘Get me a 30 ml of a Whisky Sour and a Manhattan, and a whisky cocktail of the bartender’s choice,’ he said, handing the menu back to Jerry.

I wasn’t bothered by the fact that he didn’t ask me if I wanted a drink. Discourteous behaviour fit perfectly with his personality. Besides, I was swearing off drinking, or at least mid-week drinking, until further notice.

We sat without speaking as guests began to trickle in. The chatter from the nearby tables heightened the silence between us. But we just sat there, willing each other to speak first. It was almost as if we were in a staring contest, waiting for our opponent to blink. I caved first.

‘So, arranged marriage, huh?’ I said, clearing my throat.

He gave me a blank stare as he took a sip of water and said, ‘Really? That’s what you decided to bring up?’

‘What would you rather discuss? My one-night stand with your brother?’ I asked curtly.

He refused to take the bait. ‘We don’t have to talk at all,’ he said, pulling his phone out of his pocket. He began typing out a message, unbothered by the dirty look I was throwing his way.

Fine. Two can play at this game.

With a casual flick of my thumb, I unlocked my phone screen and pretended to look busy. But the barren wasteland of my notifications

couldn't offer the distraction I desperately sought. There were no urgent emails demanding my attention, no frantic texts clamouring for a response. It was as if the Universe had hit the mute button on my social life, leaving me stranded in this awkward tête-à-tête with nothing but the sound of Aadar's incessant tapping to keep me company.

After a few agonising minutes of silence, I gave up.

I sighed loudly to get his attention, and he finally looked up from his phone.

'I'm genuinely curious. How did your parents convince you for this matchmaking gig?' I asked, broaching the subject again, this time with more amiability.

I half expected him not to respond, but he asked, 'What makes you think I had to be convinced?'

I exhaled a gust of air in surprise and placed my elbows on the table.

'Are you telling me that you, a modern, successful, debatably attractive guy, actually believe in the evils of an age-old patriarchal tradition?'

'You find me attractive, huh?' he asked, a hint of a smile playing on his lips.

'I said debatably attractive.' I huffed, feeling my cheeks grow hot.

A waiter brought us a serving of pigs in a blanket, fish fingers and mini avocado toast, and I was grateful for the interruption. He placed the drinks in the centre, not knowing which one belonged to whom. Aadar picked up the Whisky Sour and took a sip, while I wasted no time in pouncing on the food.

'Mmm, this is really good,' I said more to myself than him, as I took a bite of the pork sausage.

Aadar reached for one, and without thinking, I slapped his hand away.

'What? What are you doing?' he asked, still eyeing the food.

'Why should I share my food if you're not sharing your drinks?' I said before I could stop myself.

Aadar let out a chuckle, and I stuffed my mouth with a fish finger, knowing how stupid this was. I sounded like a child, a bratty one.

'Obviously you can drink the whisky. I'm not finishing all of this by myself on a weekday,' he said, gesturing to the three glasses between us.

Was this the way responsible adults behaved? I drank a lot more than 90 ml last night, without a single ounce of worry about it being a weekday.

‘No, thank you. I’m a little hungover,’ I admitted.

‘Well, a good whisky is a great cure for a hangover,’ he said, nudging the glass of Manhattan towards me. Was he calling for a ceasefire?

I made a great show of reluctance but took a sip anyway. The spirit warmed my throat, and I cherished the taste for a microsecond.

‘Now can I eat? I’m starving,’ he asked as his hand hovered dramatically over the food.

Between the two of us, we wiped off the appetisers within minutes. I gestured to a waiter to order the main course tasters. He noted down my order and assured us he’d be back soon.

‘What about you? How does a girl like you agree to an arranged marriage?’ he asked when the waiter had left.

‘What do you mean, a girl like me?’ I demanded, my guard shooting back up.

‘You know ... modern, successful, etc.,’ he said, carefully leaving out my attractiveness from the equation.

His words surprised me and left my skin feeling tingly.

‘Well, I didn’t agree to it. It was just that one time, and I only did it to get my parents off my back,’ I said, downing my drink to claim the remaining cocktail.

So much for no mid-week drinking.

‘So, what, you don’t believe in marriage?’ he asked.

‘When did I say that? Arranged marriage, yeah, definitely not. But I do want to get married someday,’ I accepted.

I wondered if the alcohol had any part to play in this turn in the conversation.

‘And how do you expect to meet someone?’ he asked, displaying an odd amount of interest in my personal life.

‘Um, I meet plenty of people. Off dating apps,’ I said, mimicking a swiping motion with my hand.

He let out a dry laugh, the judgement in his tone returning as he said, ‘Dating apps, right. The latest addiction for millennials.’

Before I could offer a retort, his phone started to ring loudly. He excused himself and walked away to receive the call.

As I waited for him to return, I couldn’t help but wonder what we must have looked like to the other customers in the restaurant. Would they

assume we were a couple? Perhaps we seemed like we were on a first date, drinking together and debating our differing views on love and life.

If my life was a romcom, this would've been a classic 'opposites attract' story. We would've mocked and teased each other, insisting on how much we hated spending time together without realising that we'd been sitting in the restaurant past closing hours. We would've gotten drunk, bantered while we waited for our cabs and somehow ended up getting into the first one that arrived, together.

But of course, none of that happened. Aadar's phone call lasted for the most part of an hour. When he got back, I'd finished the food and was saying goodbye to Jerry. We exchanged the paperwork and went our separate ways, holding onto the distaste we had for each other.

OceanofPDF.com

Occupational Hazard

THE DAYS LEADING UP to the car launch felt long and stuffed with work. Because of Ryan's prolonged sick leave, I had to do a fair portion of his work, which involved speaking to different vendors, managing equipment and of course, the transportation of the car. He only showed up to work at the end of the week, five working days before the event. I had secretly hoped Pooja would ask him to work over the weekend, but his fake allergies and constant sniffing got him off the hook.

My own to-do list was tackled smoothly, except for one minor roadblock. Stellar Spirit's team had taken one look at the guest list and singled out the influencer with the most followers, Kiara Gupta (@iamkiki). They insisted on her being one of the guaranteed promoters of our barter deal. I knew better than to promise a particular influencer or celebrity to a brand because there was no way I could be sure I'd be able to deliver on it. There were multiple things that could go wrong – influencers could refuse to endorse a brand for free, even in an editorial setting like ours, or worse, simply not show up. After all, there was no contract holding them responsible. They were just guests, coming to partake in a mutually appreciative social media parade.

But Aadar's emails, which on the surface were completely respectful, seemed to be taunting me. When I informed him that I couldn't ensure which influencers posed at their bar, he wrote to me saying, 'We expect someone of your skill and experience will be able to manage a social media celebrity perfectly well.' And so, like a complete unthinking idiot, I told him I'd manage it perfectly well all right.

We continued to exchange emails as we inched closer to the event but made no reference to the evening we'd spent together at Le Claude, which, honestly, is how I preferred it. That meal had definitely been a grey area in our professional relationship. It was better if his presence was limited to this email chat box. But our days of exchanging virtual niceties were limited.

The night of the event rolled in sooner than I'd imagined. Buried under Ryan's and my own work, I barely realised where the time went.

'Is he going to be there tonight?' asked Vrinda, my date for the night, as she carefully tucked her dress inside the backseat of my father's car.

'He who?' Dad asked, adjusting the rear-view mirror.

'Nobody,' I said, throwing her a look.

Oops, she mouthed.

I hadn't told my parents about my continued interaction with the match they'd found for me, for fear that they would believe it was voluntary, or worse, destiny. They'd been bummed when I'd told them Aadar and I had no interest in each other but had agreed to not set me up with any new men, at least for the time being.

'You look great, don't worry,' V whispered to me after my dad had dropped us off in front of Le Claude.

I'd been buttoning and unbuttoning my suit jacket repeatedly for the past hour, unable to decide which made me look cooler.

'Did you forget that my mom said I looked like your chauffeur?' I said, pointing to V's black mesh gown, which had a plunging neckline. She looked like a celebrity and to be honest, a teeny tiny part of me felt like she had one-upped me at my own event.

She waved me away with a *pfft* and said, 'I'm the basic bitch at any party. But you,' she paused to give me a once-over and whistled dramatically, 'you're rocking that power suit.'

I scolded myself internally, swallowing any envy I may have felt for my best friend. Linking my arm through hers, I stepped onto the sidewalk.

The launch wasn't scheduled to begin until 7:00 p.m., which meant it would be at least an hour before the street Le Claude was on started looking crowded. The restaurant had a valet service to make up for the complete lack of parking space in the busy neighbourhood of Defence Colony. I could only hope that it'd be enough.

'Shall we?' Vrinda asked, stepping aside as the bouncer held the door open for us.

The alley looked better than I'd hoped. The hanging lanterns awarded it the perfect lighting for a photo booth, and V was determined to try it out.

'Come on, it'll be like a prom photo,' she insisted, dragging me in front of the photographer.

Alex, our editorial photographer, was happy to have his first subjects for the evening.

‘You guys look great,’ he said, then pointed to the small table to our right. ‘Can I interest you in some props?’

‘Ooooooh cute!’ V said as she picked up a tiny, frilled umbrella, ‘I feel like I’m in Pahree.’

‘Your French accent is truly heinous,’ I said with a laugh and crowned my head with a knitted beret.

Our little moment was interrupted by my boss, who looked stunning in an emerald-green evening gown and diamond dangles. I didn’t get to tell her any of that, because she refused to waste a second on customary compliments and jumped straight to talking shop. One of the interns had broken the office iPhone, the DJ was running late, the backup for the DJ was a no-show and Ryan needed help with something she couldn’t remember.

I stood there waiting to see if there was more, but she gave me a look that screamed ‘chop chop’.

‘Can I help?’ V asked as we walked over to the main area.

I looked around. The space seemed smaller now that a rose gold luxury sedan sat right in the middle of it. But Le Claude’s interiors complemented the personality of the car perfectly, casting a golden glow on and around it.

‘Mmm, why don’t you get yourself a drink? I’ll join you once things kick off,’ I said and showed my friend to the bar after doing a double scan for Aadar and coming up empty.

For a second, I let myself dream about the possibility of him bailing. Then, I was sucked into an intern briefing huddle and had to shove him out of my head. The intern who’d been with us the longest, Rajat, got the enviable job of escorting Kiara Gupta throughout the night. The others were to do what they did best – take boomerangs, slow-mos and fake candid shots of anyone and everyone who mattered.

I floated through the room, supervising my team and interacting with familiar faces from the office. Since this was a branded event, the editorial team was not required to show up. Nevertheless, a few had decided to make an appearance, no doubt to enjoy a night of free food and booze. Hina, the junior copywriter, was one of them. She’d even brought a plus one.

‘Oh my God, I love your suit,’ she said, her voice strangely high-pitched.

She proceeded to introduce me to her date, whose name I instantly categorised as unimportant and therefore didn't care to retain. I was going to meet a shit ton of people tonight. It would be impossible to remember all of their names, so I had to make sure I had space for the important ones. I spotted Jerry in the crowd, the manager I'd met during my previous visit, and excused myself to go say hi.

The smaller influencers arrived early, some even before 7:00 p.m. I spent a few minutes with each of them, showing them around while I had the time. My experience told me it was the micro-influencers who proved to be the most beneficial. They hadn't been to too many events and were just happy to be included. They would go home and post a ton of pictures, always remembering to use our hashtag and tag our profile out of their eagerness to be reposted and credited. Bigger fish, like Kiara, turned up late and threw tantrums.

By 8:00 p.m., the party was in full swing, and I could finally steal a few minutes to go chat with Vrinda. She was standing by one of the cocktail tables near the DJ console.

'I'm sorry ... sorry. How're you doing?' I asked, wrapping one arm around her waist.

Her crystal heels gave her a boost that her already tall frame didn't quite need, and I fit in snugly against her shoulder.

'Oh, don't worry about me. I'm happily getting drunk,' she said, waving a hand at me. My best friend had the enviable quality of looking comfortable at parties where she didn't know a single person. Her confidence inevitably drew others to her.

I stayed by her side for a while, giving her backstories about all the people from work. She made me down her drink, instructing me to have a bit of fun before the night was over.

'I'll find my way back to you,' I said and blew her a kiss as I walked away to scan the room and play social kitten.

I spotted Aadar instantly. He was leaning against the bar, talking to a woman I didn't recognise. He caught me looking at him before I could glance away and raised his glass in my direction.

I scoffed. *Who did he think he was, Jay Gatsby?*

I didn't bother walking up to the bar to greet him. There were more important things that needed to be dealt with, like the swarm of interns who

had crowded around a stand-up comedian to take a selfie. I glared at them after the guy walked away.

‘Take photos of the guests, not with them,’ I said, shaking my head at the four twenty-somethings in front of me.

They mumbled their apologies and shuffled away, giggling quietly and looking through their phone galleries to inspect if the photos had come out all right.

By 9:00 p.m., Pooja had traded her business avatar for a social, Saturday night one. She found me next to Alex, who was busy snapping passable photos as quickly as possible to keep the corridor from getting too cramped.

‘Come here, I want to introduce you to someone,’ she said, handing me a glass of red wine.

She led me to the front of the room where an American man was speaking to Hina. He was older, in his fifties perhaps, but well-groomed and fit.

‘David, hey,’ Pooja said as we joined them at their cocktail table, ‘this is Ananya from my team.’

She then looked at me and said, ‘This is David Miller from International.’

I took a pause before offering him my hand, uncertain about the proper way to greet a superior in a setting like this. ‘It’s a pleasure to meet you.’

‘The pleasure’s mine. You’ve done a wonderful job tonight. And the food is exquisite,’ he said, gesturing towards the charcuterie plate on the table.

His black-rimmed spectacles intensified the shadows in his eyes, so he looked like he was being stern even when he smiled.

‘Thank you. And I’ll convey your compliments to the chef,’ I said, and he nodded.

From the corner of my eye, I saw Pooja exhaling a subtle release of tension. I realised that this was the first time she was introducing me to a higher-up from the company outside of work hours. Did this mean I was joining the ranks?

‘I love the Best Man idea, by the way. It could really be something if the execution is tasteful,’ he said after a minute.

‘We won’t let you down,’ I said, stealing a glance in my boss’s direction.

‘To fresh ideas,’ she said, raising her wine glass in my direction. ‘May we never run out of them.’

A little while later, Rajat appeared at our side, looking frantic. Pooja and I left David in the care of Hina and her unnamed date and followed him to the corner in front of the washrooms.

‘What is it?’ I asked, failing to mask the anxiety in my voice.

‘It’s Kiara,’ he said, tugging at the sleeves of his oversized blazer nervously.

‘Oh, she’s here? Great,’ Pooja said, taking another sip of her wine.

The three of us turned our heads to look at the booth where the car was parked. A buzz was forming around it. She was perched on the bonnet, her long legs stretching out seductively as she posed.

‘Yeah. Um, she is, but she won’t shoot at the bar,’ he said.

‘What? Why?’ I asked.

‘She says she’s on an alcohol cleanse ... and uh, she won’t endorse a product she doesn’t consume,’ he said.

I let out a puff of air. Was I to believe that she was going to be sober for the entire night?

‘Who needs alcohol when you can just ...’ Pooja said as she touched her nose and winked at me.

When neither of us said anything more, Rajat ran back to the influencer he was in charge of.

‘Um, Pooja,’ I began, wondering why she hadn’t started screaming at me yet.

‘Yeah?’

‘The Stellar Spirits guys are expecting her as a promoter,’ I said.

‘Of course they are. But as long as we didn’t promise them anyth—’

I cut her off. ‘I kinda did,’ I said, then added after a pause, ‘On email.’

The wine-induced softness that had made its way to her face swiftly disappeared.

‘What?’ she whisper-screamed.

I tried my best to explain the special circumstances under which I’d broken this cardinal rule, but obviously, I couldn’t give her anything more.

‘You have to fix this, Ananya,’ she said, her voice cold.

‘I know, yes. I will,’ I said, glancing at Kiara, who was now socialising with some of the other influencers.

‘No, not her. She won’t do it,’ she said, shaking her head. ‘Make good with the Stellar Spirits rep. Get him drunk, make sure he has one hell of a

night. If he doesn't make a big deal out of this, neither will his team.'

I nodded at her, assuring her that I'd fix it. She didn't look convinced, but she left me to deal with it on my own. I filtered the crowd with my eyes, searching for the one person I'd hoped to avoid tonight. The idea of 'making good' with him, whatever that meant, made me want to throw up. But unless I wanted to kiss my promotion goodbye, I'd have to do exactly that.

I spotted him walking away from the bar, two drinks in his hand. He was making his way towards the rear end of the room. I followed him, soldiering through the ever-growing crowd of the party. Ryan hindered my pursuit when he crashed into me in front of the car booth.

'Watch it,' he said, then changed his tone when he looked up. 'Oh, it's you.'

He filled me in about the latest crisis he was dealing with. I patted his arm, telling him I had to go deal with mine.

My pit stop with Ryan had given Aadar a longer head start, and when I finally emerged from the crowd, I found him smiling at the person I'd forgotten I'd brought with me to the party.

I turned around immediately, burying myself in the mass of people once again. I retrieved my phone from my trousers and called Vrinda, hoping she'd pick up. She did, on the second ring.

'Dude, come to the washroom. Right. Now.' I had to almost shout to be heard over the chatter.

I only moved away when I saw her excusing herself from the table. Once we were inside the washroom, I checked the cubicles to ensure we were alone.

'Annie ... you didn't tell me he was cute!' she squealed, clutching my arms.

'V, this is serious. Why the hell were you talking to him?' I asked.

She turned towards the mirror, a tiny frown forming on her face as she said, 'He came over to talk to me. Just now.'

'What did he say?' I asked, ignoring the fact that she sounded a little cross.

She pulled at the neckline of her dress, adjusting the amount of cleavage she wanted to be displayed.

‘That he felt like he’d seen me somewhere,’ she said, then added in a lighter, playful tone, ‘I think he was hitting on me.’

‘Oh God, V. He *has* seen you somewhere,’ I said, holding up my phone to remind her of our little Instagram adventure.

‘Oh shit,’ she said, turning to face me.

A woman entered the washroom, and we lowered our voices as she went inside.

‘What do we do now? He can’t find out you and I are best friends,’ I said, trying to limit the panic in my voice.

‘Yeah, or he’ll know you were stalking him,’ she said with a giggle.

I threw her an I-don’t-need-this-right-now look, and she held up her hands in surrender.

‘I’ll book myself a cab home,’ she said, sounding just a tad bit disappointed.

‘I’m really sorry I couldn’t spend more time with you tonight,’ I said, pouting innocently at my best friend. ‘I’ll make it up to you.’

She hugged me, asking if I could steal a bottle of whisky for her to leave with.

‘Just one?’ I asked, making her laugh.

I waited with her in the washroom while her cabbie showed up, filling her in about what had happened with Kiara.

‘So, you’re going to spend the evening chatting up Mr Aadar Chauhan, huh?’ she asked, teasing.

‘Please, stop that,’ I said and punched her arm lightly.

‘I’m just saying,’ she said, shrugging casually, ‘it could’ve been worse ... he could’ve been ugly.’

‘Now *that* would’ve helped.’

It took me a good fifteen minutes to find him because he’d left the room altogether. I panicked when I saw him standing outside the main door, assuming he was waiting for the valet.

‘Are you leaving already?’ I asked, stepping onto the pavement.

If he was surprised to see me, he didn’t show it. ‘Nope.’

He held up his left hand and took a drag from his cigarette.

‘That thing will kill you, you know,’ I said, stepping away from the door and closer to him.

He turned his head to look at me and slowly exhaled the smoke.

‘Did you come out here in the heat to give me a health warning?’ His face was devoid of any expression.

This wasn’t working. I realised that if I wanted him to warm up to me, I’d have to make a genuine effort. So even though it made me want to cringe, I decided it was officially time to kiss Aadar’s ass.

‘I just feel like we got off on the wrong foot,’ I said, trying to sound sincere. ‘And tonight’s a good time to change that.’

That seemed to amuse him.

‘All right,’ he said after a brief pause. ‘How do you propose we do that?’

I could tell he was trying to figure me out, but I was glad he didn’t straight up refuse my peace offering.

‘You could get me a drink to start with,’ I said, then mock whispered, ‘don’t worry, it’s free.’

‘Ha ha,’ he said, but he had a hint of a smile on his face. I waited for him to crush the cigarette and then led the way back indoors.

‘What are you drinking?’ he asked me at the bar, which was getting noisier by the minute.

I’d had a bit of everything up until now, thanks to the stolen sips and drinks. Usually I preferred wine or beer over any other type of alcohol. But I pointed at his empty whisky glass. Tonight, I needed to be on his level.

With our drinks in our hands, we gravitated towards an empty table in one of the quieter corners of the room. I placed my glass on the high table and leaned on it with my elbows, taking a moment to appreciate the turnout tonight.

‘Looks pretty different than that day, huh?’ Aadar asked, following my gaze.

‘I worked very hard to make sure of it,’ I said.

‘I bet,’ he said with a hint of sarcasm, which he must’ve regretted because he changed the topic with a compliment. ‘Nice suit, by the way.’

‘You too,’ I said, pointing to his black-and-blue woven Italian tuxedo.

Three out of the four times I’d met this man, he’d been dressed in formals. I wondered if that was because he knew he looked pretty good in them.

‘So, explored any more rishtas?’ I asked and he chuckled.

‘Been on any more Tinder dates?’ he retorted.

‘Yeah, two,’ I said, unfazed.

He took a second to sip the drink in his hand.

‘You’re telling me you’ve been on two dates with two different guys since the last time I saw you?’

I placed my glass back on the table, a little harder than I’d meant to. ‘Are you slut-shaming me?’

‘No, no, I’m not. I’m just ... surprised you had the time. With all this in the pipeline,’ he said, gesturing at the room around us.

‘I made the time. I have a rule ...’ I trailed off.

I was revealing too much. Talking to him about my love life made me uneasy. He was no doubt going to judge me for it. But I did have to keep the conversation going somehow ...

‘Do tell,’ he said, feigning interest.

Just answer his question, I instructed myself. You can do it.

‘I go on one date every week. Give or take,’ I finally divulged.

‘Wow,’ he said. ‘And how many weeks has this rule lived to see?’

I attempted to calculate how long it had been since my break-up with my lying, cheating pig of an ex in 2017, but the whisky must’ve impaired my abilities to do quick math.

‘Like three years?’ I offered.

He leaned forward, resting his chin on his right hand.

‘You’ve been on over 150 dates?’ he asked, his face lighting up with hilarity.

‘I mean, I’ve no idea if that is the actual math or not, but yeah. My friends call me a bit of a serial dater.’

Okay, I was definitely oversharing. He didn’t need to know any of this. It didn’t help that he looked like he was finally having a good time, revelling in the failures of my romantic endeavours.

‘Enough about me,’ I said before he could probe further.

‘All right, what do you want to know?’ he asked.

‘The same thing I asked you the last time we were here together. Why would someone like you turn to arranged marriage?’

He took a breath and I wondered if he was contemplating whether to tell me the truth or not. Was his family pressuring him? Was he a traditionalist?

Or did he derive some weird form of entertainment from the process?

‘I want to start a family,’ he finally said.

‘Um ...’ I said, motioning for him to elaborate.

‘I’m just ready to settle down. That’s all,’ he said, holding my gaze.

‘So you’re going to let your parents find a girl for you?’ I asked, genuinely puzzled by what I was hearing.

‘I mean, why not? They’re just introducing me to the right pool of people,’ he said, then added after a second, ‘They’re like Tinder ... for marriage.’

I laughed at that and he joined in. From across the room, I caught Pooja’s eye, and she nodded at me approvingly. *Wait a second, was this actually working?*

‘But, the whole system is so regressive,’ I said, getting back to the subject. ‘I mean, how can you gallivant all your life and then look for a virgin bahu when you turn twenty-eight? It’s ridiculous.’

He raised his hand, gesturing to a waiter who was serving drinks. It turned out to be Jerry. He greeted us warmly, happy to see the two people he knew at this party together. He replaced our glasses with two fresh whisky waters and left.

‘But I’m not looking for a virgin bahu,’ he said, clinking his glass with mine. ‘I’d like a virgin patni.’

He laughed at his own joke and I shook my head.

I clicked my tongue when I spoke, ‘You know what I mean. There are so many other hypocritical things. And don’t even get me started on the religion, caste and class filters.’

He nodded, tapping his hands on the clothed table.

‘Yeah, but it doesn’t have to be like that. A system is what you make of it. I’m looking for a girl to settle down with. I don’t care about her past, her background and all of that,’ he argued.

‘Hmm,’ I said, trying to bite my tongue.

No part of me believed that he was as liberal in his matchmaking ventures as he was making it sound. Even if he didn’t have the typical arranged marriage filters in place, his parents would. I could bet my life on the fact that a Muslim girl would never seep through that protective net. But it felt like we were getting along, and I had to keep up my agreeable act if I

wanted this night to go in my favour. So even though it physically pained me not to argue with him on the matter, I decided to let it go.

‘So how many women have you seen?’ I asked.

‘Like biodatas or in person?’

‘The latter.’

He shifted his weight from one leg to another, and I snuck a glance at my phone. It was five past midnight, and people were beginning to leave. The room felt emptier than before, and the music had mellowed down too. Apart from Rajat and another intern from the office, I couldn’t spot any lurking coworkers.

‘I haven’t really kept count,’ he said, shrugging.

‘Give me a ballpark figure.’

‘I don’t know. Twenty? Thirty, maybe.’

That, for some reason, cracked me up. A loud laugh erupted from me, and I felt a few eyes on me from around the room. Aadar waited for me to stop laughing, unimpressed.

‘I just realised what you are,’ I said, trying to stifle another laugh.

‘What?’

‘A serial suitor,’ I said and burst out laughing again.

His amusement at me was laced with a speck of annoyance.

‘All right, I think you’ve had enough,’ he said, eyeing my half-empty whisky glass.

I protested half-heartedly, but I knew he was right. I wasn’t drunk, but I was well on my way. Besides, it looked like the party was more or less over. I followed him outside, waving goodbye to Ryan, who was speaking to a transportation guy in the back. A part of me felt bad that he’d have to be here for hours winding up. But this was his job, and I’d done it enough times to know there was no way around it.

‘How are you getting home?’ Aadar asked when we stepped outside.

‘I’ll call a cab,’ I said.

‘I’ll drop you off,’ he said, handing the valet his parking ticket.

‘You don’t have to do that. I’m fine,’ I said at the precise moment I stumbled on a stone.

He chuckled and mumbled under his breath, ‘Clearly.’

I puffed my mouth, ready to strike back with verbal vengeance. But the soberer part of my brain reminded me of what was on the line here. Today

was not the right day to pick a fight with this man. And if he wanted to drop me home, I was going to let him. I'd spent the greater part of the evening with him. Surely, I could tolerate him for a little while longer. Right? Besides, if he was so keen to look out for me today, chances were he'd help me out on Monday too when I would tell him and his team about the Kiara debacle.

'So, Mr Serial Suitor,' I couldn't help saying once we were sitting inside his red Kia.

'Don't start,' he said as he pulled out of the street.

'I'm just curious. What's the rush? Like why not just wait for the right person to come along?' I asked.

'Like you're doing? With your incessant dating?'

'I know you're trying to spin this around on me, but I'm pretty happy with the way things are in my love life.'

'Really?' He stole a look at me and said, 'So you're not looking for love?'

'I am,' I admitted. 'But I'm not actively doing it.'

'One date a week? I'd say that's pretty active,' he chuckled.

I crossed my arms, turning sideways so I could face him properly.

'Are you saying there's something wrong with me? That's why I haven't found someone?'

'Either that or with all 150 of the guys you've gone on dates with. Probability is not in your favour,' he said.

The tension in the car was heightening, and as much as I wanted to undo it, there was no going back. I was in too deep, and my pride wouldn't let me back down.

'Oh, shut up. You're one to talk,' I exclaimed. 'Like you haven't rejected your fair share of prospects. And this is when your parents already vetted them for you.'

'That's right. I rejected them. Not the other way around.'

'Well, I rejected you when you came to see me. So maybe the others did too.'

He let out a dry, sarcastic laugh and said, 'I'm a catch.'

'Why's no one catching you, then?' I demanded.

'Well, I'll get caught before you do,' he said, pulling into the lane my apartment building was on.

It struck me that he'd driven all this way without asking for directions. He must be one of those people who remembered addresses even if they'd just visited once.

'You wanna bet on that?' I asked as we waited for the security guard to open the gate for the car.

'Yeah, why not?'

'Uh-oh,' I said, letting out a wicked laugh, feeling my competitive spirit kick in.

He parked outside my building and shut off the engine. Then, he unbuckled his seatbelt and turned to face me.

'So, what are you proposing?' He had his game face on.

I knew I should've laughed the whole thing off. I should've thanked him for the ride, said goodnight and gone home. Instead, I chose to wind myself up in the biggest lurch I would face in my entire life.

'Let's see who can find someone first. And if you get yourself a wife before I can find a boyfriend, you win.'

I half expected him to laugh in my face – to call me crazy and drive away. But he didn't. Instead, he held my gaze, his jaw tightening as he mulled over what I'd said.

'What does the winner get?' he finally asked.

'The satisfaction of being the bigger catch?' I said in a tone that suggested I was pointing out the obvious.

An irritating smirk lit up his face as he said, 'You're on.'

Ground Rules

Post-event coverage

A <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>

29/5/23 11:02 a.m.

to Samarth

cc: <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hello

Team,

It was a pleasure to partner with you for our recent event. We hope your team enjoyed the launch and had a great evening.

I'm attaching an Excel sheet with the social media links for the barter posts and additional influencer reposts, with stats on their performances. Do let us know your thoughts on the same.

Best,
Ananya Kapoor
Events Manager
TheManJournal

Re: Post-event coverage

S <samarkhanna@stellarspirits.co.in>

29/5/23 1:29 p.m.

to Ananya

cc: <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hi Ananya,

Thank you for sending across the links. We've been keeping an eye on the content over the last two days, and we're quite happy with the coverage + performance. @Aadar also filled me in on the events of the launch night, which he insists couldn't have gone better.

Perhaps we could come down to your office one of these days to discuss the future of this association?

Regards,
Samar Khanna

Marketing Head
Stellar Spirits India

Re: Post-event coverage

P <pooja.ghai@themanjournal.co.in>

29/5/23 2:07 p.m.

to Samarth

cc: <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hi Samarth,

So glad to hear the feedback!

How's tomorrow for the meeting? I've got a very interesting project I'd love to hear your thoughts on.

Best,
Pooja Ghai
Events Head
TheManJournal

Re: Post-event coverage

S <samarkhanna@stellarspirits.co.in>

29/5/23 3:19 p.m.

to Pooja

cc: <ananya.kapoor@themanjournal.co.in>; <ryan.pinto@themanjournal.co.in>;
<aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>; <harisharma@stellarspirits.co.in>

Hi Pooja,

Tomorrow looks good. Let's say we'll be there by 12:00 p.m.?

Regards,
Samar Khanna
Marketing Head
Stellar Spirits India

Re: Well, this is awkward

A <aadarchauhan@stellarspirits.co.in>

29/5/23 4:02 p.m.

to Ananya

Free for lunch after tomorrow's meeting? We need to talk.

Regards,
Aadar Chauhan
Senior Marketing Manager
Stellar Spirits India

I spent all of last night trying to figure out what Aadar could've wanted to talk about. Did he want to cancel the bet? Had he sobered up and realised that it had been a completely ridiculous idea? I secretly hoped not. Even though I knew it was immature and silly, the bet had given me a strange rush of adrenaline. I'd woken up the day after the event in high spirits, determined to find my soulmate, even if it was to spite another man.

Of course, I hadn't had much luck. I had swiped relentlessly through the weekend, looking for qualities instead of pointing out flaws, and even then, I couldn't find a worthy enough prospect. The only dude I had matched with had not bothered to start the conversation, and my pride forbade me from sending the first text. So that was that.

By the time Tuesday morning rolled around, I'd prepared myself for the worst – Aadar was going to back out of the bet, and I'd have no choice but to go back to my predictable dating life.

Meh, whatever.

'Did you book the conference room?' Pooja rang me on the intercom ten minutes before the Stellar Spirits team was scheduled to show up.

'Yep. We can head there now, if you want,' I spoke into the phone.

'I'll be there in a few. You and Ryan go ahead,' she said before hanging up.

I scooped up my laptop and notebook, wiggling my hips as I got up to ensure my georgette long skirt wasn't tucked inside my butt crack. When I got to Ryan's desk, he was watching a prank compilation video on YouTube – without earphones. For someone who was neither exceptionally good at his job nor incredibly hard-working, he displayed an admirable amount of confidence in the workplace.

'Ryan,' I said, tapping his shoulder to get his attention, 'it's time for the meeting.'

'What meeting?' he asked sheepishly, hitting pause on his laptop keypad.

I had to resist the urge to roll my eyes. ‘The Stellar Spirits team is coming down ... remember?’

‘Oooh, right. I’d almost forgotten,’ he said, looking up at me with a smile.

No, Ryan, you had forgotten.

When he continued to sit there without any sign of urgency, I began tapping my feet on the tiled floor, hoping he’d get the hint.

‘Right, well, I’ll meet you in there,’ he said, giving me another smile before he turned back to finish his video.

I did roll my eyes then.

The conference room was occupied by a group of sales team hoggers when I got there. I tapped my imaginary watch from outside the glass doors, indicating it was time for them to leave. After what seemed to be ages, they began to shuffle out one by one.

‘Sorry, sorry, Ananya. Meeting ran long,’ said Rahul, the newly appointed head of the sales department.

I could bet he hadn’t even made a reservation for the previous time slot.

‘No worries,’ I said politely and made my way inside.

The room was freezing, the chairs were scattered around and someone had left a half-eaten sandwich on the conference table. Ryan showed up precisely two seconds after I’d finished rearranging and cleaning up, and Pooja arrived shortly after.

‘They’re not here yet?’ she asked as she set her laptop down on the long glass table.

‘They’re coming up. I just got a call from security,’ I said, pointing to the intercom at the centre of the table.

Pooja nodded at me, then turned to Ryan for help connecting her laptop to the projector. She was going to present the Best Man idea to Stellar Spirits in the hopes that they’d want to come on board as the bar sponsors. The car launch had been nothing but a trial run, and since it had gone well, there was a good chance they’d want to partner with us for a much larger project.

‘Here they come,’ Ryan said under his breath as three male figures appeared in the doorway. An office boy showed them inside the room.

Aadar was the last to enter. The two men before him were much older, probably in their late forties or early fifties. All three of them wore pastel

shirts and black trousers. It was too hot for blazers, or I was certain they would've thrown them on. In front of these formally clad men, Pooja, Ryan and I looked like we were going for a college picnic.

Pooja welcomed them warmly, shaking their hands and introducing us. I wondered if she'd met them before or if she'd stalked them on LinkedIn to figure out who was who, aside from Aadar, who she must've met at the launch party. Ryan moved closer to the projector to assist Pooja with the presentation, and as a result, the four remaining attendees sat facing each other on either side of the table. Aadar wound up sitting next to me.

'I have to say, I'm kind of jealous I couldn't make it the other night,' said Samar, the oldest and presumably the senior most of the three. 'Aadar couldn't stop raving about the party.'

'That's very kind of you, Aadar. We were very happy to host you,' said Pooja as she took a seat closest to the projector screen. To Samar, she said cheerfully, 'There's always a next time.'

That's exactly why we all were here – to ensure there would be one.

'What will you guys have? Tea, coffee?' asked Pooja, ready to dial in their orders on the intercom.

We indulged in some small talk as we waited for the beverages, a designated period of unimportant chatter before we jumped into business. I was acutely aware of Aadar's presence next to me, and at times, I could feel him looking at me from the corner of my eye.

After a while, I felt something drop into my lap. I looked down to discover a folded piece of paper. Carefully, without making a sound or appearing distracted, I opened it up.

Found 'The One' yet?

I threw a peripheral glare at him, and he had to place a hand in front of his mouth to hide his grin.

'So, what is the project you wanted to tell us about?' Hari, the other older guy, asked after the coffee had been served.

'Right,' said Pooja, getting up to address the room. 'Let's get right to it.'

The screen lit up with the opening slide of the presentation I'd made a few days ago. 'Best Man' flashed in a cursive font, with red and gold detailing in the background. Next to me, I sensed Aadar leaning forward for a better view.

Pooja went on to explain the concept for the next thirty-five minutes, taking a few breaks as and when the team interrupted with questions.

‘That’s quite the idea,’ Aadar said when the presentation was over.

‘Yeah, it’s definitely “out of the box”,’ Samar said, making little air quotes with his fingers.

‘Maybe too out of the box?’ Hari shifted in his seat. His eyebrows were furrowed in doubt.

Involuntarily, I frowned. *Who was this old, boring man to shit on my idea?*

‘Well, that’s for you to decide,’ Pooja said diplomatically. Then she added, ‘But we’ve got the go-ahead from International and we’ll be looking at finalising the sponsors this month.’

‘I think it’s an interesting take on content around weddings. People will eat it up,’ Aadar said, and I felt a strange surge of warmth for him.

‘I agree. But we have to analyse whether it’ll be good for business. Sponsoring alcohol for weddings of this scale is no cheap barter,’ Samar said, standing out as the voice of reason. ‘Give us time until the end of the week to get back to you?’

‘Absolutely, that’s not a problem,’ Pooja said, and Samar got up to shake her hand for the second time.

The three of them left shortly after, and I wondered if Aadar had forgotten about our lunch plan. I was contemplating writing him an email as I got back to my cubicle when my phone rang. It was an unknown number.

‘How’s the food at Café Hudkins?’ Aadar’s voice sounded different on the phone, more glazed somehow.

I leaned against my desk, laptop clutched to my chest with one hand, ‘How’d you get my number?’

‘I asked my brother,’ he said, and I burst out laughing.

‘Done? Now will you answer my question?’ he asked, refusing to partake in my delight.

‘It’s passable,’ I finally said.

‘Cool. Meet me there in ten,’ he said and hung up.

Aadar, unlike me, was not a picky eater. He picked out the safest thing from the menu (a red sauce pasta) within seconds of the waiter handing him the menu, who had to return twice to inquire about my order. Finally, I settled on a plate of garlic mushroom toast, a dish I hadn't seen before on Café Hudkins's menu.

The two of us were seated in a corner booth that overlooked the street behind my office. It was in the quieter part of Greater Kailash, a few secure kilometres away from the madness of the M-block market. If a few weeks ago, someone had told me I'd be grabbing lunch with Aadar Chauhan, that too voluntarily, I would've laughed in their face. Even now, I was acutely conscious of the oddity of our relationship, if you could call it that.

'The Best Man thing ... was that your idea?' asked Aadar as the waiter cleared the menus and poured water into our empty glasses.

Even though he had already expressed his interest in the idea, I wasn't completely at ease answering his question. I didn't want him to pick it apart once I confirmed that it had, in fact, come from me.

'Um, yeah. It was,' I said, feeling a lot less confident than I wanted to sound.

His face immediately broke into a smirk as he said, 'I knew it.'

'Why do you say it like that?' I squinted my eyes and raised my chin in his direction.

I liked to believe I wasn't an extremely defensive person, but there was something about this man that always made me want to take a step back and cross my arms. It was as if everything he said to me had a degree of mockery lingering in the background.

'It's just that,' he said and cleared his throat, 'for someone who claims to be so against the institution of marriage, you seem to be obsessed with it.'

I opened my mouth, lifting a finger to silence him, 'You either have bad hearing or a bad memory. Either way, you should see a doc.'

I did not have a problem with the *idea* of marriage. I had a problem with *his* idea of marriage.

He chuckled, taking pleasure in the knowledge that he'd ticked me off again. We continued to bicker about all kinds of nonsense until the food arrived, at which point he decided to bring up the reason for meeting me.

'So, I wanted to talk to you about the other day ... about the bet,' he said, some of the playfulness exiting his voice.

‘You want to call it off, don’t you?’ I said matter-of-factly.

He paused mid-bite, his fork full of pasta hanging in the air dangerously.

‘On the contrary, I’m quite pumped about kicking your ass,’ he said, placing the food in his mouth.

‘Like hell,’ I said, rolling my eyes. ‘So, what is it, then?’

My toast was dripping with mushroom gravy, and I shoved it into my mouth for a quick bite, only to discover that the bread was rock hard. A piece fell inside with a loud crunch after I used considerable force to bite down on it. Drops of the gravy splashed onto my face and I had to wipe it off hurriedly while Aadar silently observed me from across the table. If he wanted to poke fun at my clumsiness, he decided to shelve the opportunity for later.

‘I want to lay down some ground rules,’ he said after I’d set down the embarrassingly stained table napkin.

‘Hmm. And what might those be?’ I asked, pushing my plate away.

There was no way I was eating this crap. Noticing the apathy I’d developed towards my food, Aadar moved his plate to the middle of the table. I picked a fork from the cutlery rack and dug in. I made a mental note for later – it’s okay to order safe, boring dishes sometimes, especially when in such disagreeable company.

‘We must keep each other in the loop. You can’t just spring a boyfriend on me out of nowhere,’ he said.

‘So, what?’ I scoffed. ‘You expect me to email you minutes when I’m on a date?’

The corners of his mouth lifted ever so slightly as he said, ‘I’m sure that will be extremely entertaining, but let’s settle on weekly updates for now.’

‘And what purpose will that serve?’ I asked.

‘It’ll keep the competitive spirit alive ... knowing how the other person is doing,’ he said, looking me directly in the eye.

‘Fine,’ I said after a few seconds. ‘I’ve got a rule too.’

He placed his hands on the table and leaned back all the way, so his spine was touching the back of the faux leather couch.

‘We can’t fake it. If we find out the other person is fabricating their relationship, they lose face,’ I said, imitating his posture to show him I wasn’t backing down. ‘Along with the bet.’

But I hadn't accounted for the height difference between us, which meant I had to practically lie down to reach the back of the couch.

'You think I would marry a random girl for the sake of a bet?' he asked, chuckling at the ridiculousness of my posture as well as my statement.

'Honestly, I wouldn't put you above it.'

'Ha ha,' he said, his voice devoid of any humour.

'Oh, and one more thing,' I said, the wheels in my brain turning faster and faster. The adrenaline rush was back.

'What?'

'To win, we've got to make it official,' I said.

'How convenient for you. A wedding can take months to plan. That gives you far too much time to score a boyfriend,' he said, shaking his head.

The waiter appeared to ask if he could clear the table, eyeing my uneaten toast with slight disdain.

'Yes, please,' I said, unfazed.

I had half a mind to ask for a refund, but I didn't want Aadar to think I was cheap.

Once the guy had left, I continued, 'Okay, not a wedding. But at least an engagement or roka. I'm sure you'll be in a hurry to claim the girl as your own to protect her from other suitors anyway,' I said the last part with honeyed sarcasm.

'And what about you? How will you make it official? With an Instagram post?' he let out a dry laugh.

'Hey,' I said, lighting up. 'That's actually a pretty good idea.'

'Oh, come on,' he said, throwing up his hands dramatically. 'That's bullshit.'

I leaned forward, looking him straight in the eye.

'Think about it. An engagement is your way of telling your friends and family you've found someone and are officially off the market,' I explained, holding his gaze. 'That's exactly the purpose a coupley photo on Instagram would serve for me.'

He made a great show of thinking about it while we split the bill and got up to leave. His car was parked outside the restaurant, and I walked him to it, still waiting for him to answer.

'All right,' he said, 'but both of you will have to do it.'

All the guys I knew, even the ones that had been in long-term relationships, maintained radio silence about their love lives on social media. Instagram was all about football, aesthetics and art for them. Getting a brand-new boyfriend to put up an Instagram post about me would be laborious, if not impossible. But I knew from the way Aadar's jaw was set that this was non-negotiable.

'You've got yourself a deal,' I said, extending my hand to shake on it.

After he'd sped away, I checked my phone for the first time that afternoon. I had two texts from Pooja, the first to ask me where I was, and the second to inform me that she had emailed me this week's task list and was leaving for the day. It was only then that I realised I'd spent close to two hours on this lunch, without any idea of where the time had gone.

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Blast from the Past

EVEN THOUGH I HAD spent most of my life in Delhi, save for the two years I lived in Bangalore to do my post-graduation, I hadn't managed to pick up some of the key tactics and habits Delhiites were known for. I couldn't, for example, eat chaat off the streets without spending the entirety of the next morning in the loo. I couldn't hurl abuses at every motorcycle driver who cut in front of my car while I drove. And I couldn't, for the life of me, bargain.

'Bhaiya, give me a fair price,' said Vrinda as she ran her hand over the red silk fabric.

'I called you shishter, didn't I? I would never try to deceive you,' said the man with a thin moustache, sounding incredibly earnest.

We were in a sari shop in the bustling market of Lajpat Nagar, where I had been forced into helping Vrinda source fabrics for her mother's boutique. This was the seventh store we had visited this afternoon, and I'd warned my friend I wasn't willing to come out of it empty-handed. It was surprisingly less crowded than some of the other shops, even though it had an air-conditioner to give customers some relief from the dreadful heat outside. I sipped on my cola bottle with a straw as the two of them continued to bicker in good humour.

'Can you show me some material for the blouse?' V asked, shelving the bargaining for later.

'Shishter, give me five minutes. I have the perfect blouse for this piece, but it's in Chacha's shop,' the man said, hopping off the display platform.

'We're in a hurry,' she said, even though we both knew we were going to be here for a while.

'I'll be back before you know it.' He was already out the door.

There was no other helper in the shop, so we were left alone to chat. V reached out for the AC remote and lowered the temperature to 16 degrees, flapping the neckline of her cotton kurta to dry the sweat pooling on her chest.

‘Mom is going to flip if I don’t finish this off today,’ she said, taking the soda bottle from me for a sip.

‘How are the outfits coming along for that elaborate wedding?’ I enquired.

‘Don’t ask.’

‘That bad, huh?’ I asked, patting her shoulder lightly.

‘It’s just that this couldn’t have come at a worse time. You know we were just about to relocate,’ she said, stress-gulping the sugary drink she usually stayed away from. ‘The interior decorator also bailed on us.’

‘I’m sure you’ll find another one as soon as you’re done with this project,’ I said, consoling her.

‘No, I don’t think we’re looking. Now Mom wants to do it in-house,’ she said, then added, ‘which means it’ll fall on me.’

Vrinda was a smart girl, and she had a phenomenal eye for fashion. But when it came to channelling those design capabilities into space and architecture, she struggled. Her room, for example, was full of artworks, handicrafts, dreamcatchers and odd mementos from her many travels and adventures. It was like a gallery wall, but instead of being organised into one structure for effect, it was scattered all over – like children’s toys in a community play school.

‘You’ll figure it out,’ I said, hoping I sounded sincere.

‘Actually ...’ she said, placing the bottle on the wooden plank we were sitting on, ‘I was hoping you’d do it.’

The door jingled as a customer stepped inside, looking around to find someone to help her. She was carrying at least five huge shopping bags, all from different shops and brands. When no one jumped to assist her, she swiftly turned on her heel and left.

‘Me? I can help you, but I can’t do it all—’

‘Please? You’re so much better at that stuff than me. Plus, you’re always on Pinterest looking up inspiration that you never get to use,’ she said.

‘Hey! I do use them – for my events,’ I said, puffing up my chest.

V cocked her head to one side. ‘Really? When was the last time you designed a space for an event?’

She was right. The designing had gone out the window when we began outsourcing logistics a few years ago. Now my job mostly consisted of

supervising the process and managing the guest list. Not that I was complaining – it was way less stressful.

‘I have a job, V. Where am I going to find the time?’ I asked, trying to reason with her.

‘You can just tell me the things you need, and I’ll source them for you on weekdays. And on weekends, you can put it all together,’ she said, and before I could respond, she added, ‘I’ll pay you!’

I stared at her, taken aback.

‘I meant, I don’t expect you to do it for free ... it’s a professional, paid project.’

‘Then hire a professional to do it.’ I was cross, and she knew it.

I never liked discussing money with V, not only because we had considerably different financial backgrounds, but also because she couldn’t understand why it bothered me. Like two years ago, when she had turned twenty-five, she wanted to take a girls’ trip to Vietnam. When I told her I didn’t have the funds for it, she offered to sponsor me. She didn’t speak to me for two weeks after I turned her down.

It hadn’t always been like this. When we were kids, our differences didn’t take up so much space in our lives. We shared everything. We would swap clothes, lend each other books and video games and even trade our prized Pokémon cards, blurring the lines between what was hers and what was mine. Yet as we got older, things changed. She would spend her summer vacations travelling to Europe and Australia, while I stayed home and waited for her to return. Every birthday, she would shower me with expensive gifts, and on hers, I’d try to overcompensate for my pitiable budget with handmade scrapbooks. Once, during a school fundraiser, she effortlessly sold twice as many raffle tickets as me, tapping into her family’s extensive social network, while I struggled to meet my modest quota. These instances, though seemingly minor, began to serve as constant reminders of the growing gap between us.

‘Come on, at least think about it?’ she said, pleading with her eyes.

I was saved from the pressure of responding when the shopkeeper returned, panting from his journey.

‘Here, shishter. Look at this golden beauty,’ he said, climbing the platform so he could sit in front of us.

V spent a few minutes fussing over the texture of the fabric before finalising her purchase. The bargaining that followed resembled the 2008 Wimbledon final between Rafael Nadal and Roger Federer. In the end, V scored the final point, taking the trophy home.

Outside, we stopped at a sweetcorn stall to pick up a snack. We hadn't said much to each other since she'd offered to employ me, and I desperately wanted to make the weirdness go away.

'I'll do it,' I said, handing a hundred-rupee note to the street vendor in exchange for two criminally small cups of buttered sweetcorn.

Before she could erupt into a fit of excitement, I continued, 'But I'm not taking money for it. At best, you can give me a Zara gift card.'

V flashed a bright smile at me, clinking her paper cup with mine. We discussed how to kick-start the process as we walked back to the main road, where her chauffeur-driven BMW awaited us. The driver held the door open for us both as we got into the backseat.

'By the way,' V said when we were on our way, 'I have some news about *him*.'

The way she said it left me with little doubt about who the person in question was. V followed he-who-must-not-be-named, aka my ex, on Instagram to give me life updates about him – although only when absolutely necessary. I'd blocked him everywhere, knowing I couldn't stand the heartache of seeing him live his life, sans me. But that didn't mean I couldn't still keep tabs on him.

'He's got a girlfriend ... some white chick called Juliette.'

Juliette, really?

'I see,' I said, trying very hard to block the pang of jealousy I was feeling.

'Honestly, she's not even that pretty,' V said, her kind eyes searching my face for any sign of despair.

'I don't care. It's been forever,' I said, but we both knew I didn't mean it.

It's not that I wasn't *over* him. I knew I didn't want him back – not in this life, not even in another. But I found it hard to shake off the pain he'd left me with.

'Do you want to see the post? It might give you some kind of closure,' V said, placing a hand on mine.

‘Oh God, no. That’s a terrible idea. You’ve seen it and I know about it, that’s enough,’ I said, my mouth falling open in horror.

‘Okay, Annie,’ she said quietly.

The car ride to V’s house felt longer than it should have. She changed the topic soon after she realised I didn’t want to talk about *him*, but I was distant, my mind elsewhere.

‘What’s happening on the dating front? Swiped on a new cutie?’ she asked, infusing her voice with cheerfulness.

This would’ve been a good time to tell her about The Bet. I want to say I wasn’t sure why I didn’t tell her, but that would be a lie. I knew exactly why it was hard for me to come clean to V about something like this. She’d tell me it was a stupid idea, one that would almost certainly end in disaster. She wouldn’t understand the kick it had given me, and how I was determined to find a partner, even if it was to experience some fabricated feeling of victory.

And now, I had two people to beat – my original contender and the man who had broken my heart three years ago, who was now playing Romeo to someone else.

After aggressively swiping for three days, I realised I was going about this the wrong way. I was looking for a pool of cute, intelligent and eligible guys when the truth was I’d already interacted with most of them during my online dating career. Not only had I met and turned down hundreds of guys, but I’d also ghosted countless others without giving them a fair chance. It was time, I decided, to dig into the archives.

A Saturday night study of my past chats revealed what I already knew – I wrote nice guys off too soon. For example, I had stopped replying to a perfectly sweet guy because he insisted on having a phone conversation instead of texting. I couldn’t remember why, but I guessed it must’ve seemed like too much trouble at the time. Another chat had been abandoned after the guy had responded to my courtesy ‘How’s it going?’ with a 200-word long essay about his current well-being.

It’s not that I dated assholes – I stopped doing that after Mr You-Know-Who. But I didn’t pick the good ones either, believing them to be too

vanilla for my taste. In fact, I couldn't have gone on a date with more than five nice guys in the last three years. Today, I was meeting one of them.

Ajay and I had met about a year ago over a lunch date, and I had decided within the first thirty minutes that I wouldn't be seeing him again. There was nothing wrong with him, other than the fact that he was *too* nice. He was a perfect gentleman who brought me flowers, opened doors for me and insisted on dropping me home later. Even when I continuously bailed on him after our first date, he didn't show an ounce of disrespect or bitterness towards me. He resorted to silently liking every new post I put up on Instagram and occasionally responding to my stories. If anyone deserved a second chance, it was him.

'So, first date 2.0, huh?' I said, greeting him with a light hug.

He had picked a quaint Italian restaurant in Champa Gali, one that V and I had been meaning to visit for a few months.

'I hope this one leads to a second,' he said, returning my hug warmly.

The first thing I noticed when I sat down were the customised menu cards, napkins and coasters on the marble-top table. Mine had A.K. meticulously calligraphed in black ink.

I opened my mouth to say something but couldn't find the right words. My fingers drew circles over my engraved initials on the cloth napkin.

'Wow,' I finally said, 'this is ...'

'I just wanted to do something nice for you,' he said when I didn't complete my sentence.

He looked nervous, like he was trying to assess if he'd gone overboard. I forced myself to give him my sweetest smile, and he visibly brightened.

'It's amazing. No one's ever done something like this for me,' I said, then added, 'especially on a first date.'

'Well, you're worth it. I would know, I spent weeks thinking about you after our date last time,' he said, his dark cheeks flushing at the divulgence.

Ajay was a textbook good-looking guy. He was tall (not as tall as the giants from the Chauhan family though), dark and really quite handsome. He'd had a thick, well-groomed beard the last time we met, which he had now shaved off to reveal a dimpled right cheek. He wore a printed white and blue shirt with black chinos and leather loafers.

'Welcome, Ms Ananya and Mr Ajay. You are our special guests for the evening,' a well-spoken waiter addressed us at our table.

That's when I noticed the restaurant looked awfully devoid of customers. Besides the staff, we were the only two people I could spot.

Had he booked the entire place just for the two of us?

I pushed the idea out of my head, deciding that it was better if I presumed otherwise.

We placed our respective orders from our personalised menus and resumed chatting after the man had left.

'So, still with that men's magazine?' he asked.

'Website,' I corrected, nodding at the same time.

'How's it going? Any exciting projects coming up?' he asked, looking genuinely interested.

I told him about the Best Man idea and how I hoped it would shape up over the coming month. He asked me question after question, leaving no opportunity for a lull in conversation to arise.

'What's going on with your work?' I asked, trying hard to remember what he did.

'Ah, it's the same. Markets crash, markets rise ... no big deal,' he said and shrugged.

No wonder I'd forgotten. Stock markets vehemently bored me. Nevertheless, I let him tell me more about his office and the kind of work culture he hailed from, which was poles apart from mine. We talked all the way through the main course, without pausing to appreciate the spectacular presentation of the dishes we'd ordered.

The waiter appeared at our side to clear our dishes. He was followed by another guy who set down a gorgeous two-tier strawberry cheesecake on our table.

'Oh, I don't think we ordered this,' I said, ignoring the sugary goodness that was already exploding on my taste buds.

'I got it made for you,' Ajay said shyly, 'since you couldn't find your favourite dessert on the menu last time.'

Wow, I thought, *this guy has really gone all out.*

The waiter served us a slice each of the wiggly delight, before bowing out.

'How is it?' he asked me as I took a bite, his eyes sparkling with eagerness.

‘It’s ... unbelievable,’ I said, not knowing if I was referring to the dessert or the gesture.

Don’t freak out, Annie. It’s just cake.

‘I hope you don’t mind me asking ... but why didn’t we meet again after ...?’ he trailed off, uncertain how to broach the subject of his previous rejection.

I cleared my throat to buy myself an extra moment. ‘I think I just wasn’t looking for something substantial at the time ... and you seemed like you were.’

‘And now?’ he asked.

I couldn’t get myself to commit to a yes, but I bobbed my head in response. His face lit up.

‘You didn’t have to go to all this trouble ... I mean, this cake is big enough to feed a whole wedding,’ I exclaimed.

‘You’re worth it,’ he said for the second time that evening.

Don’t freak out. He’s just extra nice.

I shifted in my seat, unsure how to respond. I must’ve had an odd expression on my face because he threw his head back in a soft laugh.

‘Okay, okay. No more grand gestures,’ he said. ‘I promise.’

I sighed internally and managed a small smile before excusing myself to go to the washroom. When I returned, he was standing in front of the table, talking to a bunch of men dressed in red and gold band uniforms.

‘... leave it,’ I heard him say as I approached.

His smile faltered when he saw I was back.

‘What’s going on?’ I asked, looking from him to the five young musicians.

At that, one of the men strummed his guitar, and the other four began to count down from three. Before I knew what was happening, they broke into an a cappella number I was too stunned to identify. I shifted my gaze to Ajay, who was cupping his forehead with one hand and was too embarrassed to look at me. The group remained unfazed by the lack of enthusiasm their audience displayed. After what seemed like a few years, the song dissolved into silence. The man with the guitar waited a few seconds for applause, and after realising there wouldn’t be any, asked me if I had any other special requests.

It was official. I had freaked out.

‘I’m sorry,’ I said to Ajay, bending down to pick up my cross-body bag from the couch. ‘This just ... isn’t going to work.’

‘Ananya, this is all a misunderstanding,’ he said, lunging forward to take my hand in his. ‘I swear, I was trying to cancel this whole thing.’

From the corner of my eye, I could see the musicians looking at each other in confusion, trying to communicate telepathically. Should they stay? Should they leave? Or ... should they just sing?

I withdrew my hand quickly and hit him with my least favourite cliché. ‘It’s not you, it’s me.’

I knew that was a lie, of course. It was *definitely* him.

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All in a Day's Work

BOLLYWOOD HAS TAUGHT ME that a date at a carnival is a classic love story waiting to happen. Which is why I showed up in high spirits, ready for my personal SRK to win me a *Chalte Chalte* stuffed dog or buy me bangles while professing his love to me, *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham* style.

What I didn't know was that fairs aren't quite as exciting without dream sequences, background dancers and, well, the right guy. I had also failed to account for the possible heatstroke I might suffer from being outdoors in the dead of the afternoon. My oversized straw hat was trying its best to shield me from the angry sun right above us, but there was only so much it could do.

'I told you we should've come in the evening,' Gaurav said as he watched me dab at the sweat beads forming on my forehead with a wet wipe.

Gaurav was my second date of the day. I'd met a guy for brunch earlier, and I was meeting another one for a theatre play later in the evening. Some people would call packing three dates in a day overkill. I called it time management. Now that my Sundays were booked for decorating V's new boutique, I essentially only had one day per week to find myself a boyfriend. So naturally, I narrowed down my best options over the course of the week to schedule back-to-back Saturday dates. A dating marathon, if you will.

One of these guys, I had convinced myself, would be The One. I hadn't had any luck with the brunch dude, who turned out to be so painfully dumb in person that I had to wonder if I'd been chatting with someone else over text. I truly believed I could've managed a more engaging conversation with a housefly. Gaurav, I realised a few minutes into our date, fell on the opposite end of the intellectual spectrum. He was well-spoken, wore Harry Potter-style round glasses and talked like a Sociology topper from college, bringing up Marxism every chance he got.

‘Why don’t we get some ice cream to cool down a bit?’ I said, pointing to a dessert stall to our right.

The Fall Fest was taking place in one of the larger grounds of Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. Most of the area was occupied by small business owners selling their goods, and the remaining was dedicated to food stalls. There was a small stage in the lounging area, with no performer in sight. The music gigs, it turned out, would happen later in the evening, when there were more than twenty people present at the venue.

Gaurav paused at a second-hand book stall before we could reach the ice cream vendor. He picked up book after book, explaining some of their core social themes to me. I pretended to listen earnestly for the first few minutes, but when he began spouting gyaan on a copy of *Jane Eyre*, I realised just how full of shit he really was.

‘Have you read it?’ he asked. When I nodded, he launched into his analysis of the classic text by Charlotte Bronte.

‘People keep hailing it as a proto-feminist novel, but that’s nonsense. You know, Jane eventually marries the same rich guy who tried to enslave her as his mistress,’ he said, waving the second-hand book in front of my face.

‘That’s a pretty simplistic view of a deeply layered text with complex characters,’ I said, disagreeing with him for the first time.

Growing up, *Jane Eyre* was one of my favourite classics. I’d read it at least a dozen times, and it annoyed me that Gaurav was trying to discredit it so unsympathetically.

My comment took him by surprise, making it clear he hadn’t expected to be countered.

‘Complex characters? Come on. Jane is an orphaned governess who falls in love with a brooding rich dude, pretends to assert her independence for a while, but eventually comes back to submit as his wife,’ he scoffed.

From the corner of my eye, I noticed that the owner of the bookstall was eyeing us from where he sat behind the counter. I wondered if he shared my date’s pseudo-liberal views.

‘Submit as his wife? Mr Rochester is disabled by the end of the story. If anything, *he’s* dependent on *her*,’ I pointed out.

‘And so she’s going to spend the rest of her life serving him. How is that a win for feminism?’ he demanded.

‘You’re missing the whole point. She *chooses* to marry him and she *chooses* to care for him. Being financially independent, she’s no longer bound by her circumstances. She marries the “rich brooding” dude for love, and she has every right to,’ I said, crossing my arms to face my date.

Instead of acknowledging that there might be some merit in what I was saying, he retorted, ‘Where did you read that? Sparknotes.com?’

When I just stared at him, he immediately changed his tone. I wondered if he regretted his snarky comment because of the diminishing chances of him getting any action on this date. To move on, he began mansplaining a different novel. I glanced at my phone, praying for an emergency call to rescue me from this headache of a date.

After about seven and a half minutes, the man handling the store couldn’t take it anymore.

‘Will you be buying that one, then?’ he asked, pointing to the copy of *Crime and Punishment* in Gaurav’s hand.

‘Oh, I’ve already read it,’ he responded, holding out the book uncertainly.

I thanked the man for his time and placed the book back on the table. Gaurav’s intellectual narcissism didn’t surprise me as much as it irritated me. Vrinda, who had gone to the University of Delhi for college, used to complain about her encounters with such men. Now, more than ever, I sympathised with her. As we walked out of the bookstall and later, the fair, one thing became abundantly clear – Gaurav was not The One.

Fortunately, I had one more date lined up to take another shot at love. And I’d saved the best for the last – Varun, the theatre enthusiast.

But as luck would have it, I got stuck in a traffic jam while trying to cover the short distance between JLN Stadium and the venue of the play. When my cab finally pulled up outside the theatre, I saw a man restlessly pacing outside. It was Varun.

‘Hey,’ I said as I ran up to him, ‘I’m sorry I’m late. Traffic was mad.’

He smiled when he saw me, but the frown lines on his forehead didn’t disappear. He gave me a non-committal side hug.

‘Well, the play began twenty minutes ago. They won’t let us in now,’ he said, his disappointment clear as day.

I wondered if he was trying to make me feel guilty.

‘Oh shit, Varun, that sucks,’ I said. ‘Should we just head for an early dinner then?’

‘Wow,’ he said, his voice stone cold.

‘Um ... I already apologised, man. I obviously didn’t mean to be late,’ I said, a little irked by his intolerance.

It was just a stupid play, after all.

‘That’s not it,’ he said. ‘You don’t even remember my name.’

And without another word, he walked away, leaving me standing outside the theatre to unscramble my fuck-up. I had to open Tinder to figure it out – Varun was the name of the guy I’d had brunch with. The man I’d just unknowingly scorned was Vivaan.

Well. Shit.

Relatives in India have a superpower: they can always tell when you’re having a shitty day and know exactly how to make it worse – by showing up at your doorstep, unexpected and uninvited. Now, before I’m labelled as too modern to appreciate her own family, let me clarify. I love my family. I adore my grandparents, I enjoy the company of my aunts and uncles, and I even share a close relationship with most of my NRI cousins. The people I cannot stand are the distant kinsfolk who call once a year and show up once in three, always loaded with the same question: ‘So when are you getting married?’

When I rang the bell to my home, I expected to see the comforting face of my mother. I hoped she’d make me a nice cup of honey lemon ginger tea to take to my room, where I would spend the rest of the evening, uninterrupted. What waited for me on the other side of the door was a person I recognised only because of my inability to identify her – she was a mehmaan. A chachiji, perhaps even a mausiji or a taiji, who knew?

She enveloped me in a brutal hug, crushing me with the muscles she’d built by encroaching on innocent children’s personal space over the years.

‘Ananya beta,’ she said, pulling back to look at my face. ‘Look at you!’

‘Namaste ... Aunti,’ I said, failing to read my mother’s lips from behind her.

‘Aunti?’ she said, as a look of feigned hurt covered her features.

My mom stepped forward, saving me from the beast. ‘This is your Mathura wali taiji, beta,’ she said, then turned to the woman and added, ‘She keeps so busy with work these days, I worry she’ll forget her own mother.’

The two of them laughed, giving me the opportunity to slip past them. I nodded at my dad, who was sitting on the sofa with a man I assumed was my Mathura wale tayaji, looking so uncomfortable he might as well have been constipated. His expression was loud and clear: *Run while you can.*

I spun around, ready to leap in the direction of my room.

‘Beta ji, come and take a look at the card.’ Taiji’s shrill voice made my escape impossible.

‘What card?’ I asked, slowly turning around to face her.

She laughed as if I had asked the silliest question in the world. ‘Harshita’s wedding card, what else?’

Don’t ask me who Harshita was.

I congratulated the woman, forcing a keen smile onto my face.

‘It is your turn next,’ she blurted the customary line and directed the next statement at my mother. ‘You should start looking, you know. It’s so hard to find decent boys these days.’

‘Ji, that’s true,’ my mother’s tone was sympathetic, but her eyes were nervously flitting from right to left.

For a brief second, I truly felt for my poor mother. Caught as she was between the values of two different generations, it was difficult for her to assert her own beliefs. Her parents had taught her that girls had to get married at the right age and run their husbands’ houses. Her daughter had exposed her to the idea of a woman putting herself first, in and outside of a marriage. Her own life was a confusing mess of the two opposing schools of thought.

My dad and she had met in college and had been friends long enough to decide that they should get married. Their relationship was built on that friendship, but it was still not an equal partnership.

‘Sarita, can you get a drink for bhaisaab and me?’ my dad called out.

Mom hurried away into the kitchen, happy to run any and all errands that would save her from uncomfortable conversations.

Unfortunately for me, that meant Taiji’s undivided attention was now on me.

‘So, a pretty girl like you ... you must have a boyfriend,’ she whispered, nudging me in the ribs.

As you may have gathered, this was a bit of a sore point for me. I didn’t care for a random aunty’s judgment about the lack of romance in my life, especially today.

‘No, Aunty,’ I said as I fake-laughed and shook my head.

‘Taiji,’ she corrected, before continuing with her interrogation, ‘you don’t have to hide it from me ... I’ll convince your parents. I’m very pro-love marriages.’

I looked at her for a few seconds before answering. I had no doubt she would go back home to her circle of good-for-naught aunties and talk shit about me. So, I decided I might as well give them some real juice.

‘Okay,’ I said, sighing, ‘there is someone, but it won’t work out.’

‘Why, beta?’ she asked, her eyes glinting in anticipation of fresh gossip.

‘His family doesn’t approve of us,’ I said, glancing down at my feet.

She squeezed my arm tightly, taking a step closer to me. ‘They’ll come around. You just need to talk to them sincerely.’

‘We tried ... but his wife refuses to listen,’ I said.

‘Try harder, beta, this is your life—’ she stopped mid-sentence as it hit her.

I burst out laughing as her face contorted with annoyance and hints of anger.

My mother appeared at my side just then and began dragging me away, saying, ‘Don’t mind her. She’s got a strange sense of humour.’

I had the brief satisfaction of watching Taiji struggling to regain her composure before my mom shoved me inside my room.

‘What did you have to do that for?’ she demanded.

I knew she wasn’t mad at me.

I shrugged and said, ‘It was the quickest, and most fun, way to get away from her.’

She whacked my arm with her hand, but there was a hint of a smile on her face. ‘You’ll get me in trouble someday.’

And with that, she left my room, shutting the door tightly behind her.

I did a trust fall onto my bed, bouncing a few times before sinking into the thick spring mattress. I was exhausted, and while the short exchange

with my relative had lifted my spirits for a moment, I felt disheartened by the events of the day.

I looked around, wondering if Marie Kondo-ing my teenage room would offer me some solace. I had spent two years away when I was in Bangalore for my post-graduation. That's where I'd met my ex, who was a senior at the time. The first time I'd seen him, he was playing the guitar in the college cafeteria, just jamming with his cool gang of musicians. Looking back, the thing I hated the most was that the most important relationship of my life had been a complete cliché – a naive girl falls for a manipulative but charming musician, gets her heart broken and is never the same again. What a shame.

When I got back to Delhi from Bangalore, I decided to erase those two years from my life. I slowly distanced myself from all the friends I'd made in college, the ones I had in common with him. I slipped back into my old routine, old friendships and old room. I'd thought about redecorating quite a few times, but I always found a reason not to. Today, for example, I was simply too tired.

I browsed through my contact list, mindlessly scrolling through the names. For someone who had one friend in total, I sure did know a lot of people. Without meaning to, I paused at one name. Instinctively, I clicked on it and typed out a message.

What's the ETA for Mrs
Chauhan? 8:30 p.m.

He was online. I saw him typing for a few seconds before the screen went blank.

I tossed the phone as far from me as possible, a wave of embarrassment washing over me.

Why did I have to text and give him the upper hand?

My loud groaning was interrupted by the sound of my phone ringing. I got up on all fours to retrieve it from the other end of the bed. The screen flashed his name.

I paused for a second before hitting answer.

'Why are you calling me?' I asked.

‘Well, you texted me,’ he responded, unfazed by the non-greeting.

‘So text back like a normal person.’

‘Texting back and forth is so much woooooork,’ he said. His voice was deep and elastic, like he was stretching in bed.

I laughed at that and said, ‘Gosh, you really *are* very old.’

‘How old do you think I am?’ he asked.

‘Mentally or biologically?’ I teased.

‘Ha ha,’ he said flatly, ‘I turn thirty in September.’

‘Jesus,’ I said. ‘No wonder.’

‘No wonder what?’ he asked, and I imagined him crossing his arms defensively.

‘The big “Thirty” deadline is getting to you. That’s why you’re so eager to tie the knot.’

He chuckled and said, ‘You’ve got me all figured out, haven’t you?’

There was a pause. I rolled onto my side, clutching Mr Corny to my chest.

‘But seriously, what’s the update on that front?’ I finally asked.

‘Why would I give top-secret intel to the enemy?’ He was still chuckling.

‘It was your rule, remember? Plus, I’m offering you a barter with updates of my own,’ I said, letting down the competitive guard for a second before I added, ‘I’m no closer to finding a boyfriend than I was last week.’

‘Well, that sucks for you. I’m actually meeting someone tomorrow. Someone I think I’ll like,’ he said, and I could almost hear his annoying smile through the phone.

‘Of course you’ll like her. Or whatever front she puts up in front of her entire family,’ I said, rolling my eyes into my pillow.

I heard him gulping water on the other end. ‘I’m meeting her solo. For lunch,’ he said.

So it was like a date?

‘Let me guess. You’re taking her to a fancy five-star restaurant, hoping to impress her over an exorbitantly priced seven-course meal?’

He laughed at that, sounding genuinely amused. ‘We’re meeting at Café Bistro for a quick cup of coffee, actually. Although a seven-course meal does sound good ... maybe I’ll save that for when I’m planning to propose.’

Café Bistro was a small, casual coffee shop in the boutique-heavy designer market of Shahpur Jat, a few lanes over from V’s store. Somehow,

I couldn't imagine two strangers discussing the prospect of marrying each other in such an informal setting.

'So you've already decided you're going to propose to her?' I asked.

I knew he was joking, but alarm bells began ringing in the back of my head. I couldn't lose this bet. Not to this man, and certainly not this easily.

'I didn't say that,' he said, then added in a teasing tone, 'but who knows?'

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I Spy with My Little Eye

WHEN I'D AGREED TO decorate V's new boutique, I hadn't taken one thing into consideration: her mom, Kavita Aunty, could be a bit of a witch – pardon my French. V had occasionally complained about her bossiness over the years, but I think the respect and fear she carried for her mom prevented her from openly discussing the woman's she-devil abilities with me, which meant I was entirely unprepared coming into this.

'These just won't do, Ananya.' She was holding the pieces of fabric I had shortlisted for the couch. 'They're too patchy.'

'Well, the idea was to use patchwork to bring out the nature of the customised services you offer,' I said, trying again.

She shook her head, moving the sample book aside. 'Why don't you give it another go?'

It had been a long day of sourcing, assembling and facing rejection. The problem wasn't that V's mum didn't like my ideas, it was that she didn't like my ideas *after* I had put in the work. I doubted she'd even read the emails I'd sent her with reference links a few days ago.

'I could go check out that store in Sarojini Nagar for you,' V offered with an apologetic look on her face.

It was already 4:00 p.m. This side gig was turning out to be more exacting than my actual job. The idea of staying here alone with V's mother for a few more hours was terrifying. I'd choose a crowded market and a sweaty evening any day over it.

'Why don't you stay here and help Aunty sort through the rest of the stuff? I'll make a quick trip to the market,' I said, eager to get away.

I hugged my friend, promising to be back in a few hours with more fabric options. I'd fully intended to keep my word until I spotted a red Kia while walking away from the boutique in South Delhi's Shahpur Jat. I was fairly certain it was Aadar's car, seeing as Café Bistro was just around the corner. Without intending to, I turned left and walked towards the entrance

to the joint. It had glass windows that made it possible to see indoors, but the red and white awnings on the patio cast a shadow on the faces of those seated inside.

Even though I knew it was a terrible idea, I couldn't stop myself from pushing open the main door. I didn't know what I was hoping to achieve from this, but a strange curiosity had gripped me. *Was he going to be there? With her? What was she like?*

I just had to know.

I snuck inside, willing myself to be invisible. I was grateful for the pastel blue shirt dress I was wearing, which helped me blend in. Without wasting too much time walking around, I sat down at a corner table on the far end of the cafe. Then, hiding behind the wooden menu, I began my espionage.

I didn't spot them right away. They were seated five tables away from me, on the other side of the room, which was separated by the entrance door. He had his back to me, but I recognised his curls instantly. His frame was another giveaway – he was the tallest person in the room. But it wasn't him I'd come to see.

The first thing I noticed about the girl was the way she ate her sandwich. She used a knife and a fork to slice it into tiny pieces and stuck each one into her mouth at regular intervals. I wondered if that was how she always ate bread or if it had something to do with the bright red lipstick she had on.

She was a pretty girl. She looked young, perhaps twenty-three or twenty-four, and from what I could tell, she was confident and chirpy. She laughed more than a few times while I was sitting there watching them, making me wonder about what Aadar was telling her.

A waiter interrupted my little secret mission, asking for my order.

'Just a water for now, please,' I said dismissively.

He stayed there for a few seconds, and I had to smile at him sweetly before he finally got the message and left me alone.

Back at their table, Shruti had launched into a story of her own. Okay, I had no way of knowing if that was her name, but she looked like a Shruti to me. Her smile became broader as the story progressed, which, I'm not going to lie, was stressful to watch. They looked like they were getting along. And that was definitely bad news.

My phone rang just then, and I glanced down at it. It was Vrinda. She must have assumed I had reached Sarojini Nagar market by now. I declined

the call, hoping she wouldn't think much of it. I could be bargaining with a shopkeeper. The call could wait.

When I looked up from my phone, Aadar's table was empty. Panicking, I glanced towards the door and caught a glimpse of Shruti's daisy sundress leaving the cafe.

What had just happened? Had they left already? When did they pay the bill?

I pushed my chair back to get up and follow them outside, only to come face to face with Aadar himself. I hadn't seen him approaching me. He must've walked from behind the counter to get to me unnoticed.

'What the hell are you doing here?' he asked, placing one hand on his hip.

'Um, hi,' I said sheepishly, tucking a stray hair behind my ear.

'You're spying on me, aren't you?' he asked, his suspicion spread across his clean-shaven face.

'Pfft.' I blew a puff of air, then said, 'I was just in the neighbourhood, helping out a friend with her boutique.'

'I see,' he said and crossed his arms. 'That still doesn't explain why you're at the cafe I told you I was going to be at.'

I cleared my throat, feeling my cheeks turn red. There was nothing I could say or do – I'd been caught red-handed. Luckily for me, the waiter showed up again, this time to hand the bill to Aadar.

'Why did she leave like that?' I couldn't help but ask.

Aadar was silent as he retrieved a few five-hundred-rupee notes from his wallet. After the waiter had left, he looked up at me with a curious expression.

'So you *were* watching us,' he said.

I blushed again but didn't deny it. We walked out of the cafe together in silence. Outside, he pulled out a cigarette pack from his pocket and lit one. We stood side by side on the patio, watching people walk up and down the street.

'She wanted me to meet her boyfriend and explain to him why she was marrying a stranger instead of him,' he said as he exhaled the smoke, then added, 'I said no.'

'Uh ... *what?*' I exclaimed and burst into a peal of laughter.

'Yeah,' he said, shaking his head.

‘She said it was her boyfriend ... not her ex?’ I had to clarify.

‘Yeeep. She is still very much dating him,’ he said, his face blank.

I laughed some more, feeling a strange heaviness being lifted from my gut. I wasn’t going to lose the bet. Not today.

‘I hate how much pleasure you’re deriving from this,’ he said, keeping his gaze locked on the street, away from mine.

‘This really is the highlight of my day,’ I said when the laughter had died down.

He took a few more puffs from his cigarette before chucking it into the standing ashtray outside Café Bistro.

‘You know of one of my dating disasters. It’s only fair you tell me one of yours,’ he said, finally turning to face me.

‘I’m not sure if you should be calling this a date ... but sure,’ I said, shrugging innocently when he threw me a dirty look.

I knew I didn’t have to, but I decided to narrate the story of my date with Ajay, the Grand Gesture Dude. Why? Aadar looked like he needed a win and for some reason, I wanted to oblige him. And sure enough, his spirits visibly rose as I told him about all the silly, extravagant stunts my date had pulled. When I was done telling him about the a cappella group, he was so stunned he could barely speak.

‘Wow,’ he said. ‘Just wow.’

‘I know.’

‘You know, some girls would die for shit like that,’ he said, trying to sound earnest, but I could sense a tinge of sarcasm in his tone.

‘Well, they’re more than welcome to have at him,’ I said, waving my hand in the air.

He chuckled and asked me something I didn’t quite register, because I was busy looking at a BMW driving past us. To my horror, it stopped a few feet ahead of the cafe and out popped V. She shut the door behind her and began walking towards me. I realised I had five seconds to come up with an airtight excuse for why I wasn’t at Sarojini Nagar. It was far from enough.

‘Annie, what? Are you back already?’ she asked from a distance.

When I didn’t answer right away, she continued to navigate through the pebbled path to reach me. Her orange-heeled sandals bought me some extra time.

‘Uh ...’

‘I tried calling you. Mom had to leave for some work, so we could’ve delayed the trip ...’ she trailed off as she spotted the man standing next to me.

For a few seconds, the two of them stared at each other, both trying to piece the puzzle in their heads.

‘I know you ... we met at the car launch?’ Aadar took a step closer to V.

V nodded lightly at him before turning her attention to me. ‘What’s going on? What’s he doing here?’

I racked my brain for the right thing to say. I couldn’t possibly tell her I’d blown off sourcing for her mom’s boutique to spy on Aadar and his date. That wouldn’t make any sense to her, especially since she didn’t know about The Bet. And this was certainly not the right time to come clean about that.

A warm breeze had started blowing, which was throwing my hair all over my face from behind. V, who stood against the direction of the wind, had her wavy locks dramatically flying away from her face. She waited for me to say something.

‘My boss called a little while ago. I had to come back from the market for a meeting with Stellar Spirits,’ I said, pointing my thumb at Aadar.

‘Oh,’ V said, still sceptical.

I fully expected Aadar to rat me out. He had no reason to go along with my lie, especially since he had zero context about why I was telling it in the first place. I counted to three in my head, waiting for a miracle to happen.

‘I think it’s going to pour,’ Aadar said, directing our attention from the awkward conversation to the rumbling thunder in the sky.

As soon as I looked up, a fat droplet of water fell on my cheek. Two seconds later, we were being ambushed.

‘To the car,’ V shrieked, gesturing towards her vehicle parked not too far away.

The driver had already stepped out to retrieve the umbrella from the trunk, but I feared he wouldn’t make it in time to be of any help. I ran to the car and quickly got in, leaving the door open for my friend. But she wasn’t behind me. I peeped out to find her struggling to walk on the pebbles, hand in hand with Aadar, who was trying to help her get to the car.

By the time both of them ducked in, Aadar after V, they were drenched. They were also giggling. Sitting there on one end of the backseat, looking at

two attractive, tall and fresh-out-of-the-rain people, I felt like a third wheel in a ticklish romantic scene.

Don't be stupid. V has a boyfriend, I reminded myself. And this is Aadar, for God's sake. Who cares?

'I know you from somewhere, I'm sure of it,' Aadar was saying while he studied V intently as the driver got into the front seat.

'The car launch, like you just said,' I offered.

But neither of them was paying any attention to me.

'I followed you on Instagram a few days ago,' V said, and I felt a wave of panic rising in my throat.

Oh my God. V was going to tell him about how I'd stalked him on social media. And after he'd caught me keeping tabs on him today, he'd definitely think I was a creep. A major one. Why was she doing this to me?

The sound of her betrayal had stunned me into silence.

'I wanted to see who my best friend was being forced to marry,' she said. I hadn't realised I'd stopped breathing until she said those words.

'Forced to marry?' Aadar threw his head back and laughed, then added after he had regained his composure, 'So you guys are best friends, huh.'

'Yep, since school,' she said, leaning back into the leather seat so I could finally feel like a part of the conversation.

There was a loud honk from behind us. The driver turned his head to ask us where we wanted to go.

'My car is just around the corner. I'll walk,' Aadar said.

'Don't be stupid. We'll drop you,' V said, instructing the driver to turn the car around.

The street was too narrow for a U-turn, so we had to drive around the block to get to his car. The two of them chatted throughout the short journey, and I sank deeper and deeper into my seat as the conversation went on without me. By the time we pulled up in front of his red Kia, it had stopped raining.

'Well, it was nice to meet you, Vrinda,' Aadar bent down to say after he had stepped out of the car.

'Same here,' V responded, giving him a bright, warm smile.

'And you ...' he said, directing his gaze towards me for a microsecond, 'meh.'

With that, he waved a dismissive hand in my direction, straightened up and banged the door shut. My jaw almost dropped to the floor in indignation.

‘Oh boy, if looks could kill,’ V said when she turned to face me.

‘I hate that guy,’ I muttered bitterly.

‘I don’t know, I thought he was sweet,’ she said.

‘Of course you did,’ I mumbled under my breath as the engine roared to life.

I put on my earphones and pretended to sleep for the duration of our journey home. I would’ve taken the Metro back to mine instead of letting her driver drop me, but I didn’t want V to think I was mad at her. Because I wasn’t. It’s just that sometimes I felt a little bit ... jealous. I loved her to death, and I didn’t wish any hardships on her of any kind, but sometimes, I felt like life was *too* easy on her.

V was beautiful, rich, ambitious, talented, had a long-term boyfriend who loved her and always got along with people. Every single person she met adored her. She was perfect, and my own imperfections stood out loud and clear next to her. Take today, for example. The guy who’d been a royal pain in my ass for the last few weeks had met her, and she had managed to bring out the best in him. I may have actually *liked* him if I had met this version of him before. But no, the guy with the nice-to-meet-yous was reserved for incredible girls like my best friend.

All I got was *meh*.

Playing Hooky

WORKAHOLICS, I'D ALWAYS maintained, were pitiful. If you had to be addicted to something, why would you choose work? So the idea that I was turning into one was particularly distressing to me. But between the lead-up to Best Man's first wedding and V's boutique decoration, I was finding no time to breathe. The problem was, I didn't know which job I disliked more.

At the office, I found myself juggling different vendors' requirements, the exhaustive guest list and of course, the bride and groom's endless tantrums. Planning a big fat Indian wedding, I had realised, was no joke. Traditionally, the burden of orchestrating every detail fell upon the shoulders of the parents, particularly the bride's family. But over time, professional wedding planners had come into the picture to save the big day.

And TMJ's Best Man went one step further. We not only offered organisational prowess (with help from an outsourced wedding planning agency), but we also had the one thing every couple wanted in today's day and age – the ability to make their wedding go viral. Our promotional services included crafting captivating content to ensure that the wedding received the attention it deserved. With our finger on the pulse of the latest trends and our unrivalled expertise in curating unforgettable experiences, we promised to elevate wedding planning to an art form, transforming dreams into reality with effortless flair and sophistication.

Or at least that's how we had sold the idea to our first client, TV actor Harsh Khanna and his travel influencer girlfriend, Deepti Singh. They'd agreed to come on board, but with a ridiculous number of demands – and the list continued to get longer as we approached the wedding celebrations. The latest, for example, was that they wanted TMJ to do an exclusive print issue with the couple on the cover.

'We're not a print magazine, Harsh,' I'd had to explain to him for the millionth time.

‘That’s all right. We can get the magazines printed ... Deepti’s uncle has a printing business in Sonipat,’ he had said, looking at his fiancée with eagerness.

‘I’m afraid that’s not possible,’ I said, exhaling in frustration. ‘We are a digital-only magazine and that’s our USP. We can’t just change that.’ I knew he didn’t give a shit about our brand philosophy, so I added, ‘Plus, nobody cares about physical magazines these days anyway.’

‘So what do you suggest?’ Deepti had asked, placing a hand on Harsh’s shoulder to keep him from continuing.

‘Apart from the microsite we are creating for the event with interviews and wedding coverage, we can also shoot and release a digital cover with the two of you,’ I’d said.

‘Like a proper magazine cover?’ Harsh had asked, his interest piqued at the sound of my generous offering.

‘Yes, but a digital version of it. You can put it on your social media and send it to everyone you know ... it’ll be great.’ I saw my opening and launched into saleswoman mode.

‘Perfect. Let’s do that,’ Deepti had said.

I’d known I needed to take Pooja’s blessing before making any of this official, but I shook hands with them anyway. There was no reason why we couldn’t give them a digital cover – we already had an editorial photographer and a talented production and design team. So when I went to my boss for her approval, I expected little to no friction on the matter.

‘This is a bad idea, Ananya,’ she had said, her face buried in her laptop screen.

‘Why? We wouldn’t have to invest anything extra in it,’ I’d said, frowning.

‘It’s not about that. We’re already over-delivering. They’re beginning to think they run the show, not us,’ she’d said.

‘I mean, it is *their* wedding ...’

Pooja’s eyes had shot up towards me when I said that.

‘And we’re not their parents. We don’t have to give in to their every demand. This is a business deal, you need to make them understand that.’ There had been a slight annoyance in her voice, like she was losing patience with me.

I understood where she was coming from, of course. A line should have been drawn. But it had become clear to me in the last few weeks that people did not take no for an answer when it came to their weddings.

Amidst the whirlwind of preparations and negotiations, I found myself not just overseeing but diving headfirst into the intricate details of the event. Even though we had hired a reputed team of wedding planners to help pull off the event, I'd somehow managed to assume the role of one myself. It was impossible not to – none of the others carried the kind of pressure I did to make this work. This was *my* idea, and if it turned out to be a complete failure, it would be *my* neck on the line. So if that meant I had to be present in every vendor meeting and editorial interview, so be it. I could handle it.

But with the boutique work happening in parallel, things became harder than they otherwise would've been. Even that would've been a pretty straightforward assignment, had it not been for Kavita Aunty, who had made it her personal duty to make my life difficult. And although V was doing most of the sourcing while I was at work, I felt myself getting more and more frustrated as the project dragged on.

I spent all week (and part of my Saturday) slogging in the office, and the rest of the weekend at the boutique. By Sunday afternoon, I'd reached my breaking point.

'It's not working, beta,' V's mom was saying, 'I liked the lamps in the store but they don't go well with the wallpaper we have in mind.'

I had given up on selling my ideas to her, so the last few days had been all about testing out hers. Between V and me, we'd brought her innumerable fabric options, lighting decor, furnishings and statement pieces – all of which had been heartlessly rejected. She liked everything ... up until it entered her boutique.

'Okay,' I said, taking a deep breath, 'why don't you tell me what your vision is, again? How do you visualise the boutique once the work is finished?'

There was a pause. She exchanged looks with V, her face blank. I could see my friend wringing her hands under the table. The boutique was bigger than my living room, but with all the furniture options strewn about, it felt cramped. Or maybe it had something to do with the stifling of my creativity. Whatever the reason, I felt suffocated.

‘I really don’t know about all that. I just want it to look beautiful,’ she finally said, shrugging.

I sighed, looking away. I had two options: I could either keep at it until I had a meltdown, jeopardising my relationship with V’s family, or I could back out of the project now and well ... jeopardise my relationship with V’s family.

‘I’m sorry,’ I said after a minute.

Both women were peering at my face, confused.

‘I can’t do this. It’s taking too much out of me, and this is just not a good time right now,’ I said, my voice apologetic but firm.

I was spared some awkwardness when Kavita Aunty’s phone rang. She picked it up on the first ring and turned around, welcoming the interruption.

I picked up my backpack and headed for the door, with V hot on my heels.

‘Annie, we’ll figure something out. Just give it some time, no?’ Her eyes were pleading with mine.

She didn’t want to be left alone in this.

‘I’m sorry, babe. I just can’t,’ I said and walked out.

One thing you should know about me is that I’m a very punctual person. Not being on time gives me anxiety. I’m a firm believer in the mantra: If you’re not five minutes early, you’re late. Another thing to know about me? I hate latecomers. Apart from that one time when I got stuck in traffic (and forgot my date’s name), I’d never been late for a date.

Having said that, I’d been on enough dates to devise a range of what was acceptable for late arrivals. Category A comprised men who’d reach up to five minutes after the agreed-upon time. No problem. The men in the next category would show up to twenty minutes late and would still be forgiven, provided they had a good enough excuse – and a great sense of humour. Category C was reserved for the men who’d show up even later and were prime candidates for being stood up. Kartik, my date for this Sunday evening, had two minutes to go before he found himself in the lonely waters of Category C.

I'd come straight from V's boutique to this resto-bar in the narrow lanes of Hauz Khas Village, so I was already in an unpleasant mood. It had felt like the right thing to do at the time, but walking out on her and Kavita Auntie had left a sour aftertaste in my mouth. I sat by the bar, sipping the chilled beer I'd ordered, trying to analyse my emotions. I felt bad for abandoning V when she was clearly counting on me. But more than that, I was disappointed in myself for not being able to pull this off. I prided myself on being able to deal with clients – even tough ones like my friend's mother. I hated failure, and this one was no one's but my own.

I checked my phone again. It was 6:20 p.m. Kartik had officially entered the red zone.

If he shows up before I finish my beer, I'll hear him out, I negotiated with myself.

The bar stool next to me moved, and I looked up. Two men in suits were placing an order for their drinks: G&Ts. Neither of them looked like my date. The one closer to me smiled in my general direction, and I turned around to see if someone was standing behind me. Embarrassed, he took his drink and left to sit at a table with his friend.

Usually, I would consider it blasphemous to swipe while I was out on a date. But this was turning out to be a really shitty one, and it hadn't even begun. I opened Tinder and let myself window shop, hoping I'd find a sweet bargain. Just as I was finishing my beer, my phone buzzed with a message.

Something came up at work. Won't be able to make it. Sorry! 6:35 p.m.

I stared at the screen in disbelief. Had I just been ... stood up? The thought made me want to gasp in horror. In the last three years, I'd been on more dates than most people would go on in their entire lives, and I'd never been stood up. Not once. I'd been cancelled on, sure. But thirty-five minutes after the date was supposed to have begun? That was sacrilegious.

'You've *got* to be kidding me,' I said louder than I'd intended.

Next to me, someone cleared their throat. It was the man from before.

'You look like you could use another drink,' he said, pointing to my empty beer mug.

‘My date stood me up ... so yeah, something like that,’ I said, sighing loudly.

He raised his eyebrows as he leaned his right elbow on the counter, ‘Oh, Pranav? Yeah, he couldn’t make it,’ he said, then added, ‘but he sent me in his place.’

A smile found its way onto my face. ‘Well, you’re awfully late.’

His shoulders relaxed further at that. ‘I fully plan on making it up to you. Shall I start by buying you another beer?’

I considered this man’s offer. Sure, he wasn’t the guy I’d swiped right on. But he was kind of cute. Besides, I couldn’t help but admire his guts. I could never approach people at bars. I preferred hiding behind the comfort of dating apps. That way, I could meet five times as many people, and if they hit me with a terrible pick-up line, I could hit the unmatched button. It was safe, secure and easy-peasy.

This, on the other hand, was new. I hadn’t chatted up a non-virtual stranger in ages, probably since college.

‘Aren’t you here with someone, though?’ I asked, turning around to find a short, muscular man seated at their table.

‘Oh, he’s a big man. He’ll be all right,’ he said, smiling reassuringly at me.

He pulled the bar stool next to mine and propped himself up on it. I usually didn’t like beards on men, but it suited his long-ish face. I could see a hint of chub hiding behind the facial hair, but his broad chest and big arms drew my attention away from it. He was on the taller side, probably five feet eleven. His knees touched mine from where he was sitting.

‘So what kind of a fool abandons a pretty girl like you? Boyfriend?’ he asked, clearly hoping I wouldn’t answer in the affirmative.

I shook my head and said, ‘No one we need to talk about.’

He flashed me a dazzling smile. I couldn’t help but notice how magnificent his teeth were – even, perfectly aligned and blindingly white.

‘I’m Madhav, by the way,’ he said, extending a hand towards me.

‘Oh, you’re a shaker,’ I said, lightly shaking his hand. ‘I’m Ananya.’

His friend joined us a few minutes later. I suggested we could all go sit at their table, but Madhav bore his gaze into his friend until he told us he had to leave.

‘Nice friend,’ I said after he’d left. ‘Colleague?’

‘He’s technically my boss,’ he said, then added when he saw the surprise on my face, ‘We were in the same college before I joined his company, so it’s all chill between us.’

‘That’s pretty cool. I can’t imagine what it’d be like to be friends with my boss,’ I said, greedily sipping the beer that had just been placed in front of me by the bartender.

‘What do you do?’ he asked, stirring his G&T idly.

I was about to tell him when he interrupted, ‘Wait, can I guess?’

‘Go for it.’

‘You seem like the creative type. But I can tell you’re also fairly left-brained,’ he said, making a big show of doing some mental calculations before concluding, ‘You’re probably in marketing.’

‘Close, but no. I work in events,’ I said, offering him a consolatory pat on the shoulder.

‘Ah, damn,’ he said.

I listened to him talk about his work. I could tell that he really enjoyed it. He was a management consultant with a popular international firm. My brain automatically began computing the information he was providing me. He worked ten to twelve hours every day, six days a week. Even today, on a Sunday, he’d just returned from an afternoon meeting.

‘Your job must leave you with no time for anything else,’ I said tentatively.

‘Well,’ he said, taking a sip of his drink, ‘it’s been a few years since I found something worthy of making time for.’

Men will say pretty much anything to get into a woman’s pants. I wanted to give this guy the benefit of the doubt, but my past experiences told me he’d be no different from all the other MBAs I’d dated – busy, busy and always busy.

Hold on, I thought. I’m doing that thing again.

You know, the thing where I write men off before I’ve gotten a chance to know them, so they can’t let me down later on? Over the years, I’d developed a terrible habit of finding faults even where none existed. I was the opposite of Uday Chopra’s character from *Dhoom* – I would meet a guy and instantly imagine all the ways it could go wrong with him. In a way, my pessimism had worked for me. I hadn’t had a heartbreak in a long time. But

on the other hand, I hadn't found love either. Forget love, I hadn't even found a decent chap to date for more than a week.

And this guy looked pretty decent. Heck, he might even turn out to be boyfriend material – if I gave him a chance, that is. Besides, I had to remind myself, I needed this more than he did.

‘Another beer?’ he asked me.

‘Uh ... I think I should call it a night. Mom's expecting me home for dinner,’ I said.

She wasn't. I just figured that if Madhav wanted to run for the position of my boyfriend, he'd have to put some effort into his campaign. Having bottomless alcohol with him on the first date (was it?) didn't feel like the right card to play. I wanted to leave him wishing for more.

‘Where do you stay? Can I drop you home?’ he asked, leaning forward.

His face fell when I said the word Noida. I chuckled.

‘Don't worry. You're off the hook,’ I said, well aware that a South Delhi boy offering to drop me home all the way to Noida was the modern equivalent of Shah Jahan building the Taj Mahal for Mumtaz Mahal.

We split the bill, downed our drinks and got up to leave. He opened the door for me, and we spilled out into the street. My cab had already arrived.

‘Well, this was fun,’ he said.

‘It was,’ I said, motioning to my cab driver to park across the road.

And now, he just had to seal the deal. I wondered if he was going to chicken out.

‘Let's do it again sometime?’ he asked, and I did a mental victory dance.

Ten points to Madhav!

We fed our numbers into each other's phones and hugged goodbye. He lingered close to me for a second, and I knew he was trying to determine if he should kiss me or not. I don't know if he decided that the setting wasn't ideal or if it just wasn't the right time, but he didn't. Instead, he pecked me lightly on my left cheek and pulled away.

I smiled at him warmly before crossing the road to board my cab.

‘Where to, madam?’ the driver asked me.

‘Noida,’ I said.

I didn't realise I was still smiling until I saw the puzzled look on the cabbie's face.

‘There’s a lot of traffic, madam. It will take us more than an hour,’ he said, clearly unhappy with the trip he’d been assigned by the taxi app.

‘No problem,’ I said, unfazed by his attitude.

I was in a fantastic mood. This unexpected date had turned out to be the pick-me-up I’d so badly needed after my monstrous week. The fatigue from both my jobs had almost completely washed away. I had no idea that a little bit of flirting and a fair deal of validation could revive my mind in such a way. I no longer felt frustrated or bogged down. In fact, I could feel the wheels of my brain spinning at supersonic speed. I had half a mind to send Kartik a thank-you text for playing hooky. Instead, I picked up my phone and typed out a text to V.

Can I un-quit? I’ve got an idea.

8:01 p.m.

OceanofPDF.com

A Crafty Plan

‘**W**ALK THROUGH THAT WITH full force and tell me if it hurts,’ I said, pointing to the mass of kaleeras we’d just hung in the changing room doorway.

Saurav looked at me like I had asked him to jump off a cliff. When I didn’t budge, he sighed.

‘Come on, is this really necessary?’ he asked, turning to his girlfriend for support.

It wasn’t. I just wanted to mess with him a little. He had been disappointing my friend for quite some time now, and I wanted a tiny payback.

V just shrugged and said, ‘It won’t kill you, baby.’

It had been my idea to invite Saurav to our late-night interior decoration sessions, hoping that doing up a bridal boutique would help get his head out of his ass. He’d promised Vrinda he would propose when the time was right. That had been two years ago. It’s not like he didn’t want to marry her – he’d made it perfectly clear that V was the girl he wanted to spend his life with. And yet, he eluded the topic every time she brought it up by sweet-talking some nonsense into her. The worst bit was he refused to give her a timeline to work with. He could pop down on one knee tomorrow for all we knew, or fifteen years later.

Two days ago, he’d been cooperative while helping out with the boutique, if not enthusiastic. Tonight, he was plain grumpy.

‘Fine,’ he grunted, throwing me an ungracious look.

The kaleeras, which V had painstakingly sourced after a long day spent in the markets of Old Delhi, were to act as curtains for the changing room. We couldn’t find somebody to customise them, so we’d spent the previous night linking them together to achieve the desired length.

Saurav braced himself for impact, took a small run-up from a few feet away and dove into the sheet of jewellery curtains. He emerged a few

seconds later, rubbing his forehead lightly. His murderous look was fixed on me.

‘I guess we’ll have to tell the customers not to do that, then,’ I said, a giggle threatening to burst out.

But V beat me to it as she threw her head back and guffawed. I joined in. Saurav didn’t.

‘You guys are evil,’ he said, but his tone was warmer now that V had bracketed herself into my little joke.

I got up to give him a friendly pat on the back.

‘Now that *that’s* out of the way, will you tell us what this big idea is all about?’ V asked.

She was seated cross-legged on the floor, next to the sofa that had been delivered earlier this evening, still covered with cardboard and plastic sheets. We had spent three nights working at the boutique, without so much as a word from me about where this was going.

‘Don’t worry about that. Your mum will love it,’ I said. ‘Everyone will.’

The conviction I had on the outside wasn’t particularly mirrored on the inside. But I refused to let the voice of doubt drown out my gut instinct. This would work. This *had* to work.

‘Yeah but why can’t you tell me?’ V pouted in the way she did when things weren’t going her way.

‘Why can’t you trust me?’ My voice was low, my right eyebrow raised.

Saurav looked from her to me as the silence dragged out, as if he was watching a tennis match.

‘All right,’ she finally said, holding her hands up, ‘what’s next?’

I pointed to the wallpaper rolls arranged vertically in the corner and said, ‘Let’s get those up.’

From the corner of my eye, I saw Saurav glancing at his watch. I knew it was well past midnight. I wondered if he’d ask to be released from his shift, but he just exhaled and started walking towards the wallpaper rolls. Stifling a yawn, I got up to help him. These after-office sessions at the boutique were taking a toll on my body, but I didn’t care. If I wanted to make this project work, I had to throw myself into it, which meant finding time for it every day and not just on the weekends. Besides, I knew I only had until Sunday to give to V’s boutique. The four-day-long wedding celebrations for

Best Man would begin next week, and I couldn't afford to be distracted then.

We worked late into the night, climbing over each other to get the wallpaper in place. That's how I found myself dozing off at the office the next morning. I awoke to the sound of someone clearing their throat.

I jerked my head up from the desk, and saw Aadar leaning over my cubicle wall.

'What ... are you doing here?' I asked, trying to shake the cloud of sleep from my brain.

More importantly, how long had he been standing there?

'You've got a little ...' he said, pointing first to my face and then to his own mouth.

I turned bright red, wiping the thin line of drool from my bottom lip. When I looked down at my desk, I saw that more saliva had collected on the spot I'd rested my head on.

I quickly placed a tissue on it and painfully watched as it turned transparent with the moisture.

When I looked up, Aadar was watching me intently, trying not to laugh. But he didn't prolong my embarrassment further.

'We've got a meeting scheduled, remember?' he asked.

'To discuss the bar menu with the bride and groom, right,' I said, as some electricity finally reached my brain.

'Are they here?' he asked, looking around the office.

'I'm sure not. They're always an hour late.'

'And you couldn't have told me that? I had to leave an hour in advance to beat the traffic,' he said, his hands on his hips.

'Sorry,' I said, 'it slipped my mind.'

It genuinely had. The long days at work and late nights at the boutique had exhausted both my body and mind. I had done zero preparation for this meeting, but I knew it wasn't an important one. I was merely there as a mediator – the inputs had to come from Aadar and the happy couple.

'So what do we do now?' he asked, checking the time on his phone's home screen.

It was 12:45 p.m.

'We get coffee,' I said, pushing my chair back to stand up.

Instead of taking him to the pantry, I led him downstairs. We had time for *proper* coffee, not the astringent liquid we got from the coffee machines at work. I was heading towards the coffee shop across the road when I noticed Aadar wasn't following me. I waited for him to join me, but instead, he began walking to his left.

'Are you coming?' I called out.

He didn't say anything, just waved at me to come over.

'What now?' I mumbled under my breath before turning around to walk towards him.

He was now standing in front of a roadside tea stall that I knew had been on this street for years, and yet I had never fully acknowledged it, let alone tried to drink from it. In fact, I'd never seen anyone from my office enjoying a cup of tea at this tapri. A few people from the editorial team bought cigarettes from this guy, but even they'd go back up to the office balcony to smoke.

'Chai?' Aadar asked.

'Um, you can get tea there,' I said, pointing to our initial choice of coffee shop.

'I'm sure, but it won't be as good,' he said, then asked me again, 'so, chai for you?'

My eyes darted along the street, scanning for familiar faces.

'What, are you afraid someone will see you standing here?'

'Of course not.'

I totally was.

'Don't worry, I'm sure the fancy folks at TMJ won't demote you for enjoying an innocent cup of chai at the local tea stall,' he said, sounding amused.

I wouldn't put my money on it, I thought.

Tentatively, I extended my hand to take the glass cup he was holding out for me.

'Cheers,' he said, clinking his cup against mine.

The impact made some of the tea spill out, and I winced as the hot liquid went down my fingers.

'Oh, sorry,' he said.

'Can you ask him for a tissue?' I asked, holding the dripping cup away from my clothes.

He chuckled. 'It's not a Starbucks, madam.'

I turned to look at him, slightly annoyed. 'A piece of newspaper? A leaf? Anything to prevent me from wiping my hands on your crisp white shirt?'

He took a step back, mouthing, 'Whoa.'

Then, he retrieved a handkerchief from his left pocket and offered it to me.

As I took the soft piece of cloth from him, a small smile inadvertently found its way onto my face. I placed the tea cup on the stone bench next to the stall and wiped my hands. Just as I returned the handkerchief, my phone rang.

'Hey, you,' Madhav's warm voice spilled over from the other side.

'Oh, hey,' I said. 'What's up?'

'I was just about to leave from the office. I'll see you in around 30?' he asked.

'Huh?'

I pulled the phone from my ear to look at the time. It was 1:15 p.m. *Shit*. I'd completely forgotten I'd asked him to –

'Come over for lunch, right?'

I was conscious of Aadar's eyes on me as I spoke into the phone, 'Shit, man. An important client is dropping by for an impromptu meeting. I don't think I'll make it out in time.'

'Oh.' The exclamation was followed by a few seconds of silence. 'I'd moved quite a few things around for this.'

He sounded disappointed, even a tad bit accusatory. I felt guilty.

'I'm really sorry. It just came up,' I offered sincerely.

'No, it's all right.' The warmth was back in his tone as he said, 'I do want to see you soon, though.'

I turned around so Aadar couldn't watch my expression as I said, 'Me too. I promise I'll hit you up soon.'

When I disconnected the call, I half expected him to ask me who I'd been speaking with. I knew he was perceptive enough to know that it hadn't been a professional phone call.

Instead, he pointed at the black Audi A3 that had pulled up in front of my office.

'That them?' he asked.

I nodded just as Harsh and Deepti spilled out of the backseat.

Aadar handed the shopkeeper a twenty-rupee note and deposited our cups inside a large pan. We jogged our way back to the entrance of my office building, just in time to catch the same elevator as our guests.

‘Oh, hey,’ Deepti said when she saw me.

I greeted them both and introduced them to Aadar, who had communicated with them several times over email but had never met them in person.

‘You look different from what I’d imagined,’ she said, smiling up at him.

‘And what was that?’ he asked, smiling back.

Even though it was just us four in the lift, the space felt compact and poky. I was facing away from the three of them, towards the doors.

‘You know, like an old, balding man,’ she said.

‘Sorry to disappoint.’

I wanted to read their faces, but I couldn’t turn without making Aadar move from his place. I didn’t have to wait long. The elevator doors pinged as we reached our destination.

Had I imagined it or had they been flirting a little bit in there?

Just as I was about to discard the idea, I caught a glimpse of Harsh’s face.

He looked like somebody had just waxed his nose hair.

I couldn’t remember the last time I’d been this nervous about anything. The night before the big reveal of V’s boutique, I couldn’t sleep a wink. I pictured my friend’s mother scrutinising every little detail of the studio, that perpetual frown deepening on her brow. There was too much on the line for her to dislike what I’d done with the place. Vrinda had placed far too much trust in me, and I didn’t want it to be a waste. I’d gone with my gut. I’d taken a risk. And now, it was time to see where that would lead me.

On Saturday morning, I met V out front. She looked just as tense as I felt, and I realised that she had way more at risk than me – she’d never hidden anything from her mother, that too professionally. Nevertheless, she squeezed my shoulders in greeting and led me inside the boutique. Even though we’d spent the whole of last week doing up the space, it was a little

surreal to see it all come together. I just hoped V's mom would feel the same way.

'What have you told her?' I asked, removing the cloth covering the royal crimson two-seater sofa.

She helped me fold it and tuck it away. Everything had to be perfect, not a thread out of place.

'That you have some new plans to show her,' she said, then added reluctantly, 'she wasn't very thrilled about it.'

'I bet,' I said. 'I didn't exactly deliver the last time around.'

V's eyes were sympathetic, but she didn't deny it. 'But I love it now. I just hope she does too,' she said, sweeping her arms around.

By now, V knew what was going on, even though I hadn't sat her down and explicitly told her. She knew I was going with a theme, that I wanted to offer a big fat North Indian wedding experience to every bride before the actual wedding. She just didn't know how I was going to package it.

We spent the next hour double-checking all the arrangements, eyeing every detail and glancing anxiously at the clock. When Kavita Aunty finally arrived, I noticed that she wasn't alone. A young girl was with her.

'Who's that?' I stopped V before she could open the door.

'Muskan ... she's the bride we've been designing for. I think they're just stopping by before heading to the older boutique,' she said, her eyes flitting from the door to me.

'Uh oh.'

Okay, this wasn't in the original plan. But I knew I had no choice but to improvise. If I failed, there'd be an extra spectator, another pair of eyes to capture my defeat.

As the two of them entered through the door, V's words came back to me. *She's the bride we've been designing for. The bride.*

And just like that, I knew I had to sell my idea to *her*, not Aunty. Channelling my most agreeable tone, I stepped forward to greet them. I could see V's mom looking around in puzzlement, but I didn't give her time to get overwhelmed.

'Hello, ma'am,' I said, nodding and smiling at both of them. 'Welcome to Akira Couture.'

The confusion on Aunty's face dissolved for a tiny moment as she returned my smile. Muskan peered back at me pleasantly, and in a desperate

moment, I tried to communicate with her telepathically.

Please, please, be impressed.

‘What’s all this?’ Auntie asked, turning to face V, who was almost hiding behind me.

‘Your new and improved boutique,’ I said, with a confidence I didn’t quite feel. ‘Let me show you around.’

I led them to the sofa against the right wall, which faced a cushioned bench.

‘Before I begin showing the beautiful bride our collection, I’d like to tell you both a little bit about the design of the studio itself and how it seeks to symbolise the North Indian bride,’ I began, walking deliberately to the wall behind them.

‘Every inch of this boutique, be it this minimal mehendi wallpaper,’ I said as I traced a finger down the mandala borders on the wall, ‘or this mandap-themed seating area, is designed to give you a complete bridal experience.’

I walked over to the kalash-shaped side table next to where Auntie was seated.

‘We pride ourselves on borrowing from the rich Hindu tradition of the North, but don’t be fooled. We’re also modern, progressive and futuristic,’ I said, opening the doors to the kalash cabinet to reveal a mini bar.

V helped me pour two glasses of champagne as I continued my presentation.

‘At Akira Couture, we understand how special the wedding day is for any bride. And we are honoured that you have given us the opportunity to make it even more special,’ I said, pausing to smile broadly at Muskan.

V’s mom was looking around, taking in the space. I knew she hadn’t been expecting this. I just hoped I’d left her surprised, not shocked. Muskan, on the other hand, had her eyes fixed on me. She was listening to me intently, I realised.

‘The perfect bride deserves the perfect dress,’ I said and paused for a second, before adding, ‘it’s not your job alone to find it ... the dress must find you. And that’s where we come in.’

V handed out the champagne glasses just as I placed two tablets in front of each of them. For the next ten minutes, I let them browse through the presentation I’d worked on over the last two nights and in between breaks at

work. I'd digitised the bridal collection, with V as my model. I spoke at length about the customisation possibilities – how our designers would work extra hard to ensure every little detail was perfect.

‘Akira Couture is a safe space. We want you to know that we're here for you. We understand you. And we want to give you exactly what you want ... nothing more, nothing less,’ I concluded.

For the next few seconds, nobody said anything. My heart began palpitating, and I wondered if I'd totally blown this.

Then, Muskaan broke into light applause before raising her champagne glass in my direction. ‘That was so amazing. Wow.’

I thanked her, letting a little ray of hope seep into my chest. But I knew she wasn't calling the shots here. Kavita Aunty stood up, her face completely blank. The three of us watched in silence as she moved around the boutique, tracing her fingers along the wallpaper, pausing to inspect the ceiling of the modern mandap. She then walked over to the clothing racks, where we'd hung a few pieces for effect. I had to resist the urge to crane my neck to follow her to the dressing area.

V and I exchanged glances. Muskan excused herself to make a phone call and stepped outside.

‘What do you think?’ I whispered to my friend.

She held up her hand, crossing all four fingers and giving them a kiss for extra luck.

‘So ...’ We heard her voice before she emerged from behind the dressing area, followed by the sound of the kaleeras rustling. ‘Who authorised the funds for this?’

‘I did, Mom,’ V said, her voice unsure.

‘Without asking me?’ She was now approaching us with firm steps.

V turned to look at me as if asking me for help. ‘I ... uh, I took a chance.’

‘Hmm,’ Aunty said, fixing her gaze first on her, then on me. ‘Well, I'm glad you did.’

You are?

I had no idea I'd said it out loud until she chuckled, placing her hands on both my shoulders. ‘Yes, beta. I am glad. I like that you've given a sort of theme to the place. It's meaningful and symbolic of the business we're in ... and that's what I love about it.’

I didn't realise I'd been holding my breath until I exhaled in her face. She laughed again, and my heart rate began to speed up.

'So you like it?' I needed to hear her say it.

'I really do. Congratulations,' she said, and I heard V squealing behind her.

I'd done it, it finally hit me. Not only had I managed to woo the toughest client of my career, but I'd also decorated and furnished a space – a job I was *hired* to do. Without me, the little world inside this boutique would not exist. It was unlike anything I'd ever felt before. It was a feeling I wanted to share.

On my way back home, I put up a photo of the boutique on my Instagram story: Did the interiors for this beautiful space by @akiracouture. #FeelingBlessed

Within five minutes, I had two responses on the story. I read the first, it was from Madhav.

So proud of you!!

The next one was from a handle that had not previously entered my chats, @thisisaadar. I didn't even know he followed me.

Looks neat. Didn't know you had it in you.

My fingers automatically began typing out a response.

A compliment? You must want something from me.

I stared at the three little dots dancing on the bottom left corner of our chat box.

What kind of a man do you think I am?

I sent my text, then caught a glimpse of myself in my phone screen's reflection. Immediately, I stopped smiling.

You're the devil reincarnate.

A devil who carries a handkerchief in his pocket. I chuckled at the absurdity, forgetting that the chat box from Madhav was waiting for my response.

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Wedding Hells

I'D BEEN ON LOCATION duty since Monday, which meant I'd had the supreme pleasure of spending my days (and a quarter of my nights) in the shaadi ka ghar – or should I say, shaadi ka five-star hotel? For the first two days, I somewhat enjoyed being away from the monotony of my office desk. But forty-eight hours, five shoe bites and countless averted crises later, I would've sacrificed my promotion to go back to the safety of my cubicle.

The first event of the four-day celebration, the sangeet, was to take place tomorrow evening. While most of the guests were supposed to check in sometime in the morning, a few overeager ones were arriving tonight. Among them were Deepti's elder sister and her husband, whose editorial interview, I'd found out a few minutes ago, was scheduled for midnight. The woman had refused to do it at a more civilised time during the day, saying haughtily, 'It's my *real* sister's sangeet. I'm not going to have any time once the celebrations begin.'

Today was the only day I could've gone back home for a good night's sleep before the madness officially began. But I knew the editorial team would want me around for the interview – they needed someone to manage the tantrums. I pulled out my phone from the pocket of my jeans and texted my mom.

Late night today as well.
Don't make dinner for me.

3:03 p.m.

She'd be worried. I hadn't spent more than a few hours every night at home for the last two weeks. At first, I'd been busy decorating the boutique, and then, with the preparations for Best Man. My dad and she had tried to lecture me a few times, warning me about how I was pushing myself too far. I'd told them the same thing I'd been telling myself over the last few days: *I'm absolutely fine. I know what I'm doing.*

I didn't. Working on a wedding, I'd realised, was the same as running around like a fashionable headless chicken. You had no idea where you were going or what was going to hit you midway, but you had to have your shimmer on.

'Is it your wedding or theirs?' my mom had asked me when she'd found me raiding her wardrobe for saris.

Now, dressed in a short, printed kurta I'd borrowed from her, I was making my way to the third-floor studio room that we'd converted into our meeting space. The twin beds had been pushed aside to make room for the centre table, and the blankets had been tucked away in the wardrobe. This was a place of business.

The newest intern, Bhargav, opened the door when I rang the bell. All four members of the social media team were present, to my pleasant surprise. I'd been chasing them for the past week, and I was glad my passive-aggressive emails had yielded something now, if not sooner.

'Good to see you guys,' I greeted them, pulling the office chair from the desk near the flat-screen television.

'How's it going? All set?' asked Jinal, the social media manager.

I let out a low whistle. 'Far from it, really.'

'How can we help?' she asked, her voice sympathetic.

The others in the room – Bhargav, the intern, and the two other young men I'd seen around the office but had never interacted with before – were all new additions to the team. Up until a few months ago, Jinal used to handle TMJ's entire social media presence on her own, with the help of an ever-changing intern. But with our continuous growth in the digital space, it had become impossible for her one-woman army to win any battles, let alone wars.

'It'd be great if you could get started on the pre-event deliverables. ASAP,' I said, then added after a moment, 'like, yesterday.'

Jinal laughed and said, 'Your timelines are always crazy.'

I ran the team through the list of deliverables for the different sponsors, the most important one being the hotel. Lotus Royale was not only providing us with the venue for the various functions for the wedding, but they were also offering the family a hefty discount on all the rooms booked for the guests. Apart from that, they'd given us five free rooms for TMJ's

team from tomorrow until Sunday. We couldn't have asked for a sweeter deal.

'Are we sticking to the template – food, building exteriors and decoration shots – or should we have some fun with it?' Jinal asked.

'You can get creative with the content, but only after you have enough safe material. You know how these sponsors are ... they don't want to take risks,' I explained.

I gave the four of them some time to go through the list and articulate their doubts. They claimed to not have any, which of course meant I'd get frantic phone calls at the last minute.

'Let's reconvene before the wedding day to discuss the remaining deliverables,' I said, standing up.

I glanced at my phone as I walked out into the long, brightly lit corridor. It was almost 4:30 p.m., and I finally had some time to grab lunch. In the elevator, I pressed the button for the lower ground floor, where the hotel's coffee shop was. It stopped on the first floor, and in walked Preet, our in-house stylist.

'Oh my God, babe. Thank goodness I ran into you,' he said, gripping me by the shoulders.

He was dressed in an embroidered black-and-silver blazer, tight black trousers and silver pointed-toe derby shoes.

'Uh ... what's up?'

'My intern ... that idiot ... he completely forgot to pick up some of the pieces for Deepti's cover shoot,' he said. I wasn't sure if he was angry or alarmingly anxious.

'But ... isn't the shoot the day after tomorrow?' I asked as the elevator doors opened on my floor and we stepped out.

'Yes, love. But the bride needs to try them on *today* so we can send the clothes back for alterations.' The words continued to tumble out of him.

'Well, shit. Send someone?' I offered, fully aware of where this conversation was heading.

'I totally would, love, but no one's here. And it's all really expensive stuff, so I can't just send a rando,' he said, and I waited for him to file his request. 'Could you ... run out and grab it for me?'

'Why can't you go?' I was ready with my response. Unfortunately, so was he. 'I wish I could. But Deepti's bridesmaids are waiting for me in their

room. I have to style them for their appearances tomorrow.'

I opened my mouth and then shut it.

'Please, I wouldn't ask if it wasn't an emergency. The store will shut in an hour,' he said, hopping on his heels to channel his nervous energy.

I looked longingly at the coffee shop in front of me, my stomach silently rumbling.

'Besides, if it weren't for you, we wouldn't have had to do this cover shoot at all.' His tone was still friendly, but he was done pleading.

Damn. I hadn't thought he'd go there. I hadn't been able to go back on my promise of a digital cover shoot for Deepti and Harsh, even though my boss had all but threatened to fire me if I didn't somehow manage to scrap it. In the end, she'd given in, seeing as the couple were in no mood to back down.

'All right,' I resigned and said, 'but you're booking me a cab. I'm sick of explaining my cab fares to the accounts team.'

Preet clapped his hands together, his mouth wide open in gratitude. 'Thank you so much. I truly owe you one,' he said.

He walked me to the elevator, as if trying to send me on my way before I could change my mind. Once I was inside, he tossed me a set of car keys.

'Forget the cab, just take my car,' he said.

The keys hit my chest and fell to the ground. I bent down to pick them up, saying, 'I'm not—'

...*the best driver*, I wanted to say. But the elevator doors had already closed.

Actually, that's not the truth. I'm a textbook good driver. I always drive in the right lane, my speedometer never reads anything over 50 kmph and I don't overtake from the wrong side – in fact I never overtake at all. I'm cautious, I follow all the rules and I don't even hurl abuses at other drivers on the road. The problem arises at the end of the drive when I need to park my vehicle.

When I got my driver's license a few years ago, my dad tried to teach me how to park in new spaces. He'd take me to crowded markets, unknown office buildings and malls for practise. And for the most part, I did just fine.

But that was mostly because he'd tell me exactly what to do: *start steering to your right, now go forward and straighten up the car, okay now reverse*. It turns out that when someone isn't doing all the physics and calculations for me, my brain just can't figure out what to do. And after finding myself in one too many stressful parking situations, I decided to call off the whole thing. Ever since, I'd been taking lifts from my dad and V whenever I could manage it, and travelling in cabs when I wasn't completely broke.

So was driving a random colleague's Honda City halfway across the city a good idea? No, it certainly wasn't. Why did I do it, then? Maybe he deserved to have his car bumped, for coercing unnecessary favours from gullible, overworked colleagues.

When I entered Khan market, it was buzzing with commotion. I drove around the exterior, hoping to find an easy parking spot. But as luck would have it, the lot was completely full. The only empty spot I found was between two angled SUVs. I knew parking here required a certain amount of expertise, and even then, it'd be a tight squeeze. And yet, I decided to go for it. What option did I have? The store was going to close in fifteen minutes. I'd come all the way; it'd be silly to go back empty-handed.

I took a deep breath, put the car in first gear and went for it. Within the first two seconds, I knew that the angle was all wrong. The passenger side of the Honda City would definitely bump against the SUV on my left. So, I reversed the car and tried to undo the damage. Except there were two cars waiting behind me, and they began honking angrily as I tried to encroach onto their road space. I tried to go forward to let them pass, but somehow, I had even less space to proceed than before. I was stuck.

At first, I waited for a parking assistant to help me out. When nobody magically appeared at my side, I honked my own car a few times. Nothing. Seconds turned into minutes as I sat there, blocking the traffic and panicking wildly. The driver in the Range Rover behind me was shooting daggers at me through the rear-view mirror. A line of other drivers was waving and screaming at me to get moving. And all I could do was sit there, hyperventilate and pray that the ground would swallow me whole.

'Hey!' Someone had walked up to the driver's seat.

My first thought was that one of the angry drivers had come to harass me up close. But when my eyes focused on the man at my window, I realised I knew him. It was Karan, my OG Chauhan match.

I rolled down the window and said two desperate words: ‘Help me.’

He motioned for me to get out of the car, and I jumped at the chance of being rescued. He got in, reversed the car, did some sharp manoeuvring and less than thirty seconds later, the Honda City was snugly parked in its spot. The drivers who passed by gave me dirty looks, and one had a particularly annoying expression on his face when he took me in – like the past five minutes suddenly made sense to him because he’d found a woman driver at the end of it all.

‘Here you go,’ Karan said as he shut the door behind him.

I took the keys from him, feeling a rush of gratitude. ‘Thank you.’

‘No problem. It was a tricky spot,’ he said, shoving his hands into his Nike joggers. ‘What are you doing here though?’

‘Ah, I’ve got a work thing. You?’

We crossed the road and began walking towards the row of shops. Khan Market had always intimidated me. When I was in school, a bunch of my classmates used to celebrate their birthdays in the expensive restaurants here. Back then, no matter how much money I spent on their birthday gifts or my own outfit, I felt out of place and judged. These narrow lanes frequented by foreigners and the crème de la crème of Delhi’s elite represented a world I could never quite feel at home in.

‘I’m meeting a friend for drinks in a bit,’ Karan said.

‘Oh, nice.’ I wondered if it was a date, but guessing by the way he was dressed, I doubted it.

‘Is my brother going to be joining you?’ he asked.

‘No, why would he be here?’

‘You two are working together now, aren’t you? Besides, from what I hear, you guys do hang out a fair bunch,’ he said with mock sincerity.

I ignored his sarcasm and responded, ‘No, I’m just here to pick up some clothes. So, if you’ll excuse me ...’

I halted at one of the lanes that led to the inner market, where the store was located.

‘Oh, I don’t mind walking you. I’ve got some time,’ he said, motioning for me to lead the way.

‘So, what’s been up?’ I asked after a few beats of silence.

‘Oh, you know. This and that. Nothing as exciting as looking for a life partner to win a bet,’ he said, his tone casual.

Okay, so Aadar *had* told his brother about The Bet. Any doubts I had about their closeness immediately evaporated.

‘To be fair, I’m not looking for a life partner, just a boyfriend,’ I said, allowing myself a small smile.

‘Yes, my brother does seem to have the stiffer end ...’ he trailed off as a group of young girls in sundresses and short shorts crossed us, eyeing him flirtatiously.

I stopped walking and turned to face him. I wasn’t in the mood to take shit from someone who enjoyed the attention of teenagers, even if he had just saved me from a distressing situation.

‘I’m not forcing this on him,’ I said.

‘Oh, don’t get me wrong. I’m not blaming you. I actually love this whole thing,’ he said, taking his hands out of his pockets.

When I just looked at him in confusion, he went on, ‘Apart from the constant entertainment it offers me, the strange relationship that the two of you share is perhaps the first bond he’s made with anyone in a long time.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘It’s a long story. I don’t want to get you late for your work thing,’ he said.

I knew what he was doing. He wanted to see if I’d take the bait and unfortunately, I was too curious to say no.

‘I really do have to hit that store, like, right now,’ I said, pointing to the designer boutique across from us, ‘but we can grab a quick coffee after that if you’re free?’

‘Sounds like a plan. Meet you at Starbucks in fifteen?’ he asked, and I nodded.

And that’s how, a half hour later, I found myself sitting across the table from my former Tinder match, aka the brother of my former arranged marriage match. It was weird, to say the least. On the whole, Karan was still an insanely attractive man. But I couldn’t detach my focus from his individual features. His eyes, for example, were dark – way darker than his brother’s scotch-flavoured ones. His jawline was sharper, making him seem less approachable. His hair was straight and smooth, like his father’s. Aadar, I knew from the time his family had come to ‘see’ me, had taken after his mother in this regard.

‘My brother ... how do I put it?’ Karan said with a pause. ‘He, um, has a hard time making friends.’

‘He is quite disagreeable,’ I couldn’t stop myself from saying.

Karan let out a soft laugh before taking another sip from his cappuccino.

‘It’s kind of a recent development,’ he said.

‘Oh?’

‘Between the two of us, he was always the charmer.’ Karan leaned back, looking into the distance in a way that indicated he’d let himself slip into the past.

I sipped my own coffee, waiting for him to continue.

‘In school, in college, he was always front and centre. Teachers loved him ... strangers, friends, relatives, my parents ... everyone adored the shit out of him. And the girls ... don’t even get me started,’ he said with a chuckle. ‘I used to be so jealous of my older brother.’

He shook his head, a glum smile playing on his lips. ‘I never thought he’d need any help in that department ... let alone from my parents.’

‘What happened?’ I asked, placing my mug down on the table.

‘He got his heart broken,’ he said.

‘Oh,’ I said, then added in a low tone, ‘happens to the best of us.’

‘Yep,’ he said, then abruptly added, ‘except she died.’

It took me a few seconds to register what he’d just said. My mind began to race as I took it in, trying to piece this information together with the image of the man I’d known for the last couple of months. I thought back to the photo I’d found on his Instagram of a beautiful girl with no caption. Was that his ex? And had that been before or after ...?

When I didn’t say anything out loud, Karan continued, ‘Road accident. Four years ago. It was truly, truly terrible.’

‘I’m so sorry,’ I managed.

‘Yeah, we all were. It was heartbreaking to watch him. He stopped hanging out with his friends – their friends – stopped going out, stopped being his chatty, charming self. He’d just work and sleep ... in the apartment the two of them had shared,’ he said. He took a deep breath, then continued, ‘At first, we gave him his space. But when a whole year had passed, I couldn’t take it anymore. I convinced him to move in with me. That’s how we got our flat together.’

I thought back to the apartment I'd spent a night in after Saurav's party. Karan's room with the cartoon figurines, the living room with the suede blue sofa set, the washroom with a fresh supply of toilet paper and Aadar's room that I'd never gotten to see.

'I tried to set him up with some girls I knew, but he was genuinely not interested. Not in girls, not in friends, not in anyone.'

'Until ...?' I offered, trying to match this mental image of Aadar with the one I'd come to form.

To me, he had never seemed like a man who was running away from love. He was probably the only guy I knew who was so eager for it that he wanted to get married and start a whole new life ... with a stranger.

'Until my parents brought up the topic of shaadi one day,' he said, sighing. 'I'm sure they hadn't expected it, but he said yes. Instantly.'

'But why?' I asked, even though I had begun to form my own suspicions.

'I guess he was tired of being lonely. This way, he could start a family, have a wife, a few kids ... without ever risking his heart again.'

Touch and Go

I DON'T UNDERSTAND WHY women are insecure about small boobs. They're really quite a blessing. Think about it: they never attract disapproving glances from aunties (cleavage, who?), they go well with every outfit and no one notices if you ditch your bra. I, for one, considered myself lucky. Take today, for example. Instead of buying a suitable, overly expensive bra for the deep, embroidered blouse I was wearing with my pastel pink lehenga, I had simply decided to let my breasts be. It was economical, liberating and fantastically convenient.

The preparations for Harsh and Deepti's sangeet were in full swing, which meant I had spent yet another night not sleeping and yet another day not eating. I was amazed at my ability to get all dolled up, walk around in heels and pretend like I had everything together. I was operating on the fear of missing out on a promotion and, well, gallons of extra strong coffee. Pooja was on the ground with me today, which was both a blessing and a curse. On the one hand, I was grateful for her discerning eye. On the other, I was terrified of her because of it. With her present, there was no room for any kind of bullshitting. She'd noticed right away that the flower bouquets on every table were thinner than they were supposed to be. I had underestimated the requirement for daisies and had to ask the florist to break the arrangements into thinner bunches to cover all the tables. I half-expected my boss to call me out on my lack of judgment, but she simply nodded and moved on.

Throughout the day, she accompanied me to every major and minor meeting. She watched silently as I approved the content shot by the social media team, without offering her own opinion. She let me handle the fit that the groom threw when he found out that he would only have one costume change for the cover shoot and not, as he'd previously expected, a dozen.

'You're saying I'll wear the same clothes in all the photos?' he had said, placing a hand on his hip.

‘No, you’ll sport two wedding outfits. One will be grand and luxurious, and the other, a bit understated,’ I had explained.

His penthouse suite had been empty, save for the three of us. He was wearing a white kurta and Nike shorts, and looked extra comical as he paced the ridiculously large living room.

‘Seriously, dude. That’s not a cover shoot. That’s not even a regular photo shoot,’ he said.

I was conscious of Pooja’s eyes on me. If I’d turned to face her, I knew I would’ve seen a bold ‘I told you so’ plastered on her forehead. I’d let this man think he ran the show, and now he was taking me for a ride. He didn’t know how much pleading and convincing I’d had to do to get him this digital cover at all.

‘Look, Harsh,’ I said after a minute. ‘We’ve thrown in this cover as a gesture of goodwill. If you don’t want it, I can scrap it altogether.’

He stopped pacing and turned to look at me. I could tell he wanted to cuss at me. Perhaps even fling the coffee mug he was holding for effect. Behind the glamour, fame and wealth, Harsh Khanna, I had come to know, was nothing but a man-child. He was accustomed to getting his way, and on the rare occasion that he didn’t, a spirited tantrum always did the trick. So far, I’d let him win. But not today – not with my boss watching.

‘We need to get going,’ I said when he just continued to gawk at me. ‘You let me know what you want to do about the cover by tonight.’

‘Fine,’ he said, as we approached the door. ‘Two outfits are fine.’

I did a mental victory dance as we left his suite. When I turned to Pooja to share the moment, her face was blank. She was looking straight ahead, unbothered. My heart fell a little, and I wondered if I’d done something wrong. But as the day flew by, I began to understand the reason for her silent observation. I was being evaluated.

The sangeet was scheduled to start at 7:00 p.m. It was 6:40 p.m. when I finally managed to escape to my room to get dressed. A half-hour later, I entered the lawns where the function was set to take place, lifting the skirt of my lehenga so it wouldn’t sweep the floor. My phone buzzed in my hand.

Omwa. See you in 30.
7:12 p.m.

I'd decided to invite Madhav to tonight's function. Between the lead-up to Best Man and the boutique redecoration, I'd had zero time to meet him. We spoke on the phone every day, but we hadn't been on an actual date since I'd first met him. *I've never been with a girl busier than me*, he had half-joked, half-complained last night. *It's a short-term thing*, I'd promised him. I didn't know that, of course. I had no idea what lay ahead of me at work after this event. I could get promoted, handle my own team for branded events and never have a second to breathe again ... or I could get fired and have nothing better to do than sit at home and complain about how *he* didn't have time for *me*. Which outcome I preferred more, I didn't know.

I was looking down and typing out a response when I walked straight into someone.

Aadar's drink flew out of his hand, soaking my chest with what smelled like a single malt. The whisky glass fell on the ground, shattering into pieces. My phone dropped next to it.

'Fucking hell,' I exclaimed as I bent down to pick up my phone. Droplets of whisky were covering its screen, and I cursed some more as I wiped it on my skirt.

'Shit, sorry,' Aadar said, helping me straighten up.

'Watch where you're going, old man.' I brushed his hand away from my elbow and opened my clutch to find some tissues.

His eyes widened as he took me in, and without so much as a warning, he pulled me into him. The air left my lungs as my face hit his chest, with his arms wrapped around me. For a second, I was too stunned to do anything. I could only acknowledge the warmth of his body in contrast with the cold whisky that was splashed all over my torso, feel the tips of his fingers brushing uncertainly against my naked waist and smell the cologne on his suit, mixed as it was with the woody notes of his drink.

And then it struck me that I was glued to a client in the middle of a work event, in plain sight. I pushed him away with all the force I could muster.

'What the hell ...' I stammered, the blood rushing to my face. 'What do you think you're doing?'

My eyes flitted around nervously. What if Pooja had seen us? What kind of conclusions would she jump to? But nobody of note seemed to be in the lawns, save for a few waiters at the bar, who made no effort to hide that they were watching us.

‘You’re, ahem ...’ Aadar cleared his throat and stepped in front of me, blocking my view of the waiters and theirs of me. ‘You’re on display.’

He raised his eyebrows and pointed his gaze at my chest before quickly looking away. I gasped as I glanced down at my beautifully embroidered pink blouse, which was now almost transparent. The drink had seeped through the fabric and was sticking dangerously close to my boobs. And without a bra to act as an added barrier, the outlines of my nipples were out there for the world to see.

I crossed my arms over my chest and turned on my heel, scouting for the nearest exit. The archway that led to the hotel lobby was a few minutes’ walk away, and I could see some guests entering through it.

‘Over there.’ Aadar pointed to the partition between the tent on our left. He placed a hand on the small of my back, guiding me outside the lawns. He kept following me as I made my way inside the hotel from the east gate.

‘I’m sorry about your dress,’ he said in the corridor leading to the conference room.

‘Just ...’ I was fuming. ‘Shut up.’

My face, I knew, was bright red. I wasn’t sure if it was because of anger, embarrassment or both. Instead of trying to work it out, I kept my arms tightly over my chest and continued walking, consciously avoiding the eyes of anyone who passed me by. Ditching a dupatta, I’d decided that morning, would offer me more freedom to move around in the function.

What incredible foresight you have, I scolded myself.

‘Where are you going?’ he asked from behind me, struggling to keep up with my ghastly pace. ‘Your room can’t be down here.’

‘We’re not going,’ I said as I paused outside the conference room on the ground floor that we had converted into the fashion closet, ‘to my room.’

I pushed the door open, desperately praying for it to be empty. I did not have the patience to explain this to Preet right now, or worse, to a styling intern. But the room was eerily quiet – even the fashion team needed time to get dressed. A huge pile of clothes was covering the long conference table, and racks of clothes were scattered around the rest of the room. I bumped into a garment steamer as I tried to make my way around the table. A crumpled scarf slipped out of the pile, and I threw it over my chest to free up my hands.

‘Whoa,’ I heard Aadar saying, ‘what is this, a flea market?’

‘Sure, if flea markets sold couture,’ I muttered.

I continued browsing through the clothes strewn about, looking for something to replace my soaked blouse.

‘Are you even ... allowed to be here?’ he asked.

A few garment bags with Harsh and Deepti’s names were hanging from a rack. I carefully stepped around them, making sure I didn’t touch anything important.

‘Aha,’ I said, picking up a pink sequined blouse from the pile on the table. It was an elegant Anamika Khanna piece.

It might’ve been a little big for me, but I’d packed some safety pins in my clutch that’d do the trick. Plus, it was padded.

‘You’re just going to take that?’ he asked again, reminding me of his presence on the other side of the room.

I said crossly, ‘Well, you’ve left me with no choice.’ Then, looking up at him, I added, ‘Besides, I’ll put it back long before anyone notices it’s gone.’

‘And what if I rat you out?’ he asked, placing his hands on the chair across the table from me.

I turned to the clothing rack behind me and retrieved a black shirt. ‘Why would you do that,’ I said, handing it to him, ‘when you’re in on the crime?’

The white shirt he was wearing had a wet, golden patch around his abdomen. I tried not to think about how, not very long ago, my chest had been pressed against that very spot.

He let out a low whistle as he examined the shirt. ‘This looks expensive.’

‘Just don’t spill any more drinks tonight.’

My phone buzzed again, and I realised I’d forgotten to text Madhav back amid all this madness.

I’m here. Wya?

7:45 p.m.

I typed out a quick response, asking him to meet me at the lawns in ten minutes. When I looked up from my phone, I found myself staring at Aadar’s naked back. I watched, paralysed, as he slipped his right arm inside the crisp black shirt. The other half of his back was still in plain view, his muscles tightening as he moved.

‘It’s rude to stare,’ he said, his back still towards me.

I met his eye briefly in the reflection on the glass wall before quickly turning to my side.

‘It’s rude to undress in public,’ I countered.

‘This is quite private, actually,’ he said before facing me to button up his shirt.

My peripheral vision allowed me a glimpse of his chest. He took his own sweet time with every button, making it impossible for me to keep looking away. When I finally gave in and allowed myself to glance at him, he flashed me a grin.

‘Well, I’ll leave you to it,’ he said, gesturing to the blouse in my hand.

And with that, he walked out of the room, leaving me alone, sweaty and strangely breathless.

Heavy Petting

‘SO ... HE KISSED ME, finally,’ I said into the phone.
‘Who, Aadar? Oh my Gooood,’ V’s squealing forced me to hold the phone away from my ear.

I half sat up on the hotel bed, taken aback.

‘What? Of course not,’ I said defensively. ‘Why in the world would *he* kiss me?’

I hadn’t told V about our little encounter on the night of the sangeet, and how it had left me feeling strangely curious. But then again, there was so much she didn’t know about Aadar and me that it seemed barely consequential in comparison. This thing with him, whatever it was, wasn’t important. And so, I wasn’t committing a crime by keeping my best friend out of the loop.

Besides, it’s not like she tells me everything, right? It’s okay to keep some things to yourself.

I’d been repeating versions of this to myself over the past few days. I wondered if writing them down would make them more convincing.

‘Come on, he’s gorgeous,’ she said in a sing-song tone. ‘Besides, there’s definitely some tension between you two.’

‘Yes, actual tension. Not the kind you’re hoping for,’ I said as I rolled onto my side, burying my face in a pile of fluffy pillows, the type you only find in hotel rooms.

I’d spent the last three nights in this executive room, and yet, it barely carried any proof of my residence. My singular piece of luggage was tucked away in one corner. Before every function, I retrieved my designated attire from it and then packed it away. My make-up bag and straightening iron lay neglected next to the bathroom sink. The wedding madness had hardly given me any time to follow through with my beauty routine. On the night of the cocktail function, I’d had zero time to salvage my frizzy hair, so I’d decided to sport a messy bun. On the day of the wedding, I’d been so overwhelmed with managing the event that I completely forgot to do my

make-up. I showed up with bags under my eyes and no kajal, calling it my 'nude look' to anyone who dared to comment.

'Okay, whatever. So, who's the kisser?' V asked.

'Madhav, obviously.'

'Oh.' Her enthusiasm from before had fizzled out.

'You could at least pretend to be excited for me, you know,' I said, slightly stung by her reaction.

'I *am* excited,' she said, exhaling loudly. 'Tell me ever-y-thiiing,' she said, channelling her sing-song voice again.

And so, I did. I told her about how he'd brought *me* flowers, even though he'd come for someone else's sangeet. I loved that he'd waited patiently for me the entire night, never complaining when I abandoned him in a pool of intoxicated strangers, whether to manage a crisis or please a client. He'd been the perfect gentleman, so much so that he'd politely turned down my offer of crashing in my hotel room later.

'What? Why did he do that?' V sounded like she was offended on my behalf.

'He said he wanted to take it slow,' I said, dragging myself out of bed.

It was 9:00 a.m. the day after the wedding, and only one function remained between me and the promise of twelve hours of sleep. It was the reception tonight, an event where the bride and groom could finally let their hair down and have some fun. The TMJ team was also planning on doing their share of drinking and dancing, if the WhatsApp groups were any indication. As for me, I fully intended to leave the party the minute I could professionally afford to do so and enjoy my last night in this luxurious, barely used bed.

'Laaaaaaame,' she sang into the phone.

I chuckled as I made my way to the washroom. 'It's kind of sweet, okay? Besides, I'm just glad we've finally kissed.'

It was true that we'd only hung out twice, but we'd spent so much time talking over the phone that it felt weird there was no physical evidence to show what was going on between us.

'And how was it?'

'It was really nice. He's a great kisser,' I said, inspecting my skin in the shaving mirror.

After the customary follow-up questions, she blew me a kiss and hung up. I tapped my phone screen to check the time. There were ten short hours to go before the reception, and I had many precarious tasks on my list, the first of which was a meeting with my colleague Ryan and the hotel's head chef. The groom's family was dissatisfied with the food arrangement from the previous night's wedding and wanted us to make sure the dishes looked as good as they tasted tonight. At 12:00 p.m., I had to sit with the social media team to sort through all the content we'd gathered so far and ensure we hadn't missed any client deliverables. And just before lunch was the final leg of Harsh and Deepti's editorial interview. The writer wanted to get some insight into their post-nuptial bliss of half a day.

I sped through my day in zombie mode, formulating monosyllabic responses during interactions to conserve my energy for the evening. After three days of outdoor festivities, the heat was beginning to get to me. Tonight's function, however, was to take place in the ballroom, which meant I wouldn't have to overdose on my antiperspirant's fumes.

I wasn't sure if I'd gotten better at managing people or if the Universe at last was being kind to me, but the first half of the day went by smoothly. The chef graciously accepted our suggestions, and Jinal and her social media team had everything ready for me to go through. And when neither Deepti nor Harsh found something to be pissed about thirty minutes into the editorial interview, I let myself relax.

Zoning out of the conversation about the happy couple's excitement for their honeymoon, I gazed at the stillness of the pool water. I leaned back in my garden chair and let my forehead peek out from the shade provided by the beach umbrella at our table. The rays of the sun, though harsh, mirrored the faint brightness brewing in my mind. Over the course of the last week, I'd increasingly felt like I didn't belong. As captain of the ship, I often found myself bent over the deck, wondering if the hype was worth the seasickness. But now that we were nearing the shore, I could sense the anxiety retreating. I'd made it through in one piece, without any signs of severe physical or mental trauma, save the bags under my eyes and a few thousand fried brain cells.

This isn't so bad. You can do more of this, I thought to myself, less as a token of reassurance than as a form of persuasion. *It's going to be all right.*

My brief moment of peace began fading away when the voices around me started rising.

‘... every right to screen what you’re going to be writing about us,’ Harsh was saying, with his anxious bride fluttering behind him.

The writer from our team, Hina, was looking at the groom with exasperation. She had shut the lid on her laptop, which I gauged meant that the interview was over.

‘It’s an editorial piece, Harsh, not a branded one. You have to trust me. I’m not going to write anything other than what you’ve told me or what I have observed,’ she said, pushing her chair back to stand up.

‘I don’t care! You’re writing about me and my wife, not some bloody movie review.’ The aggression in his voice took us all by surprise.

I got up from my chair, stepping between Hina and Harsh with my arm extended towards the groom.

‘Okay, let’s all take a breath here,’ I said, looking them both in the eye.

‘You know how it works, Ananya, so maybe you can explain it to him,’ Hina said in a tone that suggested this was below her pay grade.

From the corner of my eye, I saw Deepti tugging on her brand-new husband’s arm, who shrugged her off as though she was a housefly or some such annoyance.

‘Harsh, it’s not standard practice to let the subjects read their editorial pieces,’ I said, my voice firm but empathetic. ‘But I understand that this is deeply personal for you and Deepti, and so we’ll try and arrange for you to read the piece before it’s published.’

‘So when can I read it?’ he asked.

I glanced at Hina, who threw up her arms in the air, scoffing loudly. When I continued to look at her meaningfully, she sighed.

‘A week, I suppose.’

‘But we’ll be in Greece by then,’ Deepti spoke up for the first time, her voice tentative and unassertive.

In all my dealings with the couple, I’d never encountered a problem working with Deepti. She was hugely accommodating, the polar opposite of her overbearing husband. But I could tell Harsh didn’t appreciate it when she tried to create some room for compromise.

‘Exactly!’ Harsh said, grateful to his wife for the added ammunition. ‘You expect us to sit and proofread on our honeymoon?’

The more I tried to reason with them, the further the conversation got away from me. By the end of it, the groom stormed off, threatening to write to my boss, and his wife trailed behind him, offering me an unsaid apology with her eyes. Hina, on the other hand, was largely unsympathetic.

‘You’re on your own,’ she said, before walking away in the direction of the lobby.

I watched her disappear into the distance, my frustration growing with every step she took. What I wouldn’t give to be able to walk away from all this as easily as she had. It’s not that I thought this particular issue was extra complex. I’d dealt with bigger disasters since the inception of the Best Man, but somehow, this one was throwing me off a bit more than the others.

I sat down at the pool table previously occupied by the four of us and rested my head against the cold metal surface of the counter.

‘Uuuuuugh.’ My frustration escaped me in a sound of muffled agony. ‘Fuck him. Fuck her. Fuck this whole wedding. Fuck my job and fuuuuuuck my boss.’

I stayed bent over the tabletop, taking a few minutes to regain my composure in solitude. When I straightened up, I realised I was not alone.

Aadar was sitting across the table from me, watching me curiously.

‘Rough day?’ he asked, taking a puff from his cigarette.

‘What the hell, man?’ I demanded, scowling at him. ‘Are you a ghost or what?’

He had this extremely irritating way of materialising out of thin air, especially in my most inelegant moments.

‘I was having lunch at the pool cafe over there,’ he chuckled and offered by way of explanation.

The mention of food caused my stomach to make a loud, unattractive noise. I’d not been very kind to my tummy in the past few days, and it sounded like it was ready to rebel.

‘I don’t remember the last time I ate lunch at lunchtime,’ I mumbled, patting my stomach in consolation.

‘Hard worker, huh,’ he said, taking another drag. ‘You must really like your job.’

That made me snort.

‘What?’ he asked.

‘Can I bum one off you?’ I asked, gesturing to the smoke in his hand.

He regarded me with a raised eyebrow. 'I thought you didn't like smoking ... or smokers.'

'Just give me one.' I leaned forward, snatching the box he'd placed on the table.

He didn't say anything to stop me, but I could feel his gaze on me as I brought the thin paper-wrapped cylinder of cancer to my lips. I lit it and took a deep drag – my first in two years.

'I think I hate my job,' I said, relying on the high of the cigarette to vocalise my inner monologue.

'Don't we all?' he offered. 'In one way or another.'

I shook my head. People around me had always despised their time at work. Vrinda bitched about her boutique because her mother didn't let her explore her own instincts as a fashion designer. Saurav loathed the work culture of his cut-throat multinational company. My dad resented his finance profession, dreaming of a life where a career in research would've been possible for a middle-class man like him.

But me? I'd always prided myself on following my dreams. When I'd first gotten a job at TheManJournal, I'd been over the moon. My excitement had nothing to do with the pay, which was passable at best. I was happy because I knew I would wake up every morning looking forward to going to the office. And for years, that's exactly what had happened. I liked my work, and I liked that I liked my work.

Aadar nodded as I vented, telling him how difficult it was for me to acknowledge that the enthusiasm I had for my job was waning.

'What about that interiors thing you did for your friend? Does that get you excited?' he asked, sounding genuinely interested.

'I don't know ... yeah, I guess,' I admitted. 'But it's not like I can throw myself into that. I have a career that I've invested in ... and I can't just give that up for a shot in the dark, you know.'

I expected him to lecture me about chasing my dreams, but he gave me a sad smile instead. 'I get that. Change is not easy to come to terms with.'

I returned his smile, wondering if he was thinking about her. The Dead Girlfriend. My mind conjured the image of the woman from his Instagram. I had no way of knowing if she was the same girl, but I liked to believe that she was. Simple, sweet and beautiful, she seemed like the kind of girl whose loss would throw a man off the idea of love forever.

‘So anyway,’ he said, pulling me out of the mental maze I was navigating, ‘what happened today that’s got you smoking with and venting to the enemy?’

I laughed at his characterisation of himself before answering his question. ‘This couple, man. Harsh, in particular.’

I started filing the many complaints I had against the groom, who had left no opportunity to make my life hell.

‘It’s a wedding, Ananya. People act a bit crazy in the pursuit of the perfect day of their lives or whatever. I’m sure you’re familiar with the concept of a Groomzilla,’ he said, shrugging.

‘But that’s the thing,’ I said and sighed. ‘I’m bending over backwards to organise and celebrate a marriage that’s obviously not going to last.’

That took him by surprise.

‘Why do you say that?’

I scoffed and said, ‘Haven’t you seen the two of them together? That man has no respect for his wife.’

‘Oh come on. We’re outsiders. You and I don’t know what their relationship is actually like,’ he argued, pulling his chair closer to the table so he could place his elbows on the counter.

‘Sure I do!’ I exclaimed. ‘I’ve sat in, like, six hour-long interviews where they talked about it in excruciating detail.’

‘And based on this information, you think they’re not meant to be together?’ he asked.

‘Yes!’

‘Okay, give me some details.’

I gave him a sickly sweet smile and said, ‘Of course not. That would be against my journalistic ethics.’

‘But you’re not a journalist,’ he countered.

The glint in his whisky-coloured eyes mirrored mine. I thought about how gossiping with a sponsor about a client would be considered a no-no in any corporate handbook. But then again, I was also involved in an elaborate life-altering bet with this sponsor, so my professional code was already compromised.

‘Okay, fine,’ I said, and he flashed me a grin.

‘For one, they met on Instagram. And everyone knows that no great love story starts with a “Hey Dear” in someone’s DMs,’ I said, then added,

‘that’s like the tackiest meet-cute ever.’

‘A meet-cute? What’s that?’ he asked.

I stared at him, aghast.

‘What?’ he asked when I continued to gawk at him in silence.

‘How can you be so out of touch with romance?’ I demanded.

He placed a hand on his heart in mock pain and said, ‘Educate me, O Queen of Love.’

I rolled my eyes before introducing him to the cinematic trope of a meet-cute.

‘It’s when the two protagonists of a love story meet for the first time. Sometimes it’s a silly stroke of luck, sometimes more. But it’s always special.’

Like when Raj offered his hand to Simran, who was struggling to catch a departing train in *DDLJ*. Or when Major Ram got roped into a college prank and sang a song for his chemistry teacher, Ms Chandni in *Main Hoon Naa*. Or even when Jack tried to talk a suicidal Rose off the edge of the Titanic in *Titanic*.

His amusement grew with every meet-cute I recited from the movies I’d grown up watching and re-watching.

‘And you think this happens in real life?’ He smirked at me and asked, ‘When was the last time it happened to you, O Queen of Love?’

I threw a dirty look in his direction, but his question evoked a long-suppressed memory in my mind.

I was in the cafeteria, talking to a fellow classmate about the band competition we’d just sat through. Colleges from around the country had come to participate in the music festival, and we’d flocked to the auditorium to witness the magic. As freshers, we had no clue what to expect, but that hadn’t stopped us from rooting emphatically for the four-person rock band that represented our college, Vandalism. That was until we saw them perform.

‘They sucked so bad, Tanuj. The acoustics were all over the place, the drummer had less energy than my childhood physics teacher,’ I was saying to my classmate as we waited for our order at the counter.

‘They weren’t that bad ...’ he said, looking nervous.

‘Are you serious?’ I asked, then continued to ramble, ‘They were terrible. And that singer? He plays the guitar really well but someone needs

to tell him he can't sing in public again. Like ever.'

When I stopped talking, someone behind me cleared their throat, and Tanuj took me by the shoulders and turned me around.

Standing there, looking half-annoyed and half-tickled, was the singer of the band. The same man I now call my ex.

The memory faded away slowly, and I pulled myself back into the present. Aadar was pulling out another cigarette from his pack. He didn't extend the pack towards me, and I quashed my craving before it could consume me.

'Mock all you want, but romance is real. It may not be common, but it is real,' I said, leaning back into my chair and crossing one leg over the other.

'Well, this has been fun,' he said, stuffing the lighter and smokes into his jeans, 'but I've got to go stock a bar for a marriage that won't last.'

I laughed, half-waving at him as he got up to leave.

'Go eat something,' he said, turning back to face me and gesturing with his eyes at the pool cafe a few feet away.

I smiled to myself as I made my way to the eating joint, oddly calmed by the interaction I'd just had. I knew I'd have to face it at some point, but for now, the frustration and anger from before had receded into a corner of my mind.

After a well-deserved lunch and two cups of tea, I was back in my room by 5:00 p.m. I had close to two hours to spare before the event. I laid out the black-and-gold sari I'd stolen from my mom on the bed and breathed a long sigh of relief. There was enough time to YouTube a draping tutorial, do my hair and make-up, and maybe even grab a bite.

And so, naturally, I decided to take a nap.

I awoke to the sound of my phone vibrating next to my pillow. I checked the time, it was 7:15 p.m.

Fuuuuuck, I grumbled before clearing my throat and hitting the accept button.

'Ananya? Where are you? I've left you like five texts,' Pooja said, sounding mad.

There was no way I could let her find out I'd been napping all this while.

I pushed the grogginess out of my voice and began. ‘Oh, sorry. I was wrapped up with something in the kitchen,’ I said, hoping she wouldn’t ask me more questions. ‘I’ll be down there in five.’

She asked me to hurry up, reminding me that all the sponsors and clients were going to be at the event today, and it was my job to socialise, flatter and impress. The wedding, at least for me, was no longer about the bride and groom. It was about the people who had made it happen. And I had to make sure they wouldn’t regret it.

I cursed loudly as I stumbled out of bed and picked up the sari I didn’t know how to wear.

How difficult could it be?

When I emerged from my room twenty minutes later, I had newfound respect for all the women who woke up every single morning and donned this unnecessarily long and laborious fabric. I knew I’d worn it all wrong – the pleats were uneven, the pallu was too long and there were extra yards of fabric that I hadn’t known what to do with, so I’d tucked them in inconspicuous places. I hoped and prayed that my generous use of safety pins would keep it in place. I wasn’t in the mood to compromise my dignity for the second time this week.

‘There you are.’ Pooja seemed visibly relieved to see me.

She was standing with two older men and one woman. I greeted them all with a smile.

‘You remember Samar and Hari from Stellar Spirits,’ she said by way of re-introduction, but I couldn’t recall which name belonged to which face. ‘And this is Samar’s wife, Chandra.’

Aadar appeared a few seconds later, bearing drinks for the current party of five.

‘Here, take mine,’ he said, before gesturing to a passing waiter to bring him another one.

I sipped the whisky as the six of us made small talk about the weather, the commute to the hotel and the ballroom decorations before finally moving on to the only thing that mattered – the success or failure of the event.

‘We’ve gone a little overboard on the budget, it seems,’ said Samar, as his wife excused herself to go to the loo, no doubt sensing that we were about to talk shop.

‘Oh?’ I asked, as I was hearing about this for the first time.

‘The groom’s friends extracted a few extra bottles from the bartenders last night,’ explained Aadar, catching my eye. ‘And I don’t think they intend to pay for it.’

‘I’ll look into it, don’t worry,’ I reassured them, adding this to the mental Excel sheet I’d been maintaining all week.

Samar nodded and smiled, but Hari continued to look sceptical until I promised to send an email detailing the exchange of the extra bottles. As part of the deal, Stellar Spirits was obligated to provide twenty bottles of whisky per event. If the guests happened to consume more alcohol, Harsh and Deepti would have to bear the cost. If you asked me, that was a pretty sweet deal.

‘Have you guys eaten?’ I asked the party. ‘I’ve heard rave reviews about the chaat counter.’

Golgappas, I’d learned, were a great pacifier. The burst of flavours, fuelled by the meethi and teekhi chutney, was all-consuming. Pooja and I walked over to the next set of clients after sending the Stellar Spirits team to gorge on street food. The senior hospitality manager of Lotus Royale, Mr Gupta, was sitting at one of the tables next to the bar. He and his wife were chatting with Harsh’s mom, who looked more dressed up than her brand-new daughter-in-law in her heavy green and gold sari.

We made a stop at their table to check in on Mr Gupta. Having sponsored all the venues as well as most of the food for the celebrations, he was easily the most important person at the party. Judging by the number of empty whisky glasses in front of him as well as the way he was beginning to roll his r’s, he seemed to be having a pretty good time. His wife, on the other hand, had not hopped onto the party train. She was cradling a glass of water, awkwardly smiling at whoever came to speak to her husband.

‘Can I get you anything to drink, Mrs Gupta?’ I asked her.

‘Oh, no ...’ She shook her head and said, ‘I don’t drink whisky.’

‘Some wine, perhaps?’ I asked.

She smiled. ‘I didn’t realise there was wine.’

There wasn’t. But for the plus one of our main sponsor? I’d stomp on the grapes myself if I had to. I pulled a waiter from the bar and instructed him to pop open a bottle of Pinot Noir from the private selection for the lady.

I spent the rest of the evening drinking with different groups of people, at first with Pooja by my side, and after an hour or so, without her. After having gauged that I had things more or less under control, she switched off from work mode and joined the office folks at what I called the ‘fun table’. The editorial writers, social media interns, stylists and sales reps were all huddled together, laughing and talking animatedly.

It was 10:00 p.m. when the magic of all that whisky started creeping in. I abandoned my glass at an empty table and replaced it with a bottle of water, knowing full well that the end of the night was not yet in sight. Finding a window between all the socialising, I escaped to the parking lot to make a quick phone call.

‘Hey, you.’ Madhav picked up on the first ring.

‘What’s happening?’ I asked him, leaning on the passenger door of a white WagonR.

‘Just came out for a few drinks with the office peeps,’ he said, directing my attention to the faint hum of music behind him.

‘Nice,’ I said, then added teasingly, ‘looks like you’re having plenty of fun without me.’

‘Please,’ he laughed and said, ‘this is all so I don’t lose my mind waiting for you to call me back.’

I felt a pang of guilt for not speaking to him all day. I’d meant to call him back earlier, but there had always been something more pressing.

‘I’ll make it up to you,’ I said, mentally pencilling him in for a date or two in the coming week, when things would’ve slowed down on the work front.

‘Let’s meet tomorrow?’ he proposed. ‘It’s a Sunday and you’ll be done with your wedding stuff, right?’

‘Tomorrow is a bit difficult. Vrinda’s boutique has a small launch party in the evening,’ I explained, wondering if he’d expect an invite after I told him.

But he only said, ‘Ah, damn.’

We spoke for a few more minutes before he admitted his friends were nagging him to hang up. I urged him to go have fun and promised to call him whenever I got free from the reception, however late it might be.

‘That didn’t sound like a Tinder date,’ a voice from behind me made me jump.

Aadar was walking into the parking lot, no doubt to smoke the pack of cigarettes he was holding.

‘Jesus, will you please stop being such a ghost?’ I said, placing a hand on my heart for effect.

‘Don’t change the topic,’ he said, narrowing his eyes. ‘Who was that?’

‘God,’ I said, ‘didn’t take you for the jealous type.’

‘Pfft.’ He blew out a puff of air and said, ‘I’m just making sure you’re not breaking rule number one.’

Right, we were supposed to keep each other in the loop. I’d completely forgotten about that with everything that was going on.

‘Okay, fine,’ I said, giving in. ‘I’m seeing someone ... kind of.’

Aadar took a drag of his smoke, observing me closely.

‘So you’ve got a boyfriend?’

I moved away from the car and slowly walked over to where he stood on the other side of the WagonR, enjoying the dreadful anticipation I knew he had to be experiencing.

‘Well, not exactly,’ I said and paused for a moment before adding, ‘not yet.’

He wiped imaginary sweat off his forehead. ‘Phew.’

I rolled my eyes at him, nudging him to move over so I could lean against the car next to him.

‘Okay, your turn.’

He continued to smoke his cigarette in silence for a few moments.

‘I’m “seeing” someone too.’ He made air quotes with his fingers.

I tried to ignore the instant change in the pace of my heartbeat.

‘Don’t be vague,’ I chided.

‘I’ve met the girl two times,’ he said, dropping the light and stubbing it out with his heel. ‘She seems nice.’

‘And you’ll marry “nice”?’ I asked, crossing my arms in front of my chest.

‘Why not? What’s wrong with nice?’

‘Nothing,’ I said, then shook my head. ‘Or everything. I don’t know.’

He chuckled, shaking his head. ‘You’re so weird.’

‘This conversation is making me want to drink,’ I said, pushing off from the car.

He caught my arm before I could step away. The warmth of his hand spread across my forearm, sending sparks down my spine.

‘Here,’ he said, producing a hip flask from the inside pocket of his blazer.

I accepted the flask from him, smiling down at it. ‘Why are you carrying a flask when there’s free booze at the party?’

‘So I don’t have to keep making trips to the bar,’ he said. ‘Plus, that is the free booze.’

I took a swig from the mouth of the steel container, contorting my face as the intensity of the drink hit my throat. He followed my lead, bringing the flask to his mouth. In the safety of the dark parking lot, I allowed myself to look at him. Watching him up close felt like he had a slo-mo filter on him. I observed the way his lips parted to welcome the whisky, how his Adam’s apple bobbed when he swallowed and the precise manner in which he wiped off the droplets on his chin.

‘More?’ he asked, offering the flask back to me.

If I’d been sober, I would’ve calculated the number of drinks I’d already had, the hours I’d slept the previous nights, the total amount of water I’d consumed all day and decided that I’d had my fill of alcohol for the day. But the whisky had begun to overpower the rational part of my brain, and I felt compelled to feed the addictive high I was starting to experience.

We passed the drink between us at regular intervals as we continued to stand there in the parking lot, neither of us suggesting that we go back to the ballroom.

‘My brother told me about your little breakdown in Khan Market,’ Aadar said abruptly.

I covered my face with one hand, feeling my cheeks turn hot. ‘I wish he hadn’t done that.’

I prepared myself for a mild roast, though I wasn’t sure if he’d joke about my particular ineptitude or the general incompetence of women drivers. Neither approach would’ve been highly enjoyable, but only one was acceptable.

‘Give me your phone,’ he said, taking it from my hand before I had the chance to oblige him.

‘What are you doing?’ I tried to snatch it back from him. ‘Give it back.’

He held the phone over his head, way out of my reach. He tapped my home screen, held it out in front of my face and smiled proudly when it unlocked automatically.

‘Seriously,’ I warned, jumping up and down like a child to retrieve my phone from his grasp. ‘Stop spying on me.’

‘Or what?’

My boozy brain came up with three options as a solution to my current predicament: stomp on his foot, bite down on his hand or hit him with my iteration of Shawn Michaels’ Sweet Chin Music. Before I could pick one, he handed my phone back to me.

A new app was open on my home screen.

‘What’s this?’ I asked, confused.

‘It’s a parking simulation game,’ he said, as if it was obvious. ‘It’s great for practise.’

‘Thanks, I guess,’ I said, unsure as to how to respond.

He shrugged. ‘I’m not a complete asshole, you know.’

I put the phone away, bewildered.

‘I don’t think you’re an asshole,’ I said after a few seconds, then added, ‘anymore.’

He turned to face me and put one arm on the car as he leaned on it sideways.

‘Oh, so my charm finally worked, huh?’

I met his eye earnestly and said, ‘Your brother ... he told me about your ex.’

There was silence. He looked away, and I had to strain my eyes to read his expression in the dark. The streetlight was casting a shadow over his face, and I couldn’t tell if he was sad or annoyed.

‘He should not have done that,’ he finally said, his voice merely a whisper.

I stayed quiet, unable to think of anything that wouldn’t sound disrespectful. After a few minutes of stillness, he took a long swig from the hip flask.

‘I need to tell you something,’ he said, still peering into the distance.

‘Okay ...’ I was grateful that he’d broken the silence, but his words had struck an odd sensation of nervousness in me.

‘Your sari has been sweeping the floor all evening,’ he said sincerely.

He caught my eye, and we broke into laughter together.

‘Like seriously, what’s up with this thing?’ He folded up the interminable pallu of my mom’s sari and held it in his hands.

‘Don’t ... ask,’ I said, a stream of giggles washing over me.

We stood there, the fabric of my sari in his hand, snickering like two people who had smoked too much weed. In the future, when I’d replay this moment in my head, I would realise that his joke had nothing to do with our unending laughter. We’d simply found a way to shed the tension.

And once the lingering strain had evaporated, we found ourselves staring at each other, breathless and unsure. I was suddenly conscious of how close he was standing to me – that if he merely tugged on my pallu, I’d be in his arms. Even though I was wearing heels, I felt tiny next to him. There was something disconcerting about the fact that he could see the top of my head, while I had to crane my neck to even get a proper look at his face.

I opened my mouth to say something, anything that would snap us out of this trance-like state. But the words refused to come out. The faint chirping of crickets faded away as we gravitated towards each other, somehow inching closer without actually moving. When the tip of his finger touched my cheek, I froze. My breath, which was coming out in short gasps, dried up entirely when he placed his mouth squarely on mine.

The warm taste of whisky gushed through my mouth as I parted my lips. Pleased by the invitation, his tongue curiously made its way inside, taking its own sweet time exploring the depths of my inner world. I felt his arm wrap around my naked waist, and in one swift motion, he lifted me up. He continued to kiss me as he carried me to the front of the car, where he proceeded to place me on the bonnet.

For a few seconds, my body was too stunned to respond. But soon, I felt my hands making their way around his muscular back. I pressed my palms against his lats, finally allowing myself to think about the glimpse I’d caught of them in the fashion closet.

I threaded my fingers through his thick, curly hair, grabbing a fistful. He abandoned my mouth to leave a trail of kisses down my neck. I could feel his breath getting hotter on my body, and I had to pull his face back to mine to keep myself from moaning out loud.

He yanked the pallu off my chest, and a small ripping sound whooshed from where it had been pinned to my blouse.

‘Sorry,’ he mumbled before leaning down to bite my neck.

An uncontrollable moan escaped my lips, and my head drooped back in pleasure. I cupped his face as he nibbled on the tender skin between my neck and my earlobe. I could feel his right hand circling my breast, tracing my nipple with his fingertips.

Gathering all the might I could find in my weakened body, I placed a hand on his chest and pushed him away.

‘Not here,’ I said. My voice was raspy, but my tone firm.

‘Where, then?’ he asked, sliding his hands down my arms to interlace his fingers with mine. ‘I can’t keep my hands off you.’

With trembling hands, I opened my potli bag and handed him the key to my room.

‘Meet me here in ten minutes,’ I said, hopping off the WagonR with his help.

‘Where are you going?’ He couldn’t hide the disappointment in his voice.

‘Don’t worry. I’m right behind you.’

Finding Pooja was not difficult. She was still at the fun table, merrily drunk with the rest of the TMJ team. They seemed elated to see me, but their excitement quickly dissolved into grunts of protest when I told them I was going to call it a night. Bloody migraines, I explained to them and waved goodbye, and slipped out of the back door of the ballroom.

Time seemed to slow down as I stood in front of the door to room 601. Every cell in my body was on fire. But when the door remained shut even after the second knock, I wondered if I’d been played. Had I taken too long? Had Aadar left? Had he changed his mind and not come up at all? Would I have to go down to the reception and ask for a new key?

Before my brain could come up with more alarming questions and scenarios, the doorknob turned. And there he was, towering over me in his sharp black suit, a delicious smile playing on his lips.

The Morning After

A GENTLE HAND ON MY shoulder roused me from my sleep. My eyes took some time to adjust to the light and recognise the face peering at me.

‘Hey,’ he said, standing next to the bed.

‘Mmmm,’ I mumbled, last night’s slumber still weighing heavily on my eyelids.

He bent down to remove a strand of hair from my face, pausing when the palm of his hand rested against my mouth. Instinctively, I kissed it.

‘I really have to rush right now,’ he said, gently withdrawing his hand. ‘But I’ll call you later and we’ll talk properly, okay?’

I hugged a pillow tightly, trying to hold on to the snuggly feeling I’d woken up with.

‘What time is it?’ I asked, as he sat down on the bed to slide his feet into his shoes.

The fact that he was fully clothed made me want to pull the covers all the way up to my neck to hide my own nakedness.

‘It’s 8:30,’ he said, twisting his torso to look at me. ‘You should rest until check-out. You need it.’

I smiled lazily at him, closing my eyes to welcome the tiny kiss he planted on my forehead. I slipped back into a deep slumber, allowing myself a few extra hours before having to acknowledge the reality of what had happened between the two of us.

But when my alarm blared at 11:30 a.m., I knew I could no longer afford to do so. Waking up alone in the bed the two of us had shared, paired with my hangover anxiety, had sliced through the heart of my previously dreamy morning. Images from last night flashed in quick succession before my eyes.

The dark parking lot. Our first kiss. The car. The nerve-racking walk to my room. This room. Our clothes flying, his amused expression when he couldn’t figure out how to undo my badly worn sari, the tie around his neck

with which I had pulled him into a kiss. The way he'd thrown me on the bed, the weight of his body on top of mine and how his skin had felt against my own.

No. Stop.

I pulled the covers over my face, groaning loudly.

What had I done?

Not only had I slept with the enemy, I'd also bloody well enjoyed it. But that wasn't the worst of it. A string of messages was waiting for me on my phone. They were all from Madhav.

Still at the reception?
12:45 a.m.

Hey, I'm home. Crashing
now, but call me when u
get done? 1:32 a.m.

Are you ok???
3:49 a.m.

Good morning. Call me
when you wake up.
8:05 a.m.

I tried to drown out my groans by holding a pillow firmly over my face. It didn't help. The repercussions of last night's escapade were hitting me with full force, and I could do nothing to stop it from happening. My head was reeling with thoughts I didn't know how to make sense of, let alone process.

How had this happened? And why did something that had seemed so inconceivable up until yesterday feel so natural today? It was as if my body had known all along that this day would come, but it had forgotten to let my brain in on the secret. What was I supposed to do now? Go about my day as if I hadn't just had passionate, burning sex with the man I'd been hating for the past couple of months?

A call from the check-out desk gave me the push I needed to get out of bed. It was Sunday, the only day I had for myself before getting back to the office. There were things I wanted to do that didn't involve stressing over the guy I had slept with or the one I had wronged. Like go home and have a

meal with my parents for the first time in days. And drag myself to V's boutique's launch party, the one I had decorated. After the mayhem of the past week, I deserved to switch my brain off for a while.

This, whatever it was, would have to wait.

I was entranced with Kavita Auntie's cocktail gown. It was a brilliant shade of sapphire blue, with ruffle sleeves and a deep, sensual back. For the life of me, I couldn't imagine my mother in a garment like that. But then again, our mothers couldn't have been more different. Mine was a stay-at-home mom who had always put her family above everything else, while the woman in front of me was hugely successful and fiercely independent. My mom was warm and comforting, while V's mother was a figure of intimidation and respect. That's probably why they'd never struck up a friendship, even after having known each other through their daughters for two decades.

'Hey, you,' V said, having discovered my invisible corner. 'What are you doing?'

I was strategically avoiding the thoughts screaming for my attention by thinking about nugatory things and guzzling down glasses of champagne. So far, it was working.

'I'm enjoying the party,' I lied.

It had been over an hour since I'd arrived at the boutique, and instead of socialising with the guests and taking feedback on the decor, I'd planted myself in a corner, hoping that the frown on my face would kill any shot at friendly exchanges with strangers.

'Come on, I want to introduce you to some people,' V said as she tugged on my arm. 'They've been gushing over what you've done with the place.'

When I refused to budge, she creased her forehead with concern and asked, 'Is everything all right?'

I waved her away, swaying slightly. 'I just need to get another drink.'

She lowered her chin, tilting her head to one side. 'You've had a lot already, Annie. You sure you're okay?'

'I'm fiiiine,' I said, forcing myself to hold her gaze for a few seconds. 'I'm just celebrating.'

She nodded at that and gave me an apprehensive smile. I thrust my phone into her hand and left to fetch my fifth glass of champagne. Away from the safety of my corner, I had no choice but to smile at the people who acknowledged my presence. V's mother pulled me into a conversation with a group of older women, introducing me and crediting me for the work I'd put in. Spaced out as I was, I could only manage a few pleasantries before excusing myself from the lot.

When I returned to V, she was reading something on my phone, engrossed.

'Hey!' I said, snatching it from her.

A new message from Aadar was waiting for me on the screen.

We need to talk about
what happened last night.
You free? 8:15 p.m.

'Don't do that,' I said crossly.

She narrowed her eyes at me and asked, 'What happened last night?'

I sighed and said, 'Nothing.'

'Seriously?' I could tell she was beginning to get upset. 'Tell me or I'll DM him and ask myself.'

'Jesus Christ,' I said, throwing my hands up in the air. 'I slept with him, okay?'

My voice shot up in the end, and from the corner of my eye, I saw a lady in a red sari look briefly but curiously in our direction.

'Slept with whom?' someone asked from behind me.

V's wide-eyed expression confirmed the voice I was too scared to identify on my own.

When I finally gathered the courage to turn, Madhav was already making his way through the crowd towards the door. I rushed after him, almost spilling my drink on an uncle who was walking in the opposite direction.

The air outside was thick with humidity, making it stuffier to be in the open than in a room with thirty people.

'Madhav, wait!' I had to raise my voice to be heard over the commotion of the street.

He stopped walking away and turned to face me but refused to look me in the eye.

‘What?’ he demanded.

‘How ... uh what are you doing here?’ I asked, rubbing my forehead with my free hand.

‘You weren’t texting me back and I was worried,’ he scoffed, shuffling his feet. ‘So I asked your friend if I could come here.’

‘I ...’ I began, searching for the right words. ‘I needed some time.’

‘To fuck other people,’ he said bitterly. ‘Yes, I got that now.’

I wanted to resent him for his crudeness, but I couldn’t. This was all my fault and there was no denying it.

‘It wasn’t like that ...’ my voice faded out with the realisation that there was nothing I could say right now that wouldn’t sound insincere.

His shoulders were tense, his stance aggressive.

You’ve only known him for a few days, a part of my brain was trying to console me. *He’s overreacting.*

Even so, it pained me to know that I’d hurt him. I could’ve handled this better. I could’ve returned his calls. I could’ve been honest about my feelings. I could’ve done pretty much *anything* but sleep with another man and then avoid him afterwards.

‘Were you,’ he said as he cleared his throat, ‘just planning on ghosting me?’

‘No, God, no ... I just needed some—’

‘Some time.’ He let out a humourless laugh and said, ‘Right.’

He shook his head at me in a way that made me feel really, *really* small. And without another word, he spun on his heel and left.

I stood there, frozen, feeling as though I’d been punched in the gut. An autorickshaw honked loudly at me, and I stumbled out of the way. I sat down on the steps of the new and improved Akira Couture and downed my drink. The door opened next to me and V emerged.

‘What’s going on, Annie?’ she wanted to know.

‘Why didn’t you tell me Madhav was coming?’ I asked, trying to comprehend how I’d found myself in such a messy situation.

She smoothed her skirt and sat down next to me.

‘He texted me, and I thought it’d be a nice surprise,’ she said, shrugging her shoulders defensively.

‘You should’ve asked me,’ I said, looking down at the pearled heels I’d worn to match my white cut-out jumpsuit.

‘Unbelievable.’ V was shaking her head.

‘What?’ I demanded.

When she just continued to look away, I jerked her elbow towards me. ‘Tell me.’

She opened her mouth to let out a short, heavy sigh, as if she was getting ready to say something that had been bothering her for a while. ‘You don’t tell me anything about your life and then you expect me to know what the right thing to do is?’

‘That’s not—’ She didn’t let me finish.

‘You didn’t even tell me about you and *Aadar*.’ Her voice rose when she said his name.

‘There was nothing to tell!’

‘Oh please,’ she said. ‘You’ve been acting strangely secretive ever since you met him.’ She began counting things off her fingers. ‘You lie to me to go hang out with him and your phone constantly has texts and calls from him.’

I opened my mouth to explain but she cut me off again. ‘And don’t say it’s for work. I know you’ve been dating him ... or screwing him or whatever,’ she said.

‘That’s not it at all.’ My voice was drowned out amid her accusing rant.

‘You know I wouldn’t judge you if you’ve been two-timing him,’ she was saying. ‘I just can’t understand why you’d hide it from *me*.’

Her voice cracked at the last word and she stopped talking, breathless.

The noise of the street stood out in contrast with the weighty silence between me and my best friend. The champagne high I’d been enjoying for the last hour was threatening to come crashing down in waves.

‘There’s nothing between Aadar and me.’

When she scoffed in disbelief, I took a deep breath and continued, ‘Or at least, there wasn’t, until last night. We saw so much of each other because ... well, we’d made a bet.’

V raised her eyebrows at me, as if she hadn’t expected me to say such an odd thing. ‘A bet?’

‘Yes,’ I said begrudgingly, knowing how stupid I must sound to her. ‘A bet to see who could find love first.’

‘That’s hilarious,’ she said, letting out a snigger through her teeth. ‘Wait, are you serious?’

I lightly slapped my thighs with the palm of my hands, saying, ‘See, this is why I didn’t tell you.’

‘Because I’d try to talk some sense into you?’ Her big brown eyes were wide with annoyance.

‘Because you wouldn’t understand.’ I felt myself erupting as I exclaimed, ‘You never do!’

It was my turn to unload on her.

‘You’ve got everything, V.’ The words began to tumble out of me. ‘Your life is a fucking fairytale. You’ve got the boyfriend, the looks, the money ... everything comes easy to you. I can’t compete with that. I can’t listen to you lecture me about how to better my shitty life when you’ve been handed all of it on a goddamn silver platter.’

‘What the fuck are you talking about?’ She leaned forward, her breath coming out in short, furious gasps.

‘I can’t explain any better,’ I said and looked away.

‘Try.’ She reached out for my arm. ‘I’m your best friend, for fuck’s sake.’

I continued to avoid her eye, aware that I wouldn’t be able to say what I wanted if our gaze locked.

‘You’re my only friend.’ My voice was low, devoid of any emotion. ‘There’s a difference.’

She stared at me as a look of acute pain overshadowed her sharp features. Then, shrugging it off, she got up, dusted herself and went inside.

Instead of following her into the boutique, I crossed the road, hailed an auto and got in.

‘Hauz Khas,’ I told the driver, who sped up almost immediately.

I could think of only one thing to prevent the force of what had just happened from hitting me. I dialled a number on my phone. He picked up after a few seconds.

‘Hello ... hi.’ Aadar’s voice was barely audible over the peak hour South Delhi traffic.

‘Can you meet me right now?’ I asked, slapping my hair back into a ponytail. ‘I can come over.’

‘Um ...’ I could hear faint chatter behind him as he said, ‘I’m actually at my parents’ place tonight. I was hoping to talk to you over the phone.’

‘I was hoping to do anything but talk.’

I knew sex was not the answer to my problems. If anything, it would probably lead to newer problems. But I’d just snubbed two people I cared about in one night, and I needed an outlet for the guilt that was beginning to eat away at me. I needed to feel desired. I needed to be held.

He cleared his throat, sounding uncomfortable. ‘Ananya ... I’m sorry about last night. I shouldn’t have done that.’

Removing the phone from my ear, I stared at his name flashing on my screen. ‘Done what?’

‘Uh ...’

‘Kissed me?’ I asked, feeling the bile rise in my throat.

‘Yes ...’ The discomfort in his voice was all too obvious.

‘Come up to my room? Taken off my clothes? Put your dick inside—’

‘Ananya!’ he said my name like he was scolding a teenager for saying something impolite at a family dinner.

I fell silent, my back hitting the lightly cushioned seat of the auto as it rode over pothole after pothole. Had I spent any amount of time today analysing the events of last night and this morning, I could’ve saved myself the embarrassment of this conversation. But instead, I’d spent the entire day avoiding my thoughts and compromising my senses.

Serves you right, I thought to myself.

‘I’m about to get engaged.’ It took him a while to say the words. ‘Last night should not have happened.’

‘But it did.’ My voice was small.

Wait, did he say he was engaged?

‘I know. I fucked up. That whole bet thing ... it just screwed my head up. It made everything so exciting ... I guess I forgot what was on the line.’ I could hear him pacing on the other end.

‘The bet, right,’ I said. ‘I get it.’

He was engaged. To be *married*.

‘It was so silly and immature. What were we thinking?’ he said, letting out an uncertain laugh, like he was hoping I’d join in.

Had he left so hurriedly in the morning to meet the girl he was marrying? After making love to me all night?

‘I don’t know. Let’s just call it off,’ I said, my mouth on autopilot while my brain computed the information I was being given.

‘Yes, exactly. The bet is off,’ he said, sounding relieved. ‘Besides, we both won.’

‘Huh?’

‘I’m getting engaged to Sneha ... and you’ve got that guy ...’

‘Madhav,’ I offered when he failed to come up with a name.

‘Yes,’ he said, forcing cheeriness into his voice. ‘It’s kind of perfect, if you think about it.’

It’s an absolute fucking disaster, I wanted to scream at him, and it’s all your bloody fault.

I’d had the ugliest fight with my best friend in years. I’d ruined my shot with a guy who may have actually liked me for who I was. All because of the fucking bet.

But I couldn’t tell him any of that. Because if I did, he’d know he had won. Not only had he managed to find himself a wife, but he had also successfully played me in the process. It was an epic win for him and a shameful loss for me. There was no way I was letting him bask in that knowledge.

‘So ... we’re good?’ he asked me as the auto pulled over in front of his house.

I cursed under my breath. I’d forgotten I’d told the driver to bring me here.

‘We’re perfect,’ I said and hung up, leaving no room for goodbyes.

I got out of the auto, paid the driver all the change I had, and stood under Aadar’s apartment building, waiting for my Uber to take me home.

Kicking the Corporate Ladder

MONDAY CAME AND WENT, but I stayed in my bed. The idea of stepping into the shower, getting dressed for work and hitching a forty-minute ride with my dad to the office seemed like too much effort if all I had to look forward to was hiding behind my desk all day. I couldn't even get myself to switch my phone on. It's not that I was scared of what might be waiting for me when I did – angry messages from Vrinda, some fuck-yous from Madhav, maybe another insincere apology from Aadar. No, I was petrified of finding an empty inbox.

My mother came to check on me around 11:00 a.m., and so I faked a cough for her benefit. It was better for her mental health if she assumed I'd caught the flu. She touched my forehead with the back of her hand before flipping it over to caress my face.

'I told you not to exert so much.' Her reproach was familiar and comforting, the way only a mother's could ever be.

I grumbled and turned on my side, pulling the covers over my head.

'You just rest, Anu,' she said and squeezed my shoulder, promising to bring me a hot cup of tea in a bit.

I spent the entire day dozing in and out of sleep, trying hard to induce an illness out of the blue. In my worst moments, I found myself fantasising about conversations with my family physician.

'I'm afraid I've got bad news for you, Ananya,' he would say, his moustache dancing on his top lip.

'What is it?' my mother would ask, clutching my hand.

'She's got a rare type of cancer.'

I know, I know. It's a terrible thing to fantasise about. And yet, I couldn't help but wonder how so many of my problems would immediately be resolved if I were to magically develop a deadly disease. The people who hated me would have no choice but to give me the benefit of the doubt, those who were mad at me would have to forgive me and the ones who had wronged me would be overcome with guilt.

Morning turned into night and I stayed confined to my bed, only stepping out to pee every few hours. At some point on Tuesday morning, I briefly thought about writing an email to my boss to inform her I was sick. But I'd chucked my phone under the bed last night, and I didn't want to get up to retrieve my laptop from the study table. So I put on my sleeping mask and began counting to one hundred.

Wednesday morning arrived and my mom rushed into my room, holding the landline in her hand.

'It's your boss,' she said, holding out the phone for me. 'You didn't tell her you were ill?'

I blinked, making an effort to swallow the sour taste in my mouth. 'I can't.'

My mother had had enough of me. She tilted her head to one side and pointed to the phone in her hand with her eyes.

I sighed and took it from her. 'Hello?'

My voice was groggy and ailing, and I hoped it sounded pitiable enough for Pooja to not want to scream at me.

'Get your ass to the office. NOW.' It clearly hadn't worked.

'But I'm sick—'

'I don't care if you're in the ICU. Be here in an hour or say goodbye to your promotion,' she barked and hung up.

Quite honestly, I didn't care about the promotion anymore. Right now, it was hard to care about anything at all. But ignoring Pooja's call would've meant dismissing my own hard work of three years, and I wasn't sure if I'd be able to live with that a week from now. So I summoned all the energy I didn't possess and dragged myself all the way to my office building.

The receptionist didn't let me punch in. 'Pooja ma'am is expecting you in her office,' she simply said.

The door to her glass cabin was open, and she motioned for me to shut it behind me. She was wearing a nude jumpsuit with a belt to cinch her waist. The front of her open-toed suede sandals was tapping against her desk, in perfect synchronisation with her fingertips on the tabletop. She'd been waiting for me.

'Care to explain where you've been?' She crossed her legs and leaned back in her chair.

She was studying my appearance. In my black Beatles hoodie and loose jeans, I looked every bit the part I was trying to play.

‘I’ve not been keeping well.’ I felt light-headed even as I stood there, and I was reminded of the lack of food in my system.

‘You couldn’t have dropped me a text or an email?’ She crossed her arms to mimic her legs.

‘Wasn’t well enough to do either,’ I said, placing my hand on her wooden desk for support.

‘Sit down,’ she said, the coldness in her voice subsiding as she decided I wasn’t telling complete lies. ‘You need to see something.’

As I took my place across from her, she turned her laptop to face me.

‘While you’ve been conveniently AWOL the last few days, a very pressing email has been waiting for you in your inbox,’ she said, pointing to the screen.

My heart skipped a beat as I read the sender’s name. Michael Evans, the global editorial director of TMJ.

Pooja’s expression hardened again. ‘He had invited you to a virtual meeting. To discuss the future of Best Man – and I’m assuming yours too. The meeting was yesterday, Ananya. You missed it. And you didn’t even bother to respond.’

I swallowed hard, realising the gravity of my actions. ‘I ... I didn’t see this,’ I stammered.

‘Do you know how many people have access to him? Hell, even I’ve never spoken to him directly,’ she said, shaking her head.

I looked down at my hands, feeling the weight of my irresponsibility crashing down on me.

‘Am I ... getting fired?’

‘Fired?’ Pooja creased her forehead and said, ‘Of course not. We owe you a promotion.’

‘Um ... I don’t ...’ I said, squinting my eyes in confusion.

‘No one expects you to be perfect, Ananya,’ she said, tracing her finger along the mouth of her coffee mug. ‘But you can’t just disappear into thin air without a warning.’

I mumbled an apology, unable to meet her eye. She exhaled loudly.

‘It’s going to be fine. I’ve already done some damage control. Now all we need to do is get you on a call with Michael, and then we can finalise

your promotion.'

'So ...' I was still trying to connect the dots as I asked, 'I'm getting a promotion?'

She let out a short laugh. 'Yes, genius. After you fix this, though,' she said.

The air conditioner was blowing directly over my head, and I had to pull at the sleeves of my hoodie to cover as much of my hands as possible.

'It's not a regular promotion,' she said when I didn't ask her further questions. 'If you'd come in to work after the wedding, you would've known how big a success Best Man has been.'

'That's great,' I said, forcing some pride into my voice.

'International has decided to convert the event into an editorial property,' she said. 'And they want you to head it.'

Her voice was loud and clear, but I was having difficulty registering what she was saying, or rather, what it meant for me.

'Your own team ... six to seven weddings every year ... sponsors and clientele ... collaboration with celebrities ...'

'W-w-wait. Hold on,' I stammered. 'You want me to do this full time?'

She looked a little bit surprised by my lack of enthusiasm.

'Yes! You're absolutely brilliant at it.' She was smiling at me.

'Pooja ...' I closed my eyes for a second, trying to steady myself by holding on to the armrest. 'I hated working on this project.'

She was taken aback by my reaction. 'But ... it was your idea in the first place!'

'I know,' I said, breathing loudly. 'I was trying to give you something you'd like. Something that would get me this promotion.'

'And it worked ...' She was now looking at me with concern, as if she was scared I had a screw loose somewhere.

I thought about what she was saying for a tiny minute. If Best Man became an editorial property, I'd be organising sponsored weddings all year round. That would mean months of planning, finding sponsors, catering to their wishes, getting influencers on board, accommodating their demands and so on. I wouldn't have any time for myself, ever. And all of this for what? So I could give undeserving couples a ton of content for their soon-to-fail marriages?

‘Pooja, I know I should’ve said something sooner, but I’m sorry,’ I said.
‘I can’t accept this offer.’

There was silence.

‘Why?’

‘Because I woke up one day and realised I don’t like my job.’ I couldn’t deny it any longer. ‘This isn’t the right place for me anymore.’

‘You need to think about what you’re saying,’ she said, her voice stern. ‘Decisions like these are not taken on an impulse.’

I stood up from my seat and offered her a heartfelt smile. ‘I hope you’re wrong,’ I said, ‘because I quit.’

I got stuck in traffic on my way back home. Hundreds of cars were lined up behind each other as a result of an accident on the Sarai Kale Khan flyover. As I sat in the backseat of my cab, unmoving and silent, the ball of anxiety in my stomach began to get bigger and louder. I fiddled with my phone, trying to tell myself it was in my best interest to keep it switched off. I didn’t want to lose hope of the possibility that people were trying to get in touch with me. I didn’t want to find out that nobody cared about me at all.

The unending honking from the car on my left attracted my attention. I immediately recognised the person behind the wheel – it was Saurav. My first instinct was to duck, assuming that Vrinda was in the car with him. But on second glance, I noticed that the woman in the passenger seat was not my friend. She had a light fringe that covered her forehead and a square, unsmiling jaw. She spotted me looking at her and said something to Saurav, pointing in my direction. He turned to look at me and nodded briefly in recognition. I was rolling down my window to talk to him when the car in front of him moved, and he sped up without a goodbye. I could still see his black Jeep Compass, but it was too far away for me to observe or make any attempts at conversation.

Dissatisfied with the interaction, I slid to the other side of the seat and looked out of the window. I was hoping this chance encounter with V’s boyfriend would give me some insight into how she was doing ... and if she wanted to talk to me. But the Universe, as always, was not on my side.

If we don't move an inch for the next thirty seconds, I'll switch my phone on, I struck a deal with myself. I proceeded to maintain a mental count as my driver honked loudly to verbalise my impatience. Finally, after waiting longer than I'd planned, I held down the power button. The screen lit up as a series of animations danced in front of my eyes. The wallpaper, a selfie of V and I sticking our tongues out at the camera, seemed to mock me. I waited for the notifications to hit me.

Nothing.

Apart from a few messages from Pooja, Ryan and a school WhatsApp group I never participated in, there was no word from anyone. A sinking feeling gripped me and I had to hug my chest tightly to keep myself from falling apart.

I'd quit my job on a whim. My best friend wanted nothing to do with me. I'd lost a bet I'd gambled my friendship, love life and even my career on, and I couldn't get the guy I'd lost to out of my head. Every time I let my guard down, I found myself getting transported to that night in the parking lot. If being with him had been such a terrible, stinking mistake, why couldn't I get myself to regret it?

The peculiar ache I felt in my gut was not an entirely new feeling. I knew I'd felt it before. I opened Instagram and began typing out my ex's name.

And there he was. He smiled back at me, flashing his flawless teeth. He had his arm around a girl – @juliette298. This was what I'd been shielding myself from ever since I'd had my heart broken in Bangalore, when I'd discovered that the man in the photo had been cheating on me.

I stared at the photo, waiting for the familiar pain I felt every time I thought about him and what could've been. A few moments passed, and nothing shifted. I pinched the screen to zoom into his face. Still nothing – no stinging sensation, no nausea, absolutely nothing. It was almost like I was staring at a stranger's face.

I looked up from the screen, bewildered. He was the only man I'd ever loved. Even though I was over him, he had always held a part of my heart captive. It didn't matter if I no longer envisioned a life with him. I had long accepted that seeing him with someone else would forever be a painful sight. So then why was my brain so indifferent and my heart so unbothered?

A giggle bubbled out of me, followed by a whimper. The cab driver glanced at me curiously from the rear-view mirror.

The realisation hit me like a ton of bricks.

I was in love with someone else. And he was getting married. To someone else.

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He Loves Me Knot

I SPENT THE NEXT five days trying to obliterate the ridiculous notion that I had fallen for Aadar Chauhan. But the more I fought to deny the idea, the closer to the truth it began to seem. I couldn't wrap my head around the fact that the same man I'd considered my nemesis a few weeks ago was now suddenly the most important person in my life. I used to detest having to interact with him, and now I stared at my phone for hours, willing him to text me. But he never did. I hadn't heard a peep out of him after that hasty phone call when he'd told me about his engagement. I opened his Instagram profile every day, hoping to get a hint of what was going on in his life. But he maintained his social media silence even in the face of his successful love story.

When Saturday rolled around and I still hadn't managed to dismiss him from my thoughts, I picked up my phone and rang him. He didn't answer. I tossed my phone on the bed, disheartened. A sane person would've taken his silence as a sign of lack of interest, bitterly accepted the rejection and moved on. But it had been a few days since I'd lost my sanity. I desperately needed someone to talk to, a sounding board of sorts. I'd considered dialling V's number many times in the past week, but my ego hadn't let me.

Why couldn't *she* call?

And so, in the absence of a rational voice stopping me from making a bigger fool out of myself, I called him again. And again. I left him text after text, hoping he'd respond to at least one. I even dropped him an email on his official ID. The hours passed, but I didn't hear back from him. I knew I was being unreasonable, but I couldn't bear to give up on this without first speaking to him. I just wanted to have a word.

Okay, I *wanted* a lot more. But this much, I needed.

So I did the only other thing I could think of. I made a trip to his flat. The bell continued to ring as I waited for someone to open the door. After the fifth ring, I figured it had to be one of two things: a) he knew I was at the door and wanted nothing to do with me, or b) nobody was home.

Think, Annie. Who would know where he is?

That's when it struck me. I opened my phone book and dialled his brother. The first three times I called, there was no answer. But then he called me back.

'Ananya? Hi, you called?' I could barely hear him over the commotion.

I breathed a sigh of relief. 'Karan! Thank God! I need to speak to your brother, where is he?'

'Sorry, what?' He had to shout to be heard. 'I can't hear you properly.'

'Is. Aadar. With. You?' I enunciated every word.

'Um, yes. I'm at his engagement party.'

I zeroed in on the sounds in the background – dhol, DJ, congratulating relatives and laughter.

If there was ever a sign from the Universe to stop trying to talk to Aadar, it was this one. But I was way past listening to the stupid Universe.

'Tell me the address,' I said.

'Uh ...' I could tell he was wondering if he could simply hang up on me.

'Please, Karan. I promise I won't make a scene. I just need to speak to him for five minutes.'

'Something happened between you two, didn't it?' he said knowingly.

He took my silence as an affirmative and told me he'd give me the address if I promised to wait outside. There was no way he was letting me into the premises. He'd bring Aadar to me instead.

The engagement party was taking place in Chattarpur Farms. I got behind the wheel of my dad's car and drove like I'd never driven before. I was certain that I'd have at least three speeding challans waiting for me in the mail in the coming week. I didn't have an invitation card to show at the gate of the farmhouse and I certainly didn't look like I was a guest in my ice cream-stained sweatpants, so the guard didn't immediately let me in. I rang Karan again as I waited at the gate, and a few minutes later, I saw him signalling to the guard to let me pass.

I swerved into the parking lot and quickly parked between two sedans.

'Whoa, that was surprisingly smooth,' Karan said. He was waiting for me when I jumped out of the car.

I looked back at my dad's Swift, realising that I'd reverse parked it in record time today.

‘I’ve been practising,’ I said, thinking about how I’d been playing the simulation game Aadar had installed on my phone every night to feel closer to him.

Pathetic, I know.

‘Okay, wait here,’ he said. ‘I’ll try and pull him out for a bit.’

I nodded, watching him disappear around the corner. The engagement, I figured, was taking place in the lawns to the right of the parking lot. I began to inch closer towards it, hoping to catch a glimpse of what was going on inside.

This was all happening too quickly. I’d barely had the time to process my feelings for him, even though I’d known him for over two months. How was it that he’d decided to marry someone he’d just met two weeks ago? Was she really such a catch?

I saw Karan dragging his brother towards me. Aadar was arguing with him, gesturing wildly with his hands. But when he saw me, he froze.

‘What’s going on?’ he asked, looking from his brother to me.

Karan shrugged, slapped his brother’s shoulder and left, indicating that he was on his own.

I walked over to him, my knees feeling weak with apprehension. It was strange to love and hate the sight of a man with the same blinding intensity. On the one hand, I couldn’t stop admiring how good his broad shoulders and strong chest looked in the black and gold sherwani. But the thought that he was dressed up like that to put a ring on another woman’s finger made me want to burn it off his skin.

‘Why haven’t you been answering my calls?’ I asked when I was close enough.

‘I’m getting engaged today, Ananya,’ he said, looking down at me. ‘I haven’t had the time.’

‘Can we go somewhere, please?’ I asked. ‘To talk?’

He placed his hands on his hips, looking around. ‘I can’t just *go* with you. I need to get back inside.’

He waited for me to say something and when I didn’t, he began to turn around.

‘Okay, no, wait.’ I lurched forward and grabbed his arm, saying, ‘I need to tell you something.’

He neither moved nor pulled his arm away.

‘I ...’ I began saying, ‘I can’t stop thinking about you.’

He turned his face to look at me, his arm still firmly in my grasp. ‘Ananya ...’

‘No, let me finish,’ I said, stepping closer to him so I could slide my hand down his forearm and place it in his. ‘I know you think that night was a mistake, but I don’t. I wasn’t drunk. You weren’t drunk. We knew exactly what we were doing. And we wanted to do it ... so very much.’

He let me entwine my fingers with his as I continued talking. ‘I spent so much of my time hating you that I never even realised when I fell for you.’

A shadow crossed his features. I desperately wanted to know what he was thinking, but his eyes didn’t give anything away.

‘Please, say something,’ I urged him.

‘I can’t do this, Ananya.’ He sounded pained. ‘Not right now.’

From the distance, we heard a woman shouting his name. Aadar’s mother was standing at the parking lot’s entrance.

‘I have to go,’ he said, pulling his hand out of my grip. ‘I’m sorry.’

‘Why are you doing this?’ I raised my voice.

Tears began to sting my eyes and threatened to spill onto my face.

‘What do you suggest I do?’ he spun around and demanded.

‘Don’t go.’

‘So I should abandon my chance at marrying a nice girl, starting a family ... for what?’ he asked aggressively. ‘For a girl who can barely go on two dates with the same guy ... let alone think about marriage?’

His words stung and I felt my vision blur with tears as I said, ‘For a girl who’s telling you she loves you.’

He scoffed and said, ‘I’m too old to play these games with you, Ananya.’

His mother shouted for him again and he began walking away.

I thought about how a few months ago, he’d sat across from me in *my* home, asking for *my* hand in marriage. I didn’t want to marry him then, I didn’t want to marry him now, and it was too early to tell if I’d ever want to marry him. But watching him walk out of my life broke my heart harder than anything ever had before.

If my life was a romcom, I would’ve risked it all, gotten down on one knee and proposed to him. He would’ve smiled, bent down next to me and pulled me into his arms. But I knew by now that romcoms were a lie. However strongly I felt for this guy, I couldn’t sacrifice my own beliefs and

values to keep his interest in me alive. I couldn't ask him to marry me to prove to him that I did, in fact, love him.

And so, I held my breath as he took step after step, adding to the growing distance between us. My brain, wired as it was, repeated 'palat, palat' as he walked away. But he didn't turn. He put an arm around his frowning mother and left the parking lot, but not before I heard her say, 'Wasn't that Mrs Kapoor's daughter?'

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A Clean Slate

THERE'S A STARK DISTINCTION between the days leading up to a heartbreak and the ones that follow it. Before heartbreak (BH), you have many sources of pain, like fear, anticipation, etc. After heartbreak (AH), the only thing that can hurt you is the past. So if you find a way to block that out, you're all good. Before Aadar had so coldly turned me away on the day of his engagement, I had been burdened with the weight of hope. But ever since that day, I felt freed. Losing hope was not such a bad thing, after all.

So, yes, personally, I much preferred my life in the autumn months of 2021 AH to the summer of 2021 BH. Now that I was jobless, friendless and loveless, the only people I was forced to interact with were my parents. And even though they were sick and tired of me zombie-ing around the house, they couldn't find it in themselves to be assholes to me.

About ten days AH, they sat me down in the living room.

'We may not say it very often ...' my dad was saying, 'but we love you very much, Anu.'

Both of them sat awkwardly at the edge of the brown sofa. My mom had her hands in her lap, while my dad had placed his uneasily next to his sides. After having watched me sulk and mope for all these days, their concern had at last won over their discomfort.

'Okay ...' I darted my eyes between them.

'You know you can talk to us, right?' he continued talking in measured words.

'I'm fine, Papa,' I said, a pinch of irritation finding its way into my tone.

'You've not stepped out of the house in days, you quit your job and you haven't spoken to your friends or anyone else about it ... you've barely even said a word to us all week,' he said, his calm demeanour cracking at the edges.

My mother joined in and said, 'Are you ... depressed?'

A short gasp escaped her lips as she said the word, and she looked down at her hands, mumbling, 'I don't know what I'll do if something happens to you.'

My dad gave her a warning look, but her anxious ramble was already underway. 'This woman in my kitty ... her daughter slit her own wrists and wound up in the hospital ...'

'Sarita, please.' My dad cut her off and said, 'What your mother means to say is ... we're here for you. Whether you want to talk to us ... or someone else.'

I was overcome with guilt and love of equal proportions as I realised that my parents were proposing therapy. In a household that had never had an open and healthy discussion about mental health, this was huge. In my parents' circles, the words depression and anxiety were scorned at. First-world problems, I'd heard them say in the past. And yet, they were sitting in front of me, trying to help me crawl out of the deep, dark pit I'd fallen in.

It was too much for me to take in. In the last few days, I'd convinced myself that nobody cared about me. And so, it didn't matter if I wasted my life away, staying in bed throughout the day and talking to the ceiling during the night. I'd forgotten that there were two people in the world who would always love me, even if I was being a divine pain in the ass.

I caught my parents off guard when I burst into tears. It took them a few seconds to run over to me and wrap their arms around me. But as I dissolved into their warm, protective embrace, I began to believe what they were saying. It was all going to be okay. I was going to be all right.

The next morning, my mother entered my room and opened all the curtains, letting the sunlight in. Even though I'd been awake for the last couple of hours, I had to squint to adjust my eyes to the light. I felt like an exposed vampire.

'Good morning, Anu,' she said, her face deadpan.

The implication was clear. It was way past dawn and I would not be allowed to sleep in. I kicked my legs and groaned loudly, but deep down, I was grateful for the push. The warm shower was invigorating. I stayed in there until my geyser ran out of hot water, watching the droplets trickle down my skin and soak it with life. When I stepped out of the washroom with my hair in a towel, I paused to take a good look at my room.

This was the room I'd grown up in. In my teenage years, I would redecorate it every other year, pasting posters of the latest boy band over the previous ones. Justin Bieber had replaced the Jonas Brothers, before John Mayer had reigned supreme. The photos pinned on the board over my study desk belonged to school friends I hadn't spoken to in a decade. My bookshelf didn't carry a single title I'd read in the last three years. They were all sitting in a cardboard box under my bed, waiting to be rearranged.

I sighed and removed the towel from my wet hair. It was time.

The thing with rock bottom is that it gets boring. At some point, there's nothing left to do but climb up.

And so, I began overturning my teenage room. The person who had done it up with so much love didn't exist anymore. I hadn't been that girl for a long time. And I was tired of living in a stranger's room.

It felt strangely cathartic to rip out the posters from my bedroom wall. I began tossing meaningless mementos, photos of forgotten friends and old magazines into the trash. It's amazing how much garbage you can accumulate over a period of ten years. I found broken earrings, old journals, slam books, chargers for every phone I'd ever owned, birthday cards from old classmates, at least five bottles of frozen Fevicol, CDs and DVDs of annual day performances from school, along with leaking lipsticks and handbags that had been ruined by dust and grime.

After I was done stuffing everything I didn't need into large black trash bags, my room looked pitifully bare. It had been robbed of all its personality and in its place were sad, empty walls and naked shelves and tables. But when I looked at it, I saw a clean slate – an opportunity to create a version of my current life rather than losing myself in the life I had once lived.

I sat down on the foot of my bed, a stack of old Polaroids in my hand. Most of them had been taken about three or four years ago, after V had gifted me a Polaroid camera for one of my birthdays. Apart from a couple of photos with my parents, all of them had V in them.

V feeding me a slice of birthday cake. V and I sitting in my college classroom when she'd come to visit me. V and I dancing in a bar. V and I with our arms around each other, giggling at a joke I didn't remember.

I went through the photos, my eyes watering as the memories washed over me. And then, I found a photo I couldn't quite put down. It had been

taken in a bar in Hauz Khas on the night V had first met Saurav. He had been out with his then-girlfriend and a group of friends, and at some point, he had struck up a conversation with my friend. It had been an innocent encounter, but the two of them had exchanged numbers and later begun to date. Saurav had dumped his girlfriend for V, and they'd started their own love story shortly thereafter.

I remembered that we'd asked the bartender to take the photo I was now holding in my hand, and he'd done a shoddy job of it, not bothering to adjust the settings of the Polaroid camera. As a result, all four faces in the photo were dark and almost unrecognisable.

But the more I studied the photo, the surer I became that something was off about it. Saurav stood in the middle, his right arm around V, who was holding onto my hand, and his left arm around another woman – his ex.

I realised with a start that I'd seen her recently. She had been in his car the other day.

Ever since we were kids, Vrinda's two-storey bungalow in Greater Kailash had unnerved and awed me uniformly. I still remember, in third grade, she had invited me over for a sleepover for the first time. I had marvelled at the lush green lawns outside, the chandelier in the living room, the spiral staircase that I'd only ever seen in *K3G* before and the preposterous size of her bedroom. *How many people sleep in here?* I had asked her innocently.

Today, as I waited for her under the same crystal chandelier in the living room, I was equally overwhelmed by the opulence around me. I recalled the days after that first sleepover when I'd tried to distance myself from V because I was too ashamed to let her see the reality of my home. I didn't want to invite her over. But she had persisted, and when I finally brought her to my three-bedroom flat, she was completely unfazed. She had jumped onto my bed and started wrestling with my stuffed toys, making herself at home.

I'd learned that day that the financial disparity between us existed only in my head – it was my burden to carry.

'Hi.' V's voice yanked me out of my head, and I looked up.

She was standing at the top of the spiral staircase, wearing a fuzzy lavender bathrobe.

‘Hi,’ I said. ‘Can I come up?’

She nodded and waited for me to join her at the top. Up close, she looked different. Her eyes were heavier, as if she hadn’t been sleeping too much. Her skin had blemishes on it, freshly red after her warm shower. And her mouth was sombre and unsmiling. In our lifelong friendship, we had never gone three weeks without speaking to each other. I wondered if it had affected her as deeply as it had me.

She led me to her room, where I closed the door behind me.

‘How are you?’ she asked, her eyes blank.

We sat down on the patchwork couch in front of her king-size poster bed. The door to her balcony was open and the light from outside lit up the entire room.

‘Meh,’ I said. ‘You?’

She shrugged. ‘Meh.’

Our eyes locked and I gave her a hesitant smile. She didn’t return it.

I cleared my throat and said, ‘I need to tell you something.’

She glanced at me sideways but didn’t say anything.

‘I saw Saurav with a girl a while ago,’ I began. ‘They were in his car. Honestly, it seemed completely innocent and I didn’t think anything of it at all. But then, yesterday, I cleaned out my room and found this.’ I took out the Polaroid from my jeans pocket and offered it to her.

She took the photograph from me and turned it over in her hands, uninterested. ‘You finally cleaned out your room?’

I ignored her comment and pointed at the girl in the photo. ‘That’s his ex, V. The same toxic one who kept trying to win him back for months.’

Her face was expressionless and she remained mum.

‘You don’t think it’s weird he’s hanging out with her?’ I asked, placing a hand on her knee. ‘Aren’t you worried they might be ...?’

She blinked rapidly and then looked away.

‘Oh my God,’ I exclaimed, reading her silence. ‘You know.’

She tried to hide her face behind her hands, but I jumped from the sofa and crouched in front of her, peeling them off.

‘Vrinda,’ I said, ‘talk to me, love.’

‘He’s been ... I think it started a few months ago,’ she managed to say before dissolving into a puddle of sobs.

I clutched her to my chest, wrapping my arms around her back. Her tears soaked through my cotton T-shirt within seconds.

‘Hey,’ I whispered, ‘it’s going to be okay. I’m here now.’

It took her a good twenty minutes to stop crying. I went downstairs to make her a hot cup of tea, and when I got back, she was huddled in a ball on her bed.

‘I saw her messages on his phone two months ago,’ she said, sipping from the mug. ‘At first, I was in denial.’

I scooted closer to her, listening intently.

‘But then it started to become a little too obvious. He wouldn’t text me back for hours, his phone would be busy at night and he was always away at work.’ Her voice was shaking as she said, ‘So, I confronted him.’

‘And?’ I asked.

‘He admitted it,’ she said, the hint of a tear beginning to well in her eyes. ‘Apparently, I’d been putting too much pressure on him to get married. And this is how he decided to cope.’

My heart went out to her and I felt a fire brewing in my belly. I was furious.

‘That asshole,’ I fumed. ‘Please tell me you dumped him.’

Tears flowed down her cheeks, and she wiped them away with the sleeve of her bathrobe. ‘I can’t ... I’m not strong enough.’

I stared at her, dumbstruck. A part of me couldn’t believe that this was the same best friend I’d known a month ago. My beautiful, confident, talented Vrinda. She resembled a broken remnant of that girl.

‘You’re the strong one,’ she said through her tears. ‘You always have been. I’m just the privileged one.’

I reached out and squeezed her hand, the guilt from my words the night of our fight slicing through my gut. ‘I didn’t mean anything I said that day, V ... I was talking through my ass.’

‘No,’ she sniffled as she said, ‘you did. And you were right. I *have* had it easy.’

‘V, it’s not—’

‘But I’ve also had it so, so hard.’ She let out another sob and said, ‘My boyfriend is cheating on me and I still can’t bring myself to leave him. I’m

too scared to follow my dreams and start my own fashion line. Every day when I enter the boutique, I can see the look of disappointment on my mother's face.'

'I'm a coward, Annie,' she said, regaining her composure.

Her words bore a hole through me and I began to feel like I was going under.

'Why the hell are you crying?' She snickered through her tears.

'Because ...' I said, controlling my sob, 'because I can't believe I let you keep all that bottled up inside you for so long.'

She threw her arms around me, and we held on to each other for dear life, bawling and giggling like utter maniacs.

'You have to dump his ass,' I told her later when we had sobered down to have a glass of wine on her balcony.

'I know,' she said, taking a deep breath.

'You're going to be just fine, V,' I said, holding her gaze with intent. 'Delhi boys are in for a treat.'

She laughed, playfully punching my shoulder.

'Speaking of Delhi boys ...' I could tell she was choosing her words carefully. 'I'm sorry about yours.'

Their engagement photos were all over Instagram, so I wasn't surprised V knew.

'How are you holding up?' she asked.

'I'm fine.' I cleared my throat, uncomfortable that the spotlight was moving towards me.

She took the wine glass from me and placed it on the bamboo table behind us.

'I thought we decided on no more secrets,' she said, placing her hands on both of my shoulders to make me face her.

'No, really. I'm okay ... as okay as I can be, I guess.' I took a deep breath and said, 'I told him how I felt ... so at least I don't have to wonder, you know?'

'You did what?' she asked, dropping her hands in shock.

'I told him I loved him,' I said, a small smile creeping onto my face. 'On the day of his engagement.'

'Oh my God, Annie. You're *such* a trip,' she said, squealing. 'So fucking filmy.'

‘Yeah,’ I mumbled. ‘Except for the part where I didn’t get the guy.’

She pouted, placing an arm around my shoulder. ‘Fuck him, then.’

We picked up our drinks, sipping quietly as we admired the clean, wide roads of Central Delhi, with the setting sun disappearing behind them.

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Work in Progress

IN ALL MY TWENTY-SEVEN years of existence, I'd found nothing I despised more than exercise. Not to be overly dramatic, but the insides of a gym reminded me of a torture chamber – dingy basements with fancy equipment designed to instil dread, pain and horror. And only those with nerves of steel and an unbreakable willpower lived to see the day. It's safe to say that I was not one of those people. And yet, I'd been dragging myself to the gym in my complex every day for the past week, hoping that I'd enjoy it a little more than the previous day. So far, I'd had zero luck.

I thanked my trainer for yet another session of abuse and ill-earned punishment and picked up my duffel bag to leave. As soon as I opened the door of the clubhouse, I was ambushed by a furry creature. The dog, unleashed as he was, jumped onto my torso, leaving imprints of his paws on my neon green tank top.

'Charlie, no.' A woman came running around the corner.

She gasped animatedly when she saw me. 'God, I'm so sorry,' she said, peeling him off me and clipping his leash back on.

'That's quite all right,' I said, petting the golden retriever. 'He's a friendly one, isn't he?'

'Too friendly, if you ask me.' The woman, who must've been in her early thirties, seemed embarrassed by her pet's lack of manners.

As if on cue, Charlie jumped up and planted a giant, wet lick right on my mouth.

'Charlie! Off!' she commanded, tugging forcefully on his leash and stepping between us.

She began apologising profusely, but I cut her off. 'I don't mind. Dogs don't need consent like the rest of us.'

The woman let out a hearty laugh and I joined in.

'I'm Ira,' she said, sticking out her free hand.

She had short hair that showed off her delicate, attached earlobes. Two intricate jhumkas hung from them. 'Ananya,' I said, shaking her hand. 'Did

you move here recently?’

‘Yes, a month ago,’ she said.

Charlie had lost interest in me and was now trying to chase a grasshopper. Ira was heading in the direction of my house, so I walked with her. I found out she lived alone with her dog in the building next to mine. She was new to Delhi. Her recent divorce, coupled with a new job offer, had led her here from Jaipur.

‘It’s like starting over, you know?’ she said when I asked her how she was liking it so far.

I told her I was in the process of doing something similar myself, having quit my job.

‘So what’s the plan now?’ she asked, seeming genuinely interested.

It felt odd to be talking about my life with a stranger. Maybe it was the comforting presence of her dog or her easy smile, but something about Ira made me feel like I could tell her things.

‘Well, I’ve got a list. To get my life on track,’ I said, knowing how silly that must’ve sounded.

‘Ooh, I love lists,’ she said, her voice cheery. ‘Tick anything off it, yet?’

I thought back to how V and I had sat through that night, making our separate to-do lists to make sense of our futures. The first thing on hers was ‘Break up with Saurav’, while mine started with ‘Find something you love’. I didn’t know if I was going to love it, but I’d decided I wanted to pursue interior design.

‘I got an entry-level job with a design firm ... this morning actually,’ I told her.

‘That’s amazing,’ she said, flashing me a brilliant smile. ‘Congratulations.’

I sighed.

‘I gave up my promotion and an established career in events to be someone’s assistant in a field I have very little professional knowledge about.’ I wasn’t bitter, but a part of me did feel like I was being hellishly stupid.

‘Hey, it’s never too late to try something new ... we’re all a work in progress, right?’

Work in progress, I thought to myself. I like that.

We stood in front of my porch for a few more minutes, chatting. After a bit, Charlie began to get restless and she walked away, but not without promising that she'd stop by later for a cup of coffee.

'What are you so bubbly about?' my mother asked when I entered the house.

I pecked her on the cheek and mumbled, 'Nothing', before taking off for my room.

The list was waiting for me at my study table. I ticked number eight off the sheet of paper.

Make a new friend.

I held the sheet in front of my face, allowing the letters to dance in front of my eyes. To anyone watching from afar, it might've seemed like I'd lost my plot. I was celebrating the most absurd things. Like having a job that would pay me one-fifth of what I'd been making at TMJ. But these wins, tiny as they might have been, were baby steps in the right direction.

I allowed myself to gloat over some of my other victories from the list.

✓ *Find a job*

✓ *Redecorate my room*

✓ *Delete Aadar Chauhan's contact*

Some of the other things were harder to do.

Move on

Uninstall Tinder

Go for a therapy session

Break unhealthy dating patterns

But I knew I had to start somewhere. I'd been putting off uninstalling my dating app for a few days. I'd been dependent on it for so many things in the last couple of years – validation, action, entertainment, free food and drinks – basically everything other than what I should've been looking for on it. I needed a break.

I long-pressed the familiar red and white app logo on my phone and hovered over the uninstall button when my heart sent a plea to my brain.

A couple of swipes? For old time's sake?

I laid down on my bed, stuffing two pillows under my neck, and began swiping. I couldn't deny that I would miss this world, where I could club men into distinct categories based on their carefully curated profiles and

badly written bios. I began saying my goodbyes as I swiped left on the pool of men in front of me.

Goodbye, 420 friendly men. Goodbye, *F.R.I.E.N.D.S.* vs *The Office* fans. Goodbye, ‘not here for hookups’ guys. Goodbye, ‘not active here, DM on Insta’ dudes. Goodbye, sapiosexuals, bibliophiles, polyamorists, chaisexuals, pickup line users and dick pic enthusiasts.

And then suddenly, without warning, an all-too-familiar face popped up on my screen.

He only had one photo – a selfie. It had been taken in a park or an open area, perhaps after a morning run. Beads of sweat were forming on his forehead, making his thick curls sticky. His dense eyebrows were creased together, shielding his whisky-brown eyes, which pierced right through the screen at me.

I tapped on his profile to read his bio.

‘Looking for a tiny twenty-seven-year-old woman with frizzy hair, commitment issues and a fierce competitive spirit. I’m a simple, sweet guy, but I’ve been referred to as The Asshole, The Enemy and The Devil Reincarnate by said tiny woman. If you know her, tell her I’m looking for her. If you *are* her, swipe right and give me a chance to explain, please?’

My heart sped up as I gaped at the face of the man who had rejected me. What was he doing on Tinder? Was this a fake profile? Why would anyone make a fake profile of a nobody? Was someone trying to play a hideous prank on me? The questions zoomed through my head, leaving me no room to breathe.

Stop, I scolded myself, *it doesn’t matter*. I’d decided to move on, and whatever unfunny game the Universe was playing with me right now, I didn’t have to participate in it. *I’ll just swipe left and be done with it*, I decided.

And then, at the last moment, my fingers rebelled and went the other way.

It’s a match, the app proudly declared.

I froze.

I got up from my bed, abandoning the phone on the mattress. I started pacing my newly redone room, dragging my feet on the fresh grey rug I’d laid out in front of my bed.

What the hell was happening?

A ping went off, and my whole body reacted to it with alarm bells of its own. I approached my phone with caution, as if it was a bomb that might go off at any second.

You have 1 new message from Aadar.

I opened it.

That took you a while.

I gawked at the message, trying to make sense of it.

What are you doing here?

Waiting for you to find me.

I cursed out loud, placing a hand on my heart to make sure it was still beating.

Why? What do you mean?

So I can tell you what a fool I've been.

The words swam in front of my eyes, making it impossible for me to understand or respond to them. After a few minutes, the screen lit up with another text from him.

I called it off. The wedding.

My knees gave out under me, and I collapsed onto the bed. I caught sight of my face in the mirror on my dressing table. I looked like someone had kicked my metaphorical nuts.

Why? I wanted to ask him, but I was too proud.

I'd put my heart on the line for this man, and he had stomped all over it. I'd gone to him with my love and he had turned me away.

Is this some sort of twisted joke? Who is this? Are you catfishing me?

Of course not. It's me.

Then why didn't you just call me? Why all this?

Because you deserve a meet-cute. Like the ones in all those movies.

His poor knowledge of the romance genre was truly appalling. I wondered if this was the right time to point out that this would not qualify as a meet-cute. Aadar and I had met tons of times already, and our story had gone through a steep arc. If anything, this was the grand romantic gesture that typically came at the end.

I considered showing up at your door with a Boombox to serenade you, but it didn't feel right.

And this did?

I just thought it'd be poetic. Considering your love for dating apps and all.

I'm sorry ... did I fuck it up?

I badly wanted to answer in the affirmative. In fact, I wanted to unmatched him, block him everywhere and never give him another thought. God

knows he deserved it. But I couldn't ignore the little dance my intestines had begun performing inside me. I owed it to them to find out what he wanted to say.

What do you want from me?

After that, he stopped responding. Seconds turned into minutes, but the familiar sound of a notification refused to oblige me. I wondered if I'd said something wrong or if he'd simply decided I wasn't worth the trouble. But after forty painful minutes of self-doubt and anxiety, my phone pinged again.

I want you to come outside.

What? Like, right now?

Apprehension spread through my gut as I reread his text, wondering what to make of it. I'd spent too many hours trying to heal my heart to allow it to fall prey, once more, to the incurable disease of hope. I hovered in my empty living room, too scared to open the front door. I was fully aware that another disappointment would cause devastating damage to my spirit. But a part of me, the one that had grown up watching SRK movies and dreaming about my own happy ending, begged me to go outside.

After ten minutes of agonising conflict, I unlatched the door and peeked out. At first glance, there was no sign of him. My mother's carefully tended garden was empty, glowing in the rays of the setting sun. I craned my neck further, which is when I saw him. Leaning against his red Kia, he was looking right at me.

I shut the door behind me and slowly made my way to him. Still in my workout tights and neon tank top, I knew I must've resembled a sweaty, brightly clad pig – I was certainly no Julia Roberts from *Pretty Woman* when Richard Gere shows up at her doorstep.

Aadar, on the other hand, was as charming as ever. He wore a blue linen kurta and faded jeans. His curls were longer than I'd ever seen them,

spilling over his forehead in a gorgeous mess. He uncrossed his arms and straightened up his tall, delicious body as I reached him.

‘How did you know I’d be home?’ I asked, eager to get the first word in.

I wanted to fool my brain into thinking I was in control of this conversation.

‘I took a chance,’ he said. ‘It’s a Saturday, so I figured you wouldn’t be at work.’

I nodded, then said, ‘I quit my job.’

He gave me a warm smile. ‘That’s great. I know you weren’t happy there.’

If he expected me to return his warmth, he was in for a surprise. I stayed silent, feeling him studying my face for a sign of emotion. I hoped that I’d be able to maintain the facade of indifference under his scrutiny.

He cleared his throat and said, ‘I wanted to say something to you ... and it didn’t feel right to text it. So I came to see you.’

‘What?’ My mouth had dried up and the word came out as a croak.

He took a deep breath.

‘It took me a while... but I know now that she was never the one for me,’ he said, trying to find and hold my gaze. ‘You are.’

Abruptly, I turned away from him. In the last few weeks, I’d played out countless versions of this scene in my head. I had pictured him here, seeking me out, saying these very words. But instead of the joy and triumph I had expected to wash over me, I was overcome with anger and resentment. It was too much.

Without another word, I began walking in the direction of my house.

‘Ananya, wait.’ He was hot on my heels. ‘Please, just hear me out?’

‘Why?’ I barked at him when we were outside my garden. ‘Because you’d so patiently listened to me when I had come to you?’

‘I ...’ he began saying, but I cut him off.

‘What had you said that day ...?’ I pretended to think, then said, ‘I’m too old to be playing these games with you.’

What kind of games was he playing now?

‘I know, I know I fucked up,’ he said, reaching out to take my hand in his.

I recoiled at his touch and he held his hands up in surrender.

‘How bloody convenient.’ I scoffed and turned around to leave.

Instead of grabbing my arm, he followed me to the heart of the garden. I wanted to step inside my house and shut the door in his face, but my feet had begun to betray me. So I stood at the entrance to the flat, imprisoned by my own complex bundle of emotions.

It was quieter in the garden and even though I was facing away from him, I could hear his voice clear as day.

‘I knew I loved you ... I was just too scared to admit it,’ he was saying from behind me.

I could’ve pushed the door open and left. I knew he wouldn’t have physically tried to stop me. But I couldn’t drown out the little voice of longing that had begun to ring in my ears.

‘You went and got *engaged*, Aadar,’ I said, the hurt seeping through my voice. ‘I’m supposed to believe all that’s just over?’

‘It has been, for over two weeks now ...’ his voice was gentler as he turned me around to face him.

‘How do I know you won’t change your mind again and go marry the very next girl your meddling parents find for you?’ I demanded, still too raw to let down my guard.

It was hard for me to meet his eye. I knew my resolve would crumble under his toasty gaze.

‘Hey, don’t shit on my parents,’ he said, holding up one finger and angling his face to the right. ‘They were the ones who found you in the first place.’

Despite my best efforts to control my facial muscles, a smile slipped out. Aadar’s face lit up.

‘Can we just ... start over?’ His expression was solemn, his eyes penetrative.

‘How do you propose we do that?’ I asked, crossing my arms in front of my chest.

‘Well,’ he said, rubbing his forehead in thought. ‘You could let me take you out on a date.’

‘Hmm,’ I said, pretending to mull it over.

‘Or I could go inside right now and hit your parents with a rishta,’ he teased. ‘The choice is yours.’

‘Oh God.’ I held my hand up. ‘No, no rishtas please.’

I had no clue when or how our fight had dissolved into the familiar territory of cheerful banter, but I couldn't deny that I was thankful for it. His relief, too, was almost palpable.

He pulled me into his arms with one light tug on my wrist.

'I'm sorry, Ananya,' he whispered as he looked down at me. 'For being such a dud about this.'

'A dud? I think you mean a complete dickhead ... douchebag, maybe, or... oooh I know,' I said, enjoying the proximity between our faces. 'A dildo.'

He watched me for a few seconds, amused, before bending down to shut me up.

When his lips met mine, they didn't carry the same urgency they had from the night of the Best Man reception. They were patient and leisurely, as if they knew they had all the time in the world to be pressed against mine.

If my life was a romcom, I'd be safe in the knowledge that a happily ever after awaited me after the turn of this page. I would open my heart to this man, love him, be loved by him, maybe pass on that love to a couple of young ones, grow old with him and spend my life knowing I couldn't have asked for more. But this isn't that kind of a story.

This is a story about a bet.

'Does this mean I won?' I asked, and he threw his head back in laughter.

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Radhika Agrawal is a journalist and writes for *Condé Nast India* and *Grazia India*. Her love for romance as a genre comes from the innumerable Meg Cabots and Sophie Kinsellas she devoured as a teenager, as well as the epic love story of her own parents. She lives, dreams and writes love stories with a vengeance and believes that she can help romance get the respect and attention it deserves as a genre.

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